Tipsy

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48246760.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Hurt/Comfort, Fluff and Angst, Romance, Eventual Smut, Slow Burn, First Time, Self-Worth Issues, Lesbian Character, Friendship/Love, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Developing Relationship, Cunnilingus, Vaginal Fingering, Bipolar Disorder, Friends to Lovers, Arguing, Unhealthy Coping Mechanisms, Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Drunk Sex, Mental Health Issues

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by LonelyBoa

Summary

If I never say a word, does it make it less true?

After the war, Catra and Adora navigate the repair of a broken world and a deeper intimacy with each other. Internalized anger towards herself makes Catra take three steps back for every step forward.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter One

Chapter Summary

> Yet another night Catra spends waiting while Adora is off taking care of the world. While adjusting to her new life on Bright Moon, the lovely surprise of an early return from the hero takes the edge off.

A thick humid breeze blew, gently blowing through her shortened hair as her yellow and blue eyes watched the deep greens of the forest in the distance. While she missed her heavy locks, it did give a sense of freedom and weight lifted from her. Her lean stance dramatically framed by a dark red robe that fluttered against the low winds.

The grand stone balcony that Catra stood on as she overlooked the vast beauty of Bright Moon's night seemed to be exactly what she had needed to bring herself back down from another nightmare that had torn its way through her psyche.

She had tried to take up healthier alternatives to venting her anger and fears. The former Horde Captain had found that keeping herself busy seemed to work for a short time, before she would work herself to exhaustion. Mentally and physically running herself until there was nothing left. Her new friends had noticed and intervened, kindly offered alternatives like shopping or a group sleepover like old times.

While the gesture was nice, Catra would often find herself scowling at the thought of the social interactions before she could stop herself.

She *did* appreciate all of them. Their compassion and willingness to accept her after all she had done in an effort to tear the world apart. Truthfully the last thing she wanted when she was in this

type of mood was to be surrounded by people who she could offend with a simple change of mood or an off handed rude comment.

She clasped her hands together, the height of the phenomenal palace holding her high above everything in the kingdom. She bowed her head as she noiselessly weaved the sharp black nails into each other as if she were about to pray. If she 'had' been the type to pray, she would pray to be a different person. Anyone else.

But she wasn't. All she could do to calm her heart was come out onto the quiet balcony and listen to the distant rush of water falls and late night vendors from the streets below close shop and turn out candle lights. Normally the quiet was an antagonist, a free platform for her own mind to remind her of every abuse she endured and every poor decision she made with no other input to pull her out of the tar pit of self deprecation. After a few sleepless nights while she had first started adjusting to Bright Moon and Glimmer the Overbearing Hostess, she found solace in it. She had actually resisted sleep to such a degree where she had accidentally fallen asleep on the cool stone. The scenery was certainly the polar opposite of the Fright Zone. The once hellish landscape draped in reds and blacks were now replaced with calming colors and not one alarm within earshot.

She could feel sleep begin to coax her like a warm blanket, attempting to pull her back to her room. This part of her day was what she looked forward to. Not the most, but it was up there. Far and away, Adora was what she looked forward to everyday. Just like before. If she couldn't be better for herself, she knew she could at least try to be better for the person she loved more than anything.

While she never considered herself a lucky person by any means, she must have had some kind of pull with the gods to find her way back. It was like the words tripped over themselves when she

tried to be honest and tell her best friend how grateful she was everyday to be not only in her life, but have the once muddied feelings reciprocated. Every time they had a serious moment where Catra tried, Adora would just smile sweetly, maybe with a soft touch of her hand.

"You don't need to tell me, I already know."

She would assure softly.

There wasn't a doubt in her mind that she didn't know. The soft brush of their lips against each other had become a more common occurrence. Twice now they had fallen asleep in eachothers arms, a memory that made her heart beat rapidly. It was like before at yet, entirely new. She just knew that Adora deserved the best and while she couldn't promise that she could give her that, she would try everyday to do just that.

"Hey," a voice quietly greeted as the large window panes of the balcony doors pushed open slightly to allow Adora's sturdy frame to pass through. Catra's face lit up as she pulled herself upright, she brushed her feeling's of being tired behind her as she took a couple of excited steps toward her.

"Hey Adora" she breathed into her as their bodies met in an embrace. She had been gone for nearly a week for a peacekeeping meeting with Mermista. Having her back before scheduled was enough to keep her energized for the rest of the week. She could feel Adora's hand gently hold the back of her tightly, as if the two would melt together right there.

"I thought you were out for the rest of the week?" Catra asked, unable to drop the smile from her face fast enough. As they pulled apart, Adora's hands traveled down her arms to her hands to link them together.

"We were but what can I say? I'm a hell of a negotiator" the blonde smirked, finally causing her counterpart to scoff and roll

her eyes. Adora gave her a small peck on her cheek, causing Catra to catch her and pull her back into a deeper kiss.

"I guess I did miss you a little" Catra admitted with sarcasm lining her comment. Her frame now positioned against the strong railing with Adora keeping her pinned carefully against it. "I was going to have your favorite dinner ready for you when you got back".

Adora leaned into her more, her breath wisping against Catra's neck. Her strong arms on either side of Catra made her feel shielded from the entire world.

"I like this option better" she chuckled as she planted her lips onto her exposed neck. The intimacy, while certainly wanted, made Catra nervous. Never one to avoid a challenge, she wanted to quip something back to make Adora blush but trying to convey her feelings felt nearly impossible. She decided the best option for now was to sink into the moment together, allowing the kisses to trail back up to her mouth before the sound of someone's throat clearing pulled Adora's attention to her dismay.

"Right, didn't mean to interrupt" Glimmer's voice rang while clearing her throat, trying not to sound uncomfortable. "The night guards from the hall said they had seen you return. Mind if we do a quick debrief?" she asked, focusing her query towards Adora.

"Don't you ever knock?" Catra asked, her expression now flat. Glimmer grimaced.

"I- it's just I figured since I was still up and you-". Watching Glimmer shift from the role of proper Queen to a stammering mess looking to justify her actions was one of the more amusing things Catra liked to busy herself with. Adora's feet tapped against the shale floor as she moved towards Glimmer.

"Sure, shouldn't take long" she allowed, trying to spare her any more bereavement from Catra. She offered a longing but understanding nod as she let her hand trail and pull from hers. Duty calls and it was something they knew would be a constant in

their lives. Especially with She-Ra continuing to be the face of bringing magic back to the world. The expression in the dim light of the night made Catra confident that Adora would have stayed with her forever wherever she was if circumstances allowed it.

The two stepped out, softly beginning their updates as they walked past a semi-sleeping Melog to make their exit from the heavily accented door to the guest room Catra had been staying in for an extended period.

A bleary, glowing eyed Melog looked at the open patio door to Catra now on her own.

"Some guard dog you are" she quipped, eliciting a low chirrup as the creature stretched its large body and curled back into itself on the floor.

Catra exhaled, deciding it was time to at least allow herself to relax. Her always bare feet crossed the threshold to enter the room, taking care to close and latch it before she let the sheer drapes fall in front of it. She hadn't planned to stay in the palace long- or at all in fact. Immediately following their victory over Horde Prime and stopping the weapon, everyone was in agreement that there was much work to be done. Thankfully not the type of work that required Adora to do it alone, as she definitely would have tried.

They were to bring peace and magic back to their realm. Helping and repairing cities and villages along the way which offered Catra a feeling of redemption. Every instance of destruction that she had directly played a part in offered the chance to make amends, although she didn't feel she could ever undo the terror she had caused to the world. Her sins could never be washed clean entirely and it was something she had accepted.

It brought her more pain and fear than she had anticipated at first, seeing the faces of the men, women, and children whose

lives and loved ones the Horde had ripped from them- at her command- made her physically ill. She had loathed how Shadow Weaver made her feel small and helpless as a child yet there she was, inflicting the same sadism on perfect strangers in the name of what?

To prove herself?

To finally show everyone that she wasn't just a pathetic runner up to the perfect poster child Adora?

Realizing she was about to spiral herself, she put a halt to her train of thought. Electing to grab a small treat from the inside of her night stand to toss down to Melog, who peered their eyes open at the familiar sound of the well-made drawers being open. Greedily accepting the treat and returning to slumber, Catra ran the backs of her fingers over the top Melog's head.

As she straightened herself back up, she pulled at the tie and then the sleeves to loosen her red and black robe from her body. She shrugged herself out of the opening, leaving it on the floor and remaining in the comfort of her undergarments. It was similar to how she felt in the faces of the princesses and at the questioning expressions of the civilians as some recalled exactly who she was.

She felt exposed. As if they all saw the visage of the fraud she truly was.

Before she could crumple to the jeers and whisper of others, Adora was always there to vouch for her.

"She's here to help" she would insist with a stern tone in her voice that no one would question. It was a complex feeling, Catra wanted to argue that she didn't need her to step in but they both knew in the moment where her words failed, she needed the extra push back onto her feet. In her mind she had thought if she could turn everything around, then it could be possible for anyone. The gleam in Adora's eyes every time she offered reassurance was strong enough for Catra to believe it herself and soon be able to mirror those exact words without Adora there.

"I'm just here to help."

"I'm here to help."

"I want to help."

The more she said these words, the more she believed them.

Once she deposited her clothing from the day into her laundry bin, she let herself fall onto the mattress as she fanned her arms out. She looked at the canopy top and imagined how odd this bed would have looked back in the Fright Zone. If this were the place she and Adora had grown together, circumstances would have been different.

For better or worse, Catra was thankful in some twisted way that things played out the way they did. Had anything changed, maybe she would have never met Adora, never had the chance to save Sparkles, or they just wouldn't grow into the people they were today.

Now that she had returned to the bed, she was reminded of why she lay awake at such a late hour to begin with.

The nightmare.

Many of her nightmares were stamped with the vicious words of Shadow Weaver, Double Trouble, or countless others who were capable of twisting the knife in her wounds without even the hint of trying. This nightmare was an oddity though. In the others there was intentional anguish and pain, sometimes coupled with the life-like sounds of flames crackling around them or the screaming of figures she couldn't see. No, this one was just real enough to make her nervous to try to sleep again.

It had started so serene, deceptively so. She and Adora had their own home where everything was perfect and the two could finally find peace. As the pace of the dream sped forward, she dream Adora had to go off once more and Catra was left waiting. And waiting.

And waiting.

Her heart had responded physiologically to the panic, racing for each passing hour in the dream where Adora did not return. Before she had wretched from the dream, she had reacted as she would in real life. Debating to go out and search to see if she had been injured or stay put in case she finally made her way back to her. Everything seemed like the incorrect move and she felt no sense of control as their once blue skies turned a sickly dripping red.

A final thought had crossed her mind in the slumber. Perhaps Adora hadn't been held up in some way. A form of intentional escape where she finally severed herself from Catra without word and never planned to come back. That thought was enough to make Catra sharply inhale and snap from her sleep, trying to

catch her breath. Once she steadied herself, noting that she was still in Bright Moon and that Adora *would* be back, the nagging picked at her still because Adora had still been gone at that point. Melog had already pounced to her bedside, nudging her and licking her arm to bring her consciousness back to a grounded reality before she was able to clothe herself and step out for a breath of fresh air.

She pulled her slender legs up onto the bed to align herself with her side, holding out her hand to brush against the other side where Adora would lie with her.

How long would it be before Adora grew tired of catering to Catra's needs of validation?

She furrowed her brow to pull her monochrome eyes shut as she balled up her fist. If she could just get out of this cycle of her own mind tearing her down, she was sure she could be the kind of person Adora deserved. The kind of person she wanted herself to be.

At some point in the calm of the night Catra had managed to give into sleep. The constant counting of moments for Adora to return turned repetitive enough to let her drift off before she could catch her door silently open once more and allow Adora to enter.

She stood for a moment, in the glow of the room from the moon's beams extending across the room and a small section of the bed that held the most beautiful woman she had ever seen. She had missed her while she was away. Everytime she had left it felt like a piece of her was being torn out and left behind for when she returned to pick up the pieces.

Adora hated the possibility that her duties still made Catra feel like she wasn't a priority in her life. Her blue eyes looked over at a now sprawled out Melog, content and purring in their spot on the floor. She reached a hand down to release each boot from her

foot then pulled herself out of her red jacket before pulling her long sleeve over her head. After she had disrobed, she pulled the billow blanket back to see Catra’s hand extended over to her side, grasping for a person who had not yet arrived.

Her slow movements were still enough to wake the already sleeping woman who accepted the addition of her body to the bed in a drowsy, agreeable state . Adora slid under her arm and let the comforter cover them together.

Catra’s warmth spread around her as she held her from behind. Adora swiftly pulled her hand from her mid-torso and back up to pull the former soldier's mouth closer to place a kiss on it before returning it to its place around her midsection.

“I missed you” her voice whispered, a statement only for Catra. The bare arm around her tightened slightly.

“Missed you too” Catra responded, working to not sound like she had just been sleeping.

Chapter Two

Chapter Summary

> Adora mentions plans with friends to her reluctant girlfriend. Catra wants to make a good impression on the night out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The warmth of the morning light was nearly enough to coax Catra out of bed if not for who was laying next to her. She had a fleeting thought of getting up, getting dressed and looking put together for Adora's return home but they both would find humor in that. As much as she cared for her, that was not who she was. She also wanted to steal these moments and live in them forever. Once she was awake and lost any concern for allowing Adora to catch up on her rest, she gently rested her head just behind the crook of her neck before nuzzling deeper into her and resting her lips in scatter points down its length.

"That tickles" Adora groaned in what could have been read as annoyance if it weren't for the smile that grew across her face. Catra took advantage of the new angle as Adora turned slightly to peer over at her in the orange glow of the room.

"Sounds like a you problem".

Adora reached around to the back of Catra's head to pull her into a deep kiss. Different from the night previously, as if she were re-staking her claim to her home. Catra leaned in eagerly, as they entwined and familiarized themselves with each other yet again. Instinctually she found herself climbing on top of Adora in the heat of the exchanges, now straddling herself above her as deeper, more passionate kisses bloomed. While her mouth was busy, she moved her hands down the uncovered skin she rested on, feeling the toned muscle of her lover's abdominals under her.

The low flame within her felt ignited, alive.

From her vantage point and the small amount of clothing between the two, the simple movement of her wandering hands found their way from Adora's neck and jaw, down to her chest as her black nails played with the coverings of her breasts. The bolder movements didn't go unnoticed, prompting Adora to lean slightly back to check in on Catra's facial expression. Seeing that she had yet to yield her grasp and her breathing had begun to deepen, Adora felt the need to intervene against her own best interests.

"Are you sure?" she questioned, laying prone with her golden hair tousled under her.

Catra pretended as if she hadn't heard her before Adora's movements halted all together to make her face the question. "Sure about what?" she played the part of ignorance, trying to rub the flat part of her palm down Adora's collarbone as she lay prone.

"I just mean I don't want you to feel like we have to just because I'm back".

The sentiment was ridiculous. So much so that it almost made Catra laugh in her face. Here was this all powerful being, literal She-Ra embodied beneath her that she was trying to seduce and she was questioning her?

Sure they had experimented a little in the bedroom but it wasn't as if they had unlimited time alone. The dynamic between the two had changed so much over the years that it felt unspoken that they would find themselves along the way. Adora had insisted that open communication was the key, a planned out battle strategy that made Catra want to gag.

"I thought this was a pretty clear signal I was sending" her glowing eyes flashed up to stare into Adora's. That damned smirk showed itself again.

“Yeah I- believe me I’m good with this. I just wanted to check.” she put her hand over the tanned fingers that traced her skin, convincing it to stop and let Catra focus. Catra let one shoulder slump, feeling somewhat deflated.

“Look if you’re not into it then just say that " Catra demanded, her previous yearning expression wiped from her sharp face while her arms pulled back to her sides. Adora, realizing her mistake, tried to move a hand onto one of Catra’s thighs to offer assurance.

“No that’s not it, I’ve missed you more than anything. I didn’t want you to feel pressured…” Adora struggled to find what she wanted to say, already anticipating an outburst from her long time friend.

“Pressured? From who? You?” Catra mocked “Please, I would be the one dragging poor She- Ra’s squeaky clean reputation through the mud if they found out I was corrupting you like this.” She felt a sense of power in teasing Adora, who looked relieved with this outcome.

“Drag away” she challenged, causing Catra to scoff and tip herself off of Adora’s side to lie next to her. Using her forearms to prop herself up, the pair looked at eachother. Adora brought her hand up to cup the side of Catra’s face while she traced her cheek with her thumb. Like a magnet, Catra felt herself sink into the touch and almost emit a low rumble of a purr from within her.

“What kind of stuff do you have going today?” curiosity lacing normal scratch of Catra’s voice. Adora sighed but kept her positive disposition adjusted on her face.

“Glimmer and Bow wanted to get dinner and maybe do some shopping later” she informed. Catra stretched before grabbing a bundle of the blankets to recover herself.

“Cool, have fun with all that” she offered in a faux chippered spirit. She could feel the weight of Adora shift on the bed as she

stood up. Catra pulled the plush comforter up to her neck, effectively caccooning herself in.

“Glad you think so, cause we’re both invited”.

Blue and yellow eyes popped open with a sneer pulling at her upper lip.

“But-”

“Just a couple hours, you like them. It’ll go by quick” Adora assured, pulling her long hair up into a ponytail and beginning to adjust her signature bump atop her head.

“I hung out with Sparkles while you were gone,” Catra argued. She was right in the fact that she didn’t dislike Glimmer, but she could only handle so much of her trying to mother their friend group before she found herself involuntarily rolling her eyes.

Adora pulled loose strands of blonde hair behind her ears before scanning the room for her clothes she had changed out of the night before. “Yeah she mentioned that, she said you left in the middle of game night without saying goodbye to anyone”.

Catra had forgotten entirely about game night at Spinerella and Netossa’s. She wasn’t having a bad time, she actually enjoyed being a little competitive with the princesses in some board and card games during the evening. It was just so many guests crowded and talking that drained her quickly where she had decided to call it a night. She had even been close to winning some of the games before she left.

“They were talking to people, I didn’t want to interrupt!” she defended. Adora chuckled as she dressed herself, peeking over and shaking her head at a fully awakened Melog who was

patiently waiting to see who would get ready first to take them outside.

"Right, well it'll just be some eating and the four of us so no pressure" she assured. Patting her leg and giving a pitched whistle to call Melog over, she walked for the door. "I think it's a nice place too so feel free to wear that suit again" her voice asked, hopeful. Catra shot one last look at the door as it opened and Melog ran out with Adora pacing behind him.

"Love you" Catra called out flatly.

"I love you, I'll see you tonight" she responded cheerfully.

Catra didn't move, letting herself plunge deeper into the comforting embrace of her thick blanket. Absolutely superior in comfort to anything she had in the Fright Zone or Horde Prime's ship. By this point, she was surprised she even had those thoughts. She was finally able to admit to herself that things were better outside of the Horde. Food was better outside of the Horde. People especially, were better outside of the Horde. She had gotten into an argument with Lonnie a long time ago about the concept of nature versus nurture.

Were people failures or successful due to their upbringing or the biology within them?

Does that change the course of one being good or bad?

At the time of these questions, Catra had just told Lonnie to shut up or they would be given extra cleaning duties and it would be her fault but she had just been a teenager when it had come up. She hadn't even been asking Catra the question, it was one of their training instructors as she was working to become stronger

and faster but wondered if one's own genetics could play a part. It really wasn't a question Catra deemed important and quickly worked to embarrass her to try and shut it down before it wasted more of their training time.

Now that she was actually old enough to ponder a novel idea like that, it bothered her incessantly. She had always been so confident that her choices were her own that she would act on freely no matter how wreckless. But she and Adora had been raised together, in the same place, with the same people. So why had she known the answers or instantly chosen the path of righteousness even when she was unsure where it led?

He made her feel foolish for not leaving with her when she first had the chance. Perfuma had told her some things were choices that she had to make on her own. She was always one to offer advice that Catra never asked for in the first place. Maybe it was her genetics, but if that were so she would have certainly been unredeemable until her last breath. Catra would forever be grateful that was not the case. If she had left only because of Adora's insistence, she would have resented her more for being her unwavering 'sidekick' who followed her every order and couldn't stand on her own. That feeling of total accomplishment was never achieved though, she would never have been enough for Shadow Weaver or herself. Mistakes had to be made so she could learn from them, as much as she hated how that sounded.

"... *but your heart's never been in it"* Double Trouble's words echoed in her mind.

Catra had plenty of time to get ready but decided to start with a shower in her private bathroom. The rush of water looked like a smaller version of the vast waterfalls outside of the kingdom. The streams of water quickly began eliciting steam that floated through the room. The luxury of the bathroom alone was enough

to make her feel like a whole new person. The type of person who had skin care routines and floral scented concoctions to make her hair extra voluminous.

Once she had finished lathering and rinsing, she thought of what she should wear and if she should get a small gift for Adora before they went out. It was humorous to her that these were the things she busied her mind with now, when just a short period ago it was more pressing matters of obliterating the rebellion. Now she wondered what color she should wear on her night out.

She grabbed a heavy towel, patting the sides of her face and neck to catch stray droplets of water that slid down from her shortcut before she wrapped the towel around her midsection. Keeping her feet planted on the surfaces of the mats to prevent herself from slipping, she avoided the mirror. Certainly wanting to look good for her date, she just felt a slight aversion to staring at herself in the reflective surface.

To relieve herself from the humidity of the bathroom, she stepped back into the cool blast of air in the bedroom. Catra had already made the decision that she wanted to look good enough to tease Adora. She wasn't self-conscious about her looks by any means. Things like that were easy to alter on a whim and she knew Adora loved her. It was everything beneath that decorated surface. The attitude, personality, and rash decisions that made her who she was that she was unable to make-up into whatever she wanted for any occasion.

That kind of change was a painfully slow one that had many steps backward.

She could have one nearly perfect day only to linger on the words or looks of someone else and obsess about that until her mood was in shambles. She shouldn't worry so much. She shouldn't complain so much. Everything was good now and she had no room to complain. Those sentiments only made her feel worse when she did fall into those habits again. It was the concept of

trying to find the healthy balance of moving on while taking care of herself that she felt completely out of her depth with.

She wanted to be strong.

But she wanted the praise and for people to like her.

She wanted to give everything to Adora.

But she didn't want her to feel like she was doing that out of a feeling of obligation.

She wanted so much, but had grown to expect nothing.

She pulled open an off-white drawer to search through for an outfit, deciding that something between casual and dressy would work. If they saw she was trying too hard, they would taunt her for being too cute and make her feel awkward again. Catra pulled articles of clothing from the drawer, settling on a black half jacket over a red tank top with a classy looking pair of straight legged black trousers. She toyed with the idea of wearing her favorite leggings but knew that would draw a comment from Glimmer about restaurant clothing etiquette. At least this was an outfit she was comfortable walking around anywhere in.

Grabbing the towel, she rubbed it against the side of her head to dry the remaining flecks of water from her hair. Managing her mane-like hair was more time consuming before, she always elected to avoid brushing it when possible due to the time it took

but now she loved the ease of being able to just go while allowing it to air dry.

Today felt like it could be the day she shows Adora how far she had come.

Forgoing shoes, rationalizing that her feet were clean and fine for the dining establishment later because she had just washed them today she exited her room down the cathedral ceiling halls of the palace. Soft shades of purple and blue colored the space as she trailed her way down one hall then to a staircase to a nearby servants exit. Catra preferred the use of the less populated halls. Using the main gates and halls always ran the risk of bumping into someone who wanted to spark up some small talk. The choice of taking the smaller routes provided more freedom in a shorter amount of time.

The skinny spiral staircase that snaked its way down near the kitchen was much less notable than the other way but Catra hadn't come to sight see anyway. The plan was to sneak out to town and poke around in the vendor booths before she had to meet back up with the others later. She passed one of the cooks, carrying armfuls of fresh produce into the kitchen. The plump woman called out a pleasantry to Catra who gave a wave back. Some of the staff at this end of the castle had grown familiar with her and her favored escape routes when she was trying to dodge a meeting. Her pace was light and confident as she rounded the corner to exit the wooden door under the stairs she had just descended.

Greeted by the gorgeous atmosphere of Bright Moon's morning she followed the pristine cobblestone path through the side garden and down another flight of stairs with her contrasted eyes set on the gate.

“Hey! Wildcat!”

Her stomach dropped at the notion that her attempt to sneak out had failed, knowing instantly who was calling out to her. She turned her head to look down the length of the garden to a small plaza area where Scorpia was already standing to wave a large claw in her direction. Her short white hair was adorned with a small straw hat and Perfuma remained seated in the grass next to her, tending to the flowers with the

“Oh, hey” she offered, hesitantly shifting her direction between her escape and Scorpia, who was already approaching with hints of green staining small portions of her large red claws.

“Funny seeing you wander through here. Perfuma and I are just getting some weeding done,” her words spilled out of her like an offering Catra had never required her to give. The shorter woman nodded, not enthralled with her regaling tale of pulling plants but was working not to be the rude, careless friend she used to be.

“Yeah, gotta get that done early in the day I guess” Catra added awkwardly. She raised her hand to wave a farewell as she began to step back in the direction she had been headed originally.

“That’s what she said!” her short white hair swayed slightly as she looked back to her friend who was continuing to work. Her freckled face paused for a moment before looking up and cupping her hands around her mouth to call for Scorpia.

“Come take a look! This one is a weed and this one is just a flower that hasn’t bloomed yet!” she projected kindly. Just from her tone, Catra could tell they must have had a similar conversation before. Scorpia moved instantly, leaving the cat-like woman to wonder if she should just take her leave or if they weren’t quite finished with the hostage style small talk she felt like she was stuck in. She decided to approach the pair, both nestled in the soft grass that lined the multicolored flower beds. Scorpia was bent down with full attention paid to the two stem structures she held in her hands. The pile nearest to them looked like clones

of the specimen in her hands that had already been pulled and cast off.

She watched as Scorpia nodded and let out a few sharp inhales of breath as she began to realize how many she had accidentally pulled from their homes. Perfuma was nothing less than helpful as the sound of her voice calmly explaining how to tell major differences droned into the lax air.

While the two prattled, Catra looked at the variety of ferns, flowers, and exotic plants that surrounded them. Each new flower bed had its own ecosystem. The span of colors was never ending and it was clear meticulous care had gone into this area that she had never really bothered to stop and take a closer look at.

"Hey Perfuma " her voice lightly interjected when she found a break in their conversation. Perfuma looked over at her with a smile. That same smile made her wonder if she basked in her discomfort. She knew how to deal with all types of personalities but nobody had ever been as soft as Perfuma. The gentle flow of her words and the advice that she freely gave made Catra think she had ulterior motives in the beginning. But it wasn't an act, it was just who she was. Past their first altercation, she had done well in never making Catra feel judged, even if she felt foolish for asking what felt like basic questions about how to manage her emotions and better herself.

Seeing that she had her attention she continued, "If I wanted to buy something for a person. What should I get?".

Perfuma brushed her long blonde waves behind her ear. Even with minimal context, she seemed to understand what Catra was asking.

"Something…do you mean a flower or plant?" her voice asked in its natural melody.

“Either? I just don’t want to get her something that’s just going to die.”

Perfuma stood, brushing her lengthy skirt free from its wrinkles. She put a tanned, dainty finger to her chin as she hummed curiously while scanning the nearby sections of garden.

“Were you thinking of a certain color?” she looked down at Catra with her eyebrows slightly raised. Now her embarrassment from asking the question had channeled itself into embarrassment that she hadn’t thought that far ahead.

“I don’t know, yellow?” she crossed her arms, noticing her voice was becoming a little harsher than she meant it. She looked around, pretending to search for a reference as she breathed to release some stress. Perfuma was a friend, she would never tease her about a gesture like this. She had been the one to encourage her to be more open with Adora about how she was feeling. She nodded excitedly, fully agreeing with her color choice.

“I think I have just the thing” she chirped as she led her past several large boulders that naturally bisected the garden’s path. She took the right side, taking a trailing Catra slightly upward on a low incline before stepping off of the dirt path to smaller landscaping beds surrounded by less man made materials. The displays were not as grand as the main ones that boasted their bounty in the center of the plaza, but they still rivaled in beauty. The scent of nearby lavender and spruce trees in the distance tangled themselves in an aroma around her as she followed her floral guide.

They stopped just before a small, intimate display with large shaded leaves on one side. Closer to the inside of the area. Perfuma gave a small twist of her wrist, sending one of the flowers to grow slightly longer and bring it to Catra’s attention. A large yellow flower with a billowy circular shape stood proudly. Its

ruffles appeared to be jammed into the stem while its leaves supported its image with a healthy deep green contrast.

“Peonies are a classic for sure. Not too formal, not too cliche. But it is rare to find them in yellow” Perfuma gushed, clasping her hands together as she admired her own handiwork. Catra agreed it was perfect, beautiful in fact.

“They look great, but if yellow is hard to find do you think the merchant in town is going to have a bouquet?” she inquired. Perfuma immediately shook her head.

“When I say rare, I mean *rare* . Usually you’ll find these in pink, white, or maybe a red?” she offered. Catra shook her head.

Adora was light in the dark. She was the sunshine after a wicked storm. The symbol of hope for an entire world almost consumed by darkness and destruction. Before she even opened her eyes in the morning, the soft glow that shined through her eyelids reminded her of the warmth Adora made her feel whenever she was around her. Just like her smooth golden hair that shined as they ran together, yellow was just who she was.

She wouldn’t ask Perfuma to cut from her own garden though. It felt demanding. She considered just going with another flower.

“What if I get one of those fluffy yellow ones?” Catra asked, poorly describing a flower she had no idea the name of. Perfume looked back to the cluster surrounding the now taller flower. At her gaze and the barely there movement of her fingers, several more grew up to match the height of the taller flower.

“You know there is a deeper meaning to types and colors of flowers, right?”.

Catra looked at her friend dumbfounded. Unsure of what she was going on about this time.

“Like…roses are romantic?” she asked, trying to sound like she had some kind of an inkling of what she was referring to. Her

concentrated eyes went back to the peonies, seeing the spheres move together as if they were swaying in a dance.

“Sort of. A language. If you’re thinking of someone, you might get them pansies. Hydrangeas used to be a common way to show someone if you were thankful…” once the stems had grown long enough Perfuma reached her arm to grasp them, taking her other hand to carefully cut them in a quick motion. “I think you were right to choose yellow peonies. You’ve come a long way.”

The ears on Catra’s head dipped slightly, her face looking at the bundle of florals in Perfuma’s hand then back to her face. For someone so at ease, Catra felt like she was always the one to cut her deepest without trying. Somehow doing it with the ammunition of kind words. Her hands brushed Perfuma’s as she accepted the bouquet.

“...what do yellow peonies mean?” she asked, unable to leave the mystery alone. Perfuma smiled sweetly, tilting her head. As she carefully lifted them hem of her dress as she walked back towards where Scropia had returned to weeding, she looked back to answer:

“Fresh starts”.

Chapter End Notes

Next chapter is going to be a little more spicy. I used to write on another fanfiction site so I'm getting used to ao3 now.

Chapter Three

Chapter Summary

Double Date night for the Best Friend Squad keeps the former Horde cadets pretty busy.

Chapter Notes

Just a heads up that we are venturing into smut territory.

Catra stood outside the restaurant, people watching as the pedestrians of Bright Moon continued on in a flow with their evening plans. In her hands was the bouquet from earlier. She had done some hunting to find suitable wrapping and red ribbon to present it. All that was left now was to wait for her friends to arrive outside of the address Glimmer had a footman give her earlier.

Blossoms looked like that kind of place that Glimmer would frequent. The outside was slightly more chic than the other shops on the street with glowing sconces illuminating the entrance doors. There were many options for outdoor, indoor, and from what she could tell from the first level, some rooftop seating as well. The smells were heavily cut off by the closed doors. Even through the large barriers, the mouthwatering scent of savory meat was enough to keep Catra occupied with waiting.

"Hey you!" Adora's voice greeted, already close enough to lean into Catra in a side embrace. Her heart fluttered at nearly being snuck up on and to have Adora in her arms again.

As they pulled apart, she found her eyes wandering down then back up at the white lace sundress that Adora was wearing. It showed off her perfectly toned legs, easily on display above the muted gold flats on her feet. The dresses design had a neck line just low enough to show a hint of her cleavage. It took all of her situational awareness to remember that Bow and Glimmer were

not only there, but mere steps behind Adora. Thankfully they didn’t seem to have noticed the distractions that were pawing at Catra.

“You look great” she breathed, suddenly at a loss for any more impressive adjectives. Adora immediately swooned over the flowers, stealing a quick inhale of their scent before looking back up to Catra. Seeing her leaned over with her cool eyes seering into hers, she wished they could leave right then and there.

“Beautiful flowers, Catra " Glimmer complimented, Catra caught a quick glimpse she pointed at Bow before returning to her regal demeanor. Catra looked around to see if she still had any security guards that had tagged along with her. Thankfully, she saw no out of place looking cloaked and partially armored men with their ever stocky stances and faces barricaded behind their helmets as they performed their duty of protecting the Queen that didn’t need it.

Seeing Glimmer's disdain of their never ending presence during special occasions or trips to more densely populated areas made Catra chortle, trying to play a little bit nicer by not ribbing her about it more. Although Glimmer had grown into a mature young lady fit to lead the people of Bright Moon, snippets of the same stubborn child that just wanted to let loose peaked through. She could identify with her, she just wanted to make people proud deep down. Where Glimmer had grown in a conducive environment for healthy relationships and management of her emotions, Catra had lacked those accommodations.

The sturdy doors smoothly swung open. A taller hostess dressed in all black greeted them while instructing other waiters in similar dress to hold the doors open.

“My Queen, we are so honored to have you as our guest tonight. We have your party’s table ready right this way” she motioned with her arms, continuing to act in her professional manner. If

Glimmer was embarrassed by the overdone greeting, she didn't show it. She thanked the staff before following inside.

The group of four was led past the several dark mahogany tables with patrons already enjoying their night with each other as staff would move swiftly around them to take care of their needs. The hostess led them past a section of booths to their right, many of the eyes that studied them in the low light as they went past. They seemed to widen at the image of the Queen and then She-Ra walking past them during dinner time. Glimmer offered small nods of recognition and Adora turned to make sure Catra was still with the group, offering her slightly raised hand for Catra to accept.

She grasped into her hand before they entered one more doorway. A small courtyard with a stunning dark wooden lattice overhang offered a more intimate place for them to enjoy their meals. Bow pulled a chair out for Glimmer as Adora and Catra released their hands to take their seats at the corners adjacent from each other. Bow, who opted for a dressier dark magenta suit with more subtle midriff showing seated himself next to Adora with Glimmer between himself and Catra.

The soft string music that played on the inside of the lobby and low voices of other tables was a far enough distance to not be overwhelming but low enough to make Catra's heart thud harder. The fancy outfits, casual boring conversation made her nervous that she would fail to mirror the behavior. Electing to just get through the dinner without appearing to try too hard would be the default she decided to lean on.

"What do you think you're going to get?" Adora asked from her side. Always the planner. Catra gave a shrug to appear indifferent, as if her stomach wasn't trying itself in knots.

"Maybe the steak? Or fish" she questioned herself, peering at the tall rectangular menu. The font was in an italicized cursive,

scrawled in tiny letters across the middle of the thick parchment. Everything about the place screamed “upper class”.

“Catra you have to try the trofie al pesto, it’s to die for” Glimmer interjected. Before settling a hand back over her menu she continued; “How is your search for an apartment going?”.

Catra stopped her eyes from scanning the listing of food in front of her, drawing up to Glimmer's eyes. She now remembered that she had told her about her intentions for finding her own place at some point. Wishing she hadn’t said anything because it was taking her longer than she anticipated. She tightened her mouth as she looked down and back to her.

“Still on the lookout for just the right place”.

Originally she didn’t care if the place even had four walls or heat. Catra just wanted out of the watchful eye of the palace, as lovely and luxurious as it was to stay there as the Queen’s friend; it was still a place of unspoken restrictions. Several of the princesses during game night, Glimmer brought the topic up in front of the group who had all weighed in that she had to find a place that she loved and could visualize herself in so she would be happy. She acted like their advice was a little childish, it was only a place to stay but as time went on, she found herself being more selective with selecting.

"I'm happy for you to stay at the castle as long as you'd like. You are always welcome" Glimmer said sweetly.

Catra was selective. She wanted a back yard. She wanted somewhere that had big windows to let the sun in, enough for Melog to bask in the sunbeams and Adora to have enough space to complete her work outs. Something that needed a little fixing up was fine. She wanted enough room to have a small kitchen table that she pictured the two eating evening dinners at. Catra

surprised herself with all these wishes she didn't realize she had. It made turning some of the properties down easier.

Before Glimmer could probe more, the waitress appeared back at Glimmer's side. In her hands she held a long necked wine bottle, the label worn and in another language.

"Whenever you are ready, we have a great selection tonight. Smoked salmon and herb roasted lamb are the chef's specialties tonight" she presented the deep shaded red in front of herself carefully with two hands, "this is a lovely pairing with either option. Compliments of the owner for leading us to victory and keeping Bright Moon safe".

The table was smiling all around, thanking her for the beverage. Along with another waiter with a towel resting on his arm, she took each of their stemmed wine glasses to fill an amount small enough for a sample tasting. Glimmer expertly gave a small swirl of her glass before smelling, allowing the aroma to permanent the space around her and breath. Bow continued to overlook the menu, asking the waiter questions about what ingredients were in a specific dish. Catra looked at her glass. She had never been much of a wine drinker.

Her fingers clasp around the base of the glass, black nails clinking slightly as she lifted it to her mouth for a sip. The taste was some sort of puckery fruit, surprising her and sending her back for another sip that turned into her finishing the drink.

"Pretty good?" Adora asked, smiling and raising an eyebrow. Catra nodded while the hostess quickly filled her glass slightly more this time. Adora decided on her meal and took a sip of her own wine. Instantly nodding in agreement with Catra.

"It's vintage" the waiter said, producing a small receptacle of ice to place the bottle in from the cart behind him. Catra nodded as if that meant anything to her.

Cuisine was ordered and they all settled into more comfortable conversation. A small bread basket was brought out while Bow elaborated on the new tech he and Entrapa had been working on specifically for taking out certain Horde bots that remained in sections of the land, one shot would degrade the machines faster and leave the area without the blemish of war or the danger of one detonating on the innocent.

"At least a lot of the work is clean up related" Adora commented, thankful that there wasn't an overarching threat of someone trying to hunt or destroy them. Just the remains of what used to be. Catra finished her glass once more and wondered if she should eat a slice of bread from the fresh basket that had been brought out. While she listened to Adora recount her last trip, the waiter had stealthily refilled her wine again.

"The service here is excellent," Catra noted, unsure why she decided to announce that to the entire table. Glimmer nodded, eyeing her glass.

"My mother and I used to come here" her face reflecting whatever memory she was thinking fondly.

"Oh yeah, she always liked to get the penne dish. What was the name of it? I don't think they serve it anymore…" Bow's voice trailed off as he rambled in remembrance with Glimmer. Catra snuck a look to Adora at the mention of the late Queen Angella. Catching the small sign of a frown form, Catra covered her hand over Adora's and gave a small tap. She knew that Adora grappled with the feelings of her involvement with the Queen and felt guilty she had caused such a thing to happen to her friend. A Catra's touch, her hand grasped her fingers inside gratefully.

The food arrived and Catra was feeling much more at ease, which she wasn't sure why as she hadn't been counting the amount of times her wine had been topped off by staff as she chatted with her friends. She freely engaged in each topic, smiled more, and

laughed along with Bow's lame jokes. It had been a long time since she felt so accepted. She asked Glimmer about her gardens and how Entrapta and Scorpia had offered to tend to them as a past time even at her insistence that there were groundskeepers and landscapers on hand for such tasks.

The taste of her dish was phenomenal, just as the hostess had said it paired perfectly with the wine. The feeling of actual enjoyment radiated through her, warming her from the inside out. The bottle was finished off quickly in most part thanks to Catra and partially Adora who only had two more refills past her sampling. The night had begun to wind down, a few couples approaching the table on their way out to greet the Queen and wish her well. Compliments were paid to the chef and staff as Glimmer paid the bill even after the staff insisted her meal would be fully compensated.

"Delicious, thank you guys so much for coming out. It's so nice to have the Best Friend Squad together again like this" Glimmer said fondly. Bow stood, offering his hand to a seated Glimmer for her to stand. The two whispered something Catra had no interest in overhearing. Her senses were being pulled in different directions by nearby flames dancing to accent the atmosphere of the tables. Her attention orbited back to Adora like metal to a magnet. She had been nodding in agreement at the sentiment of having her closest friends together for a night out before she felt Catra's eyes on her. As she looked at Catra, sizing her up. The magicat tilted her head and flashed a dazzling smirk with some of her teeth peering through, a sharper canine tooth making Adora consider her next plan.

"If you're not doing anything the rest of the night-"

"I'm not" Catra cut off Adora's quieted attempted offer in immediate acceptance. She would follow her to the end of the world if she asked. The swirling thoughts in her mind bounced from how lucky she was to be with someone like Adora to being fairly confident she could take her in a fight, even in She-Ra form

if circumstances were fair. She was unable to wipe the dizzy smile from her face as she admired her partner.

After the four of them had left the restaurant, Bow and Glimmer said their goodbyes before heading back to the castle. Adora had told the pair that she and Catra were going to take the opportunity of a beautiful night to go on a walk before heading back. Once they had gone on their way, Adora clasped Catra's hand, surprise pulling her from her intense gaze at a taller tree lining the street that she swore she saw a bird moving in.

The evening began to grow slightly darker. Even though Adora had the more revealing outfit, she felt warm as she released her hand in favor of wrapping it around Catra's waist as they walked side by side. Catra focused on keeping her steps at straight as possible to keep fumbling to a minimum.

"I'm glad you came out tonight" genuine emotion coming from her tone as they passed the muffled nightlife around them. People passed them as the groups of couples or with friends were coming out to enjoy the night and the families with children were headed home to turn in for the night. Catra caught the glimpse of a father holding a smaller child, up well past their bedtime and asleep on his shoulder, as he walked holding hands with the presumed mother. The three of them looked so serene as they wordlessly walked home, both with content smiles as they looked at each other in a way that made Catra feel like it was a secret she hadn't been let in on.

She exhaled, a small chuckle escaping. "Me too. The food was great and I get to see you all dolled up" she poked, making an obvious glance behind Adora at the soft round shape of her bottom in her skirt. She laughed and huffed, fighting the face of shyness that she knew Catra was trying to make her feel.

"Shut up" she laughed.

“Do you want to swing by a pub on the way back?” Catra asked, noticing the many options of bars around them on the main street.

“I think you’re tipsy enough, little girl” Adora teased back as they stopped walking. The golden hero placed herself face to face with Catra, straightening her posture to look slightly down at her. The brunette’s face grimaces before matter of factly attempting to put her date back in her place.

“I have never felt better actually. If you’re worried that you can’t handle a drink with the common folk down here I guess you don’t *have* to have a quick ale with them” she baited with sarcasm dotting her entire argument. She kept her eyes pointed, with no hint of wavering. Adora kept a straight face as she loosened her arm around her.

“An ale does sound like a good nightcap” admission in feigned exasperation. They spontaneously decided to head for the first place they saw, a busy older looking building that seemed to have more business than some of the newer looking establishments.

They worked their way in through the packed door, their frames smaller than those in the doorway which helped make it easier to snake past the droves of people. It was much louder than the street or the previous restaurant, but Catra was well beyond caring. A grin was stuck on Catra’s face as she was led to the bar, before she was even seated Adora motioned to the barkeep to give them two drinks. They settled into the stools, hearing boisterous laughter and hands slamming on tables. This was just rowdy enough to feel more comfortable than the stuffy place they had just eaten dinner at.

The bartender tapped two large steins onto the bartop, foam spilling over the edges greedily as she pushed the drinks towards the women. Adora gave a two finger wave before grasping the handle of her mug and taking a long awaited sip.

“Damn, would have been nice to have one of these over there” Adora joked, eyeing Catra who held her own mug. She didn’t care for ale personally, still it was nice to see Adora unwind a little bit. She hyped herself up and raised her glass to take an identical swig. The hearty froth traveled down with ease.

“I want to go with you next time.” Catra admitted, not caring if she ripped the wheel of conversation to an entirely new course.. Adora peered at her, deciphering what she meant before taking another drink and answering. The sticky countertop becoming more and more tolerable with each passing minute.

“You’re welcome to, you know that”.

Adora’s voice had grown quieter, almost too imperceptible for the area they were in. Catra moved her head from side to side, debating if her words were ones she wanted to say out loud. Her previous drinks giving her this feeling of resistance to anything that could possibly go wrong.

“I just…I don’t want to look like your lost puppy” Catra lifted her hand from the counter top to support the side of her cheek as she leaned into it. She fiddled with the large container holding her ale. Adora finished off her drink, throwing a furrowed brow at her girlfriend in the process.

“What are you talking about?” she probed.

“You know what I’m talking about. Like I can’t stand on my own without you around” she could feel the mood shift in a way she hadn’t meant for it to. It was a self contradiction of wanting to be with her love but feeling the need to prove that she didn’t.

“Nobody thinks that, Catra” Adora assured. “If you want to be there, then be there. There’s some meetings that are closed but you can at least travel with and work on some other projects we’re trying to get started”.

She thought about how easy it would be to stretch this into a new argument. Luckily she was able to recognize that was not what she wanted in the slightest bit tonight. She didn't need to prove herself to anyone…

A female barkeep set two small shot glasses with a clear colored liquid in front of them with tiny thuds. "Courtesy of the gentlemen over there" she motioned to a packed table in the corner.

"Thanks but tha-" Adora couldn't refuse in time before Catra was already tilting her head back and taking the shot. She placed the glass back down and gave the table a nod of approval as she could feel the dulling burn of the alcohol. She loved the way it made her feel. As if she wasn't a prisoner of her own mind. Adora scoffed at her, looking at the drink.

"Don't smell it" Catra interjected, words now painted at the and with a light slur. She was able to see her uncertainty "if you don't want it, I'll take it".

Adora studied the faint freckles of Catra's face for a minute before taking the shot as well.

"You just want to get the leg up on me".

"Only if you ask nicely" Catra countered.

The two didn't stay too late into the night. After a few more rounds and feeling like the world was beginning to glide around her, they decided to call it a night and paid their tab. The castle wasn't a far walk and the two accidently continued to speak and laugh loudly before they adjusted to the quiet sounds of the outside. Loud music and glasses clinking had been replaced with the low chirp of crickets and other nocturnal creatures along the road back to Bright Moon's palace.

Catra rested her head on Adora’s shoulder as they walked.

They had just made it to the outer ends of the courtyard entrance. The beautiful picturesque scene she had seen during the day had become a diametric beauty of itself. The lively shades of green from the day were now shrouded in shades of gray and black as they climbed the stairs to follow the path back up.

“Did you ever think about coming back?” her tone much more fitting her serene surroundings. Adora’s hair swayed as she had not been expecting a question like that.

“Where? To the Horde?” Adora clarified, clearing her throat and feeling the effects of her own inebriation. Catra nodded against her. She was silent for a long time before her answer: “I thought about coming back to you”.

Adora’s blue eye predatorily looked into Catra’s, focused on their spectacular colors before looking at her mouth patiently.

“I wish you had" Catra admitted before pulling herself into a kiss with her arms wrapping themselves behind Adora’s head. She pulled Catra’s jacketed waist closer until they were against each other. Both hungry for more, the low groan she was able to elicit from Adora as her mouth trailed down her towards that tantalizing neck line of her dress. Adora took a gentle hold of Catra’s chin, guiding her back to her mouth again. The scent of alcohol and Adora was sending her on a high she would gladly stay on forever. As Adora’s tongue explored her mouth, she let her hand travel down the back of Adora’s white dress. With one hand she held her back and the other hand began to move under the short hem to feel the soft lace of Adora’s panties.

An immediate response was given as Adora inhaled excitedly at the close contact, before snapping back into a less bold reality.

“Wait, wait. Not here” she said frantically. Catra removed her hands, eager to feel and taste more of her. Adora grabbed Catra’s

hand, leading her into the palace. Either a blur from her slight intoxication or because of her one track mind, she didn’t see a single person in the halls. Adora’s room was in a different wing than Catra’s was, but it was also more private. The moment they had left the main walkway and down enough of the towering halls where they were sure no prying eyes would see, Catra pulled Adora into her for their lips to meet again. They were steps away from the entrance of her bedroom, Adora pinned Catra against the wall to lustfully work her mouth against hers.

She reached over to pull the door handle, opening the door before pulling Catra inside with her. The darkness enveloped them, welcoming them into the ambiguous space. Not bothering to look at the room, which was clearly larger and more open than her own due to the status and length at which Adora had been staying, Catra focused on taking off her own jacket, minimizing the layers between them. She could feel the familiar sensation of the open air again, the archways that displayed the starry sky had led onto her own balcony.

Adora had already kicked off her flats before running her hands down Catra’s light curves. The feeling of want was overwhelming as Adora worked at pulling her partner's shirt over her head, casting it aside on the floor. In the fervor of their movements, now who pushed Adora down onto the large bed. She held her strong position, staying seated while Catra mounted herself on top of her lap while she kept her mouth just a breath away from Adora’s before lowering herself to crash into her lips again.

Now seated above Adora in black bra and trousers that Adora had moved fast working hands towards to begin to play with the waistband before unbuttoning its clasp. Catra placed both hands on the sides of her lover's face, tracing her thumbs downward over cheekbones, her bright eyes closing. The firmness she felt from Adora's hands spontaneously moving and cupping over bra pulled a sigh from deep within her. Her hips slowly began to grind against the support of Adora's thighs under her. The drive to move

faster, harder, was one she willingly gave into as she could feel the heat within her build along with her wetness.

Deciding to take a more domineering route, she pushed Adora down on the bed. Holding her there by pouncing over her and forcfully kissing her as she moved the right strap of her dress off of her shoulder. Adora quickly understood and began loosening herself out of her garment that looked intended for much more innocent activities than being pulled down her body and being left on the floor.

For the first time there was no question, no hesitation. Only a clear understanding of what each wanted and what they were willing to give.

“You’re so beautiful” Catra growled, prowling above her as she moved down her exposed chest. Adora looked ethereal, her fair skin standing out in the night. Goosebumps rose from her skin as it was teased with each touch. The short-haired woman brought her mouth to a rose pink nipple topped on a full, perky breast, causing Adora's breathing to hitch as her body writhed against Catra, tipping her off and allowing them to switch positions. Catra now looked up at her, watching Adora sink down past her hips to pull her slacks off of her lower half.

Left with only her underclothes, she felt Adora’s face settle near her thighs, light kisses on her inner thighs growing hungrier. By this point, Catra was unsure if it was the indulgence from their night out or purely the sublimity of a moment she had waited so long for. Every day dream or fantasy she had about what this moment could entail did not measure up in the slightest bit to the feel of being touched, being *desired* by Adora.

She felt Adora’s fingers gingerly touch more intimate areas, slowly moving her panties to the side before looking up to check on

Catra. Her eyes opened, looking down to give an excited nod before feeling the soothing sensation of Adora’s tongue against her skin. The attention Adora gave pulled whines from her throat, making her clasp her own hand around her mouth while her free one searched the layers of bedspread to link with Adora's.

The feeling changed as Adora alternated with her fingers to make small, swirling motions on and around her clit. Catra looked at Adora with pure trust, feeling eager desire for her to continue her movements.

“Adora…” she moaned. The other taking the sounds of approval as encouragement to keep going and to give Catra what she wanted. She brought her broad shoulder up even with Catra, still keeping her hand lower to tease her opening at the excitement of the magicat’s hips moving in motion with her hand. Adora breathed heavily then covering Catra’s lips with her own before inserting one of her digits into her.

She inhaled, pausing her movements with vulnerability sparking in her yellow and blue eyes. Once she came back to her senses, she nodded with her forehead against Adora’s to allow her to move in and out at a controlled speed. Any thought she had before was completely wiped from existence. The only thing she could focus on was those hands and how much she wanted more of Adora. Her breathing grew heavier, each time she shifted to reciprocate or give Adora attention she was met with a palm caressing the side of her face.

“Shhh, let me take care of you” Adora pleaded. In her lustful and inebriated state, there wasn’t much she could do to argue back. For once, she allowed herself to give in and indulge herself in something a sober Catra wouldn’t have thought she deserved. Between the heat building from between her legs and seeing Adora’s outline between her thighs, the pressure in her core rose and pushed itself to a wonderful burst as her lover worked and praised her.

The gasps and self-muffled groans gave way to a peak of relief, washing over her in waves she could feel wash throughout her entire body. Adora had noticed the change in her reaction, her mouth displaying a grin bright enough to have been seen by even those lacking a strong night vision. She stroked Catras hair, kissing her on the forehead as Catra fluttered her eyes open with a deep breath of satisfaction.

Before Catra could tilt her head to reciprocate, Adora nestled herself against Catra. She pulled her in an embrace with the softness of Adora's bare chest against her back and the fortress of her arms draped around the front.

The late hour and the feeling of coming down from her sensual high made her take pause before she could think of something to say. Any witty response or clunky attempt at a genuine compliment stayed jailed within her as her level of energy waned to a peaceful drift. Catra placed a graceful hand over Adoras forearm that held her, rubbing her thumb in a repetitive motion as she felt her girlfriend’s own muscles relax for the two to finally find rest together.

Chapter Four

Chapter Summary

> After the events of their date, Catra's emotions begin to get the better of her as she doubts where she stands. To bring herself down, she decides to try a healthier way of coping through a walk.

Held in the arms of her lover, Catra reluctantly opened her eyes. Each passing second allowed her to take in more information and recall more of what had happened last night frame by fuzzy frame. The siren call of the warmth almost tempted her to the point of returning back to a restful bliss Adora. However, her own thoughts would simply not allow her the peace. She sighed, feeling the tired pull of exhaustion keep its comfortable tendrils around her before she slid Adora’s bicep off her side to make her silenced escape.

It had never crossed her mind that her first time with Adora would end with her searching for her clothes and sneaking into a walk-of-not-quite-shame before the sun had risen. In her dreams, she would have stayed in bed with Adora for the entire day following.

She slid her pants back on before locating the crumpled shirt by the foot of the marooned plush bedding. Her eyes gave a look back to Adora’s sleeping form, which stirred slightly before settling. Catra stood, pulling her shirt over her arms and head as she walked quietly towards the door. Her stomach was feeling turbulent. Now paired with the complete absence of the wonderful spinning feeling and replaced with the heavy burden and the beginning of a hangover.

The small prick of embarrassment rose within her as she exited the room.

She should be over the moon, ecstatic and feeling closer to Adora than she ever had. Holding her from that emotion was the one thought:

Would this have happened if they hadn't been drinking?

The clear blue shine of the pristine halls felt cold and unforgiving as she made her way back to her own room. She had felt amazing last night, both before and during their time in bed together but for every blurry recollection of the events, she wished she had done better.

She wished she had said something more clever. Wished she had more experience to give Adora, and slightly wished she hadn't drank as much.

Catra pulled her arms in, crossing them and covering the small stripes that lined her arms as she made a direct path to her room, to her dismay, still managing to pass one laundress with a fresh stack of towels for a nearby restroom.

"Good morning Ms. Catra, you're up bright and early" her older voice greeted cheerfully. Catra replied with an exhale and small wave. She was unsure what kind of state her appearance gave off but she imagined she looked similar to how she felt; *messy* . She wanted people to unsee her if it were possible.

Finally making it to her room, she let herself in to be greeted by an excited Melog who rubbed his body along her legs affectionately. She ran her hand down his side, now feeling guilty she had left him on his own for the majority of the day. The tender curiosity on the beast changed into a nervous lick of bluish flames around its mane, notably mirrored Catra.

In the security of her own room, that wasn't really hers in all honesty, she could feel her nerves set in to work against her. Shame? Regret? Not entirely, she enjoyed the events of last night thoroughly and in the moment felt like a better version of herself after she had taken a few sips. There was a small wave of embarrassment, pecking at her for having too much to drink in front of Glimmer and Bow. From her point of view she didn't think she was a stumbling, slurring wreck of a girl but it's hard to say what the Queen of Bright Moon would view her possible discretion as.

Those worries were there but were minimized against what could be going through Adora's mind. She hadn't drunk enough to have blacked out… *right* ?

Catra locked her door, taking extra care to keep any would-be visitors from barging in. She wanted a shower, she wanted to return to bed, to Adora. But the most she could manage with her dry throat and fixed gaze was to melt her way back to her own bed to hide away from this feeling.

Crawling into bed and curling her entire body under the shield of comforters was warm and stuffy, making it an adjustment to breathe. It cured some of the need to stow herself away from the world. She had never been great at processing her own feelings, much less being able to discern what they were.

She held her eyes shut tightly, her face matching in frustration in the dark of her thin layer of protection. The thought that if she actually went ahead and threw up she may find relief from the nagging and sudden churns of her stomach.

That feeling of discomfort was one she wanted to physically expel from her body along with the bile and alcohol that remained in the pit of her stomach. Now that she was curled, she felt the dull pain inside of her where Adora's fingers had once been. She had been

gentle, but the foreign movements and it being her first time made her a little tender from their encounter.

Then from a waterfall of thoughts stemming from that recognition made her understand why she wanted to hide away. She wanted to take care of Adora. Wanted to reciprocate and be the one teasing her in an experienced way when they had finally been allowed to go further with each other. Catra blushed in frustration imagining how stupid she must have looked. She knew what she wanted to do and how she wanted to make her partner feel but she had never had the practice or experience. Adora just wanted to care for her, so she did. No uncertainty or awkward movements of how to make that happen.

When did she learn that?

The thought of Adora having other partners was a petty one, but one that started the inner fire of jealousy within her. She couldn't have blamed her, they were enemies for a long time after she defected. Catra didn't have a stake over her in any capacity, much less a sexual one in the years previous. Still the thought of someone else touching her body, doing the job of making her arch her back or make involuntary sounds was one that pissed Catra off.

It was another instance in the never ending list of Adora just luckily making her way through life. Of *course* people thought she was desirable. She was the most beautiful person in the galaxy. Anyone should count themselves lucky just to have a conversation with her. That's why she found it so hard to picture her laying down with someone else, if that were even the case.

Her time with the Horde and Prime wasn't an entirely lonely experience. It definitely was not a successful one. The only person she had tried to open herself up to in that capacity was Double

Trouble. The recollection shoveled more on her feeling of mounting embarrassment. Thankfully she hadn't *thrown* herself at them, but in a desperate attempt to forge the connection she craved, she had tried to proposition them with her best caricature of confidence.

She cringed at her past self. The memory of the exact words were ones that she thankfully couldn't remember. Clearly and vividly she could remember their response:

"I don't think you mean what you're asking, but I don't do clingy *"* the remark searing into her skin, making her hurt and feel dirty at the same time.

Double Trouble, in fairness, had made it clear that this was just another job for them. She had thought that given more time together and if they could see how worthy she was, maybe Catra could change their mind to earn some form of affection. If that wasn't going to work, then she thought she could offer something a little more valuable. A warm body. Anything to make her feel like someone *wanted* to hold her.

In the long run it was fortunate that her attempts at seduction didn't work. It would have been another avenue for her to self-destruct, even though the rejection was a further driving force in her war with everyone, including herself.

That was in the past and she couldn't fairly fault Adora for seeking something similar. As much as she hated it herself, sometimes the lure of human contact was just something you couldn't help but crave. Now she had it. Not only had it, but with a person that she trusted most in the world. Someone who wouldn't use her for their own gratification just to be cast aside once they were finished.

To Adora, she mattered.

As the nausea rocked her eyes to a close, she still felt inadequate and yet she had never known Adora to demand anything from her. No matter how many times she yelled and pushed her away, she was always there to bring her back and accepted her in whatever she was facing in life.

Still the thought continued to bang in her mind as she drifted off in a stuffy sleep again.

The worry that it wasn't entirely Adora that had been attracted to her enough to act upon it last night. The fact that it took a decent amount of alcohol for her to take action.

Please don't be because of that.

Please , don't be because of that.

A reverberating knock faded in, Catra wasn't sure how many times it had been as she slumped her neck above her hill of comfort to peek at the still locked door. Melog looked to the door and then back at Catra expectantly.

"Ms. Catra, it's just me" the voice of Lana, one of the housekeepers called. "Ms. Adora sent me with this and a message, if you're awake"

When Catra stood this time, the room seemed to tilt much more violently than it had on her first walk down. She rushed to the door, twisting her wrist to unlock it to receive whatever it was that Lana had.

At the appearance of a half asleep Catra who looked like she had seen better days, Lana's eyes widened. She held a small silver tray

in her hands, Catra looked down at a glass of water and some sort of medication, feeling the unimpressed expression on her face loom over poor Lana.

"I- um she said if you weren't feeling well take two of these…" she stuttered, trying not to be disrespectful of Catra's messy bedhead. The poor woman had been aware that the only thing that ailed Catra was the repercussions of a good night out. Cata nodded before swigging the small placement of pills back with a sip of the water she offered before placing the two back on her platter. She gave a tired long stare to Lana to get on with whatever else she might have to say. Noticing that her superior seemed to be waiting on her to react, she sprung back to life.

"She also wanted to let you know that there is an upcoming campaign that you are invited to join-"

"Where?" she cut her off gruffly.

"She didn't say but she said she'll be around later if you want to discuss it" Lana looked at Catra to see if her answer was acceptable. Catra had no energy to pander and accepted the information with a nod, closing her eyes while scratching lazily at her own arm.

"Okay, thank you" Catra said, turning back.

"What…would you like me to respond with anything?" she asked quickly before Catra retreated. Her exhausted angular face stared at her.

With no expression she answered with an aloof: "Tell her I'll consider it". She entered her room again to suffer in peace. She wanted to head right back to bed but decided that she needed to at least pretend to do something productive today. Once the pain killers kicked in for her headache, she could handle the rest. Her

thinly opened eyes looked to a perked up Melog on the bed. He needed attention today.

"How about I shower and we go on a walk?" she asked, prompting a tilt of their wispy head.

She made quick work of rinsing off and switching out for a fresh set of clothing, immediately improving how she was feeling and her mood. She still had the mixed feeling of hunger and like her stomach may just reject everything at any given moment.

Still she couldn't just wait around her room all day. Someone would assume something was wrong and come poking around one way or another. Walking helped her stay out of her own mind too much. With the help of Melog's natural cloaking abilities and the well timed use of the other stairwell, the two made it out of the palace with ease. Melog peered his head around, looking excitedly at the vast offerings of the nearby forest. A kaleidoscope of blue shades exchanged themselves on leaves above them moved to and away from each other.

Melog moved from her side to explore the twists of a nearby root system at the base of a tree. Catra slowed herself to keep in the same area as Melog. She wondered if the place Adora would be going to next would have trees like this.

"We're going to see the world!" And conquer it!"

Her own words rang in her mind. Partially reflected her true wants while parroting the same goals that were forced upon by someone else until she believed they were her own. She and Melog continued their stroll deeper into the woods, no real aim or desire

to be anywhere for the time being. She was sure she wanted to go wherever this next mission was taking Adora. Deciding to stay behind for only the sake of being self-conscious was stupid and childish.

Like Adora had said, if she wanted to go, then she would go.

Along the section of overgrown trail they walked on, she could spy eroded pieces of metal from past Horde robots. Nature had already done the heavy work of reclaiming its land, with its green vines holding fast to every joint of the bot. Relief at seeing such a powerful piece of tech now reduced to a worthless heap of scrap with clusters of tiny flower buds creeping up along its side was ironic.

At least the tech didn't have an issue with knowing when to give up. It didn't have the capacity to push past its limits. To go over one hundred percent was impossible. Once it was blown to pieces or disconnected from a power source it didn't have the option to fret about its next move. It was left to rest, even in the poor condition it was abandoned in, it looked like some sort of art installations the university students around Bright Moon's academic district would display on the streets.

Catra used to wish she had just been left to rest. A life without berating from Shadow Weaver would have been a dream that never came true.

Just because she was gone didn't mean the loop of tearing down Catra would stop, it would just come from the internalized Shadow Weaver. All of her mannerisms and tells were committed to memory, known by heart. She knew precisely which mistake would elicit what reaction from her. To beat anyone else to it, she could hound herself with the punishment instead. She wished she were *left to rest.*

After nearly an hour of wandering around the winding paths in the woods, Catra and Melog turned to head back towards the more populated areas. The trails were familiar enough that she knew the way they were currently traveling would let them up past the old barracks building and through a previously outdated training yard. In a stark contrast to Bright Moon's well kept facilities, this was the one portion that could be described as a bit run down.

Glimmer had recently ordered renovations on the area, vastly improving the grounds and training offered to both her guard and army in the event of another world wide war, she and her people would be ready.

For the meantime, the area was being cleaned of all of the construction materials and it was normal to see small groups of servicemen and women strolling around to show off the new offerings before it's official unveiling. The matching off white exterior still stood, Glimmer not wanting to change the face of history in her home. Catra had only seen schematics of the plans for the inside and they had looked impressive.

She walked confidently, gazing over the area as she drew closer. The tangles of the Whispering Woods were exchanged for the cleanly cut grass of the grounds. It was still a convenient location to the castle, being just on the other side of a large gray rock formation that walled it off in a defensive barrier.

Catra saw Melog give a quick sniff in the air before slowing and falling into line with her. He was letting her know there was someone ahead. Facing forward she saw that he was correct, just off the side of the path she was traveling was three people. A stocky woman with her dark hair pulled up into a protective style on the top of her head with a large green anthropomorphic man and his smaller blonde counterpart all too far to make out their conversation from where Catra stood. All of their past Horde uniforms now had the red colors exchanged for the more fitting

tones of Bright Moon, soft shades of blue lining the edges of their clothing.

Her steps took pause, she debated taking a different route. Speaking to her former team was something she had intentionally been putting off since she heard the trio had found work not only on Bright Moon, but with the guard. Shaking the uncertainty off, she continued her walk. She wasn't going to change her walk just to hide tail from them.

It wasn't until she was within a few yards that Rogelio noticed her approaching. She watched him give Kyle a small nudge that was still hard enough to move his entire body. After he turned to see, he quickly whispered something to Lonnie before all three of them had shifted to look. They were always terrible at discretion. All at once they feigned getting back to their work.

Now close enough to see that they were digging, Catra wondered what the best greeting would be. Or maybe none at all would be fine. They were close enough that there was no way any of them could pretend to have not seen each other. Always the head strong one, Catra bit the bullet.

She gave a small wave. "Hey guys" her voice called much more meekly than she had meant, causing her to frown at herself. Catra severely doubted that even the comradery of growing up together, being cadets, or surviving a war was enough for them to act as if everything was perfectly fine between them. She had been the one to make sure that it was never fine back when she was their superior.

Kyle gave a shy wave, Rogelio only offered a stony stare while Lonnie didn't even bother to stop working to acknowledge her.

Melog's color shifted along with Catra's discomfort to a slightly green color.

"Working with construction now?" the former Horde captain tried to jest with a weak forced laugh. She should have just kept moving.

Kyle was again, the only one to bite. "Nah, just have to dig up some soil samples around the kingdom to check lev-"

"Some of us have work to do, you know" Lonnie snapped, wedging the blade of her shovel into the ground before resting a forearm on it and shoot a cool glare at Catra. In the absence of words, Lonnie took the opportunity to figuratively dig at Catra one more time. "We don't get to just play around in the palace all day because we're all buddy-buddy with Adora".

She had known that Lonnie and her had never gotten along, but even from her the words hit hard. Catra stood silently, her companion now much smaller and standing at the ready by her ankles. Inside, she knew she wanted to apologize or at least acknowledge her behavior back when she was their Captain. The stabbing of her insult made her only want to sharpen her own in response.

"It's not like that…"

"Okay so what, you just come out here to tell us what an incompetent job we're doing? What'd you do Catra, get a nice cushy promotion again up there? You were always good at keeping yourself afloat however you had to" she mocked, seeming satisfied to finally be able to say the words without fear of retaliation.

Catra's face grew hot, looking at Rogelio and Kyle then away. The now glowing red of Melog's mane cast more light around them as a low growl came from the creature.

"And here you are, doing the same thing you looked down on Adora for" Catra motioned to the ground around them and pointing out the fact that none of them were with the Horde now. Lonnie gave a snide grin.

"So you are here to fight your girlfriend's battles?"

At the second mention of Adora, any hope Catra had to keep her level head and possibly extend the olive branch was decimated. She wanted to hit Lonnie and shut her up.

Melog began to rise in irritation with her, Kyle's eyes fixated on the changing of the creature and looking noticeably worried.

"Lonnie, I think we have enough samples from this quadrant…" his quiet voice tried its best to divert some of the tension. She ignored him.

"Quiet Kyle, if Catra is here for something she should just spit it out" she provoked again. Catra stalked closer to Lonnie with no intention of backing down.

"You sound like you're the one with a fucking *problem* " Catra raised her voice, now closing in on Lonnie. She knew from past experiences that Lonnie was stronger but that she was faster. Lonnie pushed her shovel over, scowling at Catra with her body positioned to ready herself. If she was looking for a confrontation, that's exactly what Catra would give her. She flexed her hands, balling them into a fist before flicking them and her razor-like claws outward.

Before either of them could get another word in, the echo of Scorpia's voice rang from over the trail in front of them. From the looks of anyone approaching, the situation looked tense with Lonnie and Catra in eachothers face while the other two stood out of their way. The two of them shifted their stances slightly before the larger statured woman neared.

"We've been looking for you all morning, we have a meeting" she greeted happily, clearly oblivious to the energy emitting from the encounter. She waved a friendly claw at the trio, receiving much more genuine reactions than Catra had. She gave a fierce look to Lonnie before storming off.

"Have fun at your meeting!" Lonnie called out as she left, almost triggering Catra to turn around to strike her if Scorpia hadn't been there.

Melog's color died down slightly. He kept his prowling eyes on Lonnie even after Catra had made some distance between them. While she walked she kept her arms tense, still feeling on the lighter side of rage. Scorpia finally seemed to notice her body language after several minutes of walking.

"Hey, are you good?" she asked, concerned.

"She pisses me off" Catra murmured, trying to regulate herself. She wanted to yell. She wanted to not talk to anyone. She wasn't sure what she wanted.

"Everything okay?" she asked. Catra had to stop herself from berating her for what a dumb question that was. Everything was clearly not okay but that wasn't Scorpia's fault. She had been trying to work on being clear on things when they bothered her and thankfully Scorpia was one of the people who knew that.

"No, well yeah, but…" her adrenaline made it difficult to find what she wanted to say. "She should learn how to keep her mouth shut."

Scorpia looked on, fretting her friend's current state of anger and exasperation. She watched Melog keep his place between the two of them as they walked the trail closer to the palace. Trees were more spaced out as the closer they grew, the more attention to detail was paid to the landscaping.

“Sounds like she had a lot she wanted to say. Did you try ignoring her?” the white haired woman asked simply. Catra glared at her for offering the same advice someone might give a child. “What I mean is that sometimes people just keep talking and you just let them.”

“Not when she says shit like that” Catra argued. Scorpia looked at her, her black eyebrows furrowed.

“Was it that bad?” her quiet voice asked.

Thinking of the actual words that had been exchanged, Catra decided that she had heard worse said about her. Both behind her back and to her face. Scorpia’s line of questioning made her realize it wasn’t the words that bothered her, it was the way she wanted to react to them.

She was ready to go back to the way she used to be just because someone said a few words she didn’t like. Catra had been prepared and willing to tear at Lonnie for the crime of having an attitude. She hadn’t, but if things had progressed and she had to face Adora the same way she had as children to admit she had such little control over herself, that would have been the ultimate punishment. When she thought about all of the ammunition Lonnie had at her disposal and the things she *could* have said, she figured there was given more leniency than what had the potential to play out. Had they switched places, Catra knew she wouldn't have been able to stop herself from tearing into her with every word that she had.

Catra sighed. “No” she admitted. Scorpia nodded, walking in silence for most of the way back to give Catra the space she needed while still being with her.

Chapter Five

Chapter Summary

> An improtu meeting with her old group from the Horde, Catra attends a meeting regarding the latest mission. Deciding to join the efforts again, she later meets back up with Adora to air her bottled up feelings from the other night.

Making their way to the war room, the extreme height of the lilac ceilings made Catra's late entrance feel a little less noticeable. The meeting had already begun and due to the amount of people in the room, it was easy to join the masses without standing out.

Princesses from their respective kingdoms and higher members of Bright Moon's military sat around a table in their established throne-like seats, at the front sat Glimmer with Bow and Adora at her side which was customary for hearings like this. Catra listened intently, their voices carrying easily through the spacious room's acoustics. Standing around the walls of the rooms were other guards, strategists, and a couple of secretaries there to take notes and make arrangements based on the plans formulated. Scorpia slipped back into her seat by Perfuma, who gave her a knowing glance as it would have been impossible for her to not notice her presence was missing.

Her line of sight wandered over to Adora automatically, she was seated and listening intently to Glimmer explain the successes of the reclaiming and clean up from the war. The fighter must have felt someone's gaze on her, causing her to break her attention from Bright Moon's royalty to look around the room. Catra snapped her eyes back to Glimmer, feigning interest in her speech.

"...but with the success we have in the effort, we have also come across some concerning news. Some of our sensors have picked up anomalies in remote villages…" her clear words were self-assertive, never floundering as she fulfilled her role elegantly. At

her revelation, Catra began to pay more attention to what was happening in the meeting.

On a large holo-map on the table that flicked to life, Entrapta pointed to several dotted areas where they had picked up tech from Prime's ship that they had believed to be previously destroyed. To be sure to have done the thorough work of ridding the world of the stain of his presence, many of the leaders decided it would be wise to send a lead team out to take care of it.

Lead always meant She-Ra.

Deciding on dates and departure times, arrangements were made for Adora, Bow, and Entrapta to check on the situation before sending out any reinforcements that may not be needed. At the close of the meeting, Adora's stern eyes finally connected to Catra as she caught her inconspicuous presence. The room began to rise, people standing and dismissing themselves to leave after having all the intel from the situation that they needed for the time being. Melogs faded glowing eyes scanned the groups of officials as they filed out of the hall.

"Hey" Adora asked, having followed the flow of those exiting to make her way to Catra. She wore her red jacket. Catra stood herself up straightened from the position of her lean against the wall. Her mind barricaded itself from thinking about the more compromising positions the two were in last night compared with the professional distance they tried to hold now. She could tell that Adora was trying to get a read on her, mentally working out why she had left abruptly this morning.

"At least this briefing was short, right?" she joked dryly, entirely avoiding the topic. Adora gave a small laugh, putting a hand on

her hip.

“Right, sometimes they get a little lengthy. That’s why I was surprised to see you here” she admitted.

The room was nearly empty now, the low murmurs now. Adora scuffed a boot on the floor, waiting for a response.

“Yeah Scorpia came to get me”.

She hated the quiet small talk as if they were acquaintances who had nothing more pressing to talk about than the weather.

“Where did you go?” Adora asked, sincere concern pulling at her brows. The tone of her voice alone made Catra feel terrible.

“I wasn’t feeling good” a half truth she wasn’t sure Adora would buy. A curt nod in response.

“If last night wasn’t- I didn’t mean to make you feel…”

“You didn’t” Catra cut her off. She hadn’t meant to sound so rash with her but Adora had a habit of feeling like everyone’s emotions were her personal responsibility. Her ears flattened slightly, irked with the notion that Adora had forced her to feel any sort of way. Catra could tell that Adora did not believe her. The strange feeling between them still permeated the space.

“I hope you’re feeling better” she walked to the doorway with Catra.

“All good, gotta be feeling better if I’m going with you” she shifted her eyes playfully back to her, seeing her light up.

“You think you will?” Adora’s eager body language forcing her to stop and orient herself to give Catra her full attention. It was like seeing her when they were young again. Catra smirked.

“Just to make sure you three don’t wander into a leftover trap or something,” she clarified “...not because I like you.” The flirtation was a catalyst to Adora’s now elated expression, her smile spanning across her face at the excitement for the two to have a new experience together.

“Definitely *not* it” she jokingly agreed. Before she could get another word out, Bow interrupted to prep Adora for logistics of the area they planned to land and set up a small base camp in. Adora excused herself, parting with Catra by giving her a small peck and telling her she would see her later.

Everytime she left her presence she felt like life was gently being pulled from her. Heading with Melog back to her room, colors seemed moderately duller, little traces of amusement she found in anything were fizzled down to bland meaningless background filler. Each time they left each other, her thoughts were ever preoccupied with the thought of the next time they would be together.

Just before she stepped out of the room, a small silver cart caught her wandering eye. Bottles and immaculate shakers rested in their place on the wheeled shelves, offering themselves to her.

Her stomach had just begun to ease from last night but the opportunity to chase the fragmented feeling she had last night was tempting. With Adora, she felt whole but the intoxicated state she had put herself in last night was enjoyable enough to make her feel like she was a complete person on her own for once. That she was strong and capable to do anything that she wanted, maybe even similar to the high that her beloved experienced when she would transform into She-Ra.

Sparing no more thought, her hand wrapped around a bronze bottle and swiftly left with it. It wasn't stealing if it was offered.

Catra held the bottle down at level with her thigh, gripping it harshly as if it would try to escape her like so many others had. Just a taste when she returned to the room, she decided. Something to wind down with.

When she and her pet companion entered her room, she tossed the remaining curtains open to let the sun in. The breeze was now considerably colder than the day before. The feline-like animal solidly dashed to the open balcony to catch a glimpse of birds flying by before lowering himself to look out the distance under the banister. Though she could communicate with Melog with ease, it wasn’t needed with the clear intent on their face to chase and inspect the far off movement.

The former captain used the distraction, willfully telling herself that she wasn't trying to hide it from Melog, but she didn't need their large feline eyes staring up at her while she search the top of her dresser for the small decorative porcelain pieces she swore she had spotted on its mantel before. Dusting the round rim of the receptacle with her thumb to clear it of any dust, she broke the seal and poured the amber flow into the glass.

The smell wasn't her favorite, completely over amplified by her senses as the odor of fermentation rushed over her. The burning taste was strong, tiny scorches washing over her before disappearing. The effects gave a warm, velvety feeling as it carefully dulled all of the stimulations that prodded her earlier. Her hand reached to place the small glass back, while she opened her top drawer to push some loose clothing aside. After tightening the cap with an extra push, she put the bottle into its make-shift nest then pulled a few garments over top of it for extra peace of mind. One was fine, she wasn't looking to overdo it in the middle of the day. Her mind did wander, entertaining the caressing thought of how much a second drink would help her relax before she brushed it off. She felt better, sharper.

With the help of her new found liquid aid, she decided to spend her afternoon straightening up her living space, which was done fairly quickly. It wasn’t like the old dormitory where the shared space was bland and never gave a feeling of comfort even when it was at its cleanest. Of all of the things that troubled her in her youth, keeping her bunk clean was never something that was a top priority. The others would criticize her for her perceived laziness, that she should at least make an attempt to make up the scratchy comfort of her bed, but what would it matter?

Shadow Weaver would still be displeased. She would reprimand, letting Catra and all of the other cadets know that she was just a filthy little creature that didn’t know how to keep anything clean. It wouldn’t have mattered if she swept and mopped for hours to make the floor shine, she could never do anything right. It wasn’t like they were allowed much time to actually enjoy their time in the space anyway.

Having this hide-away now was as sweet at a full inhale after holding your breath for too long. She could take up this space in whatever way she felt, though it felt unnatural, at Glimmer's assurance she became more at ease with laying on the floor when she wanted or letting Melog join her on the bed. She picked up the few traces of left clothing and put them in her hamper before reorganizing the small glass bottles that lined the shelves in her personal bathroom, which was another luxury that she graciously accepted. It was nice to exist in a space without being dismissed as unmotivated, an insult that made her only pull further into herself and try even less.

The only space she had that felt anywhere near hers was the burnt red rust of the high tower she would climb to get away from everyone or when she needed to process her jumbled thoughts. In no way was it her own sanctuary but the only people who cared to climb that high were ones specifically seeking her out for

lighter reasons than just being critiqued, which was only ever Adora and on a rare occasion, Scorpia. The crusted scraped up railings would rake across her skin when she ran her hands across them on the way up, a sensation that when teamed with her massive height above everything made her feel like she had miniscule form of control.

Now she sat in her new version of her previous high tower. Seated on the railing, one long leg dangling and the other pulled up close enough for her to rest her arm on and Melog standing on hind legs to stretch up to her hand as she scratched soothingly down their blue form. She had already packed a loose assortment of items that would be needed on their deployment. The bag on her bed was not heavily packed when the door opening made her head whip up. Adora, now transformed into She-Ra, walked in, heavily booted footsteps glowing into the calm of the room.

Catra raised an eyebrow, dropping her bare feet down to pad back into her room. One arm rested on her hip and the other hanging to her side. She eyed Adora, looking at the eththerial get up she never came to her in.

"Hello *She-Ra* " she condescended. The large stance of the shining woman shifted as she looked down, a widening of her eyes having noticed her form again. She sighed, closing her eyes and dwindling down to herself as the light faded. Once she looked up, she smiled to Catra and walked over to the bed before crawling onto the bed, sitting with her legs crossed.

"Sorry that took so long, they wanted me to give an inspirational speech to keep morale steady" she worked a small button that fastened her red jacket closed. After she loosened it and pulled the garment from her, she bundled it onto the soft bed beside her, working to make herself step out of the work role that she found herself stuck in most days.

Catra looked on without a word, causing Adora to feel the need to fill the silence. “We head out tomorrow,” she added softly. Catra gave a single nod.

“I’ve already started packing” she informed blandly. Adora straightened herself up more, brushing a small blonde strand from her face as she knew something was amiss. They never felt uncomfortable when it was just the two of them, even if they were sitting in silence all day just enjoying the feeling of being together it hadn’t felt as shifted. She eyed Catra, trying to look for a tell that would help her figure out what had happened. She knew that her girlfriend hated it when she tried to read her and “fix” the situation when she decided it was needed.

“Everything okay?” she asked against her better judgment, knowing that it may be the ignitor that set her off. Catra forced her eyes to paint themselves as a bit more expressive, Adora could tell easily when she had something on her mind.

“Yeah, just excited for tomorrow” she partially fibbed. Adora looked at her, trying to discern if she was serious. Catra rarely got excited unless it was a job that allowed them to travel to new, exotic places so it wasn’t an impossibility.

Though her words were sensible, Adora noticed the gap still spanning between them as she remained alone on the bed and Catra was standing with her arms folded. She raised her sleeved arm, extending a hand to entice her closer.

She could never resist.

Catra stepped toward her, climbing her legs onto the bed to crawl towards her lover. Once their hands touched and Adora pulled her in, it was like a clean erasure to everything else. The mental list for their upcoming mission was instantly washed from the forefront of her mind now that they were together.

Adora pulled back, bringing herself down flat with a small plush landing on the comforter and Catra following her lead to keep their fingers entwined and bring herself into the safety of her arms and her favorite place at the crook of her neck. Her scent of light vanilla and sandalwood wrapped Catra in its tightness, causing her to move and nestle closer into the athletic arms of her partner.

Catra felt like she could melt into her, her palm finding rest over the steady beat of Adora's heart.

"I'm really glad you're coming with me" Adora whispered. Catra couldn't fight the smile that found itself washed across her lips. Sure she was a hero, a fantastic leader, and all of these things of importance to the world, but for Catra, she had the infallible power to make her feel optimistic without even trying. Her long lashes lifted to meet with Adoras calming gaze as the two remained settled in with each other. Had she not decided to travel with, she knew the tearing pain of her leaving once again would have been brutal.

Any time that they could steal away together went by too fast, each touch and kiss inching them closer to another separation. Catra wanted it, every moment, every inch of Adora that she could but she hadn't wanted to share with anyone. Although she felt like she didn't earn the right to be held by her like this, it didn't stop her from feeling lost when the time was over and she was left waiting again.

She wanted to take advantage of every moment they had. Every minute that Adora made her feel weak in the knees, every chance to hold her calloused hands, she wanted it all. She snaked an arm around Adora's side, pulling her body closer to her own then bringing her hand up to her bicep to trace a black nail up and down her muscles like she was memorizing the shape of her. Her

hand rubbed the small of her back, enchanted by the curves that lay hidden under.

The feeling her touch evoked on Adora's skin was quick to show, her muscles tightened and her breathing lowered as she traced the constellation of freckles on Catra's face. Adora leaned downward, their mouths meeting in anticipation. Adora's toned body moved on top of Catra's while they repositioned their lips as they only broke in search of air. Strong hands ran through her dark brown hair and down to her neck as Catra held her arm around her waist, unable to let her go.

The weight of Adora on her drove her to further her movements, absent mindedly lowering her hands from Adora's mid-section to the firm shape of her ass. She grabbed at her waist, trying to move the obstacle of her pants out of the way without the help of her vision to guide her. At the touch of Catra's hand working its way through the band, Adora pulled back, halting their exchange. Without a word, she continued to kiss as she used her own hand to guide Catra back up to less explicit areas of her body. Catra frowned, unsure of how Adora thought she was going to breeze past that exchange.

"Hey…" Catra pleaded firmly, stopping to look at Adora's face. What had she done where a normally eager Adora would turn her down?

"It's okay" Adora assured, rubbing her thumb down her cheek. Catra still held a look of uncertainty at Adora, dark browns pinching together on her face.

"...you don't want to?".

The playful mood soured slightly, Adora could feel her shrink under her as she hovered above. Catra's hand released from her back.

“Of course I want to, I don’t want you to feel like you have to…” Adora looked at her like she was carefully gazing at a priceless art piece, fearing that her voice alone would be enough to damage it. Her face dropped, etching all of the previous moments of desire away.

“Adora, I’m literally throwing myself at you” annoyance hanging on the edge of her words. She hated feeling paranoid, her mind knew that Adora would never be withholding anything from her. Still she wondered if she was unattractive or still too outburst prone for Adora to want her without the external influence of alcohol.

“I want it too-”

“But what's the problem then? You love me so much until it’s too much and you come to your stupid senses?” fury brewed in each dig she gave. It was a rockslide of anger that she had no reliant protection to stop.

“Catra, stop.” Adora demanded, a hint of pleading in her voice. They knew that the isolated time they had together was slipping away like sand funneling down an hourglass, she didn’t want to spend the time arguing with the one person she looked forward to seeing every hour of her day. Melog now moved forward, pacing the foot of the bed nervously as they watch Catra shimmy herself up and out from Adora’s pinning position.

“I don’t feel forced into anything. I know you being a big magic lady seems to have that effect on everyone but don’t flatter yourself.” she snapped. Adora shook her head in small motions as she stammered to collect her words.

She leaned herself back, allowing Catra’s pointed stare to meet her at eye level now. “Right, but the first time we do something like that and you disappear the next morning. What the fuck am I supposed to think?” her exasperated voice trenching itself deeper.

In her frustration, she gave an exaggerated eye roll. Always finding it easier to deflect real conversations with a childish or snide comment. She wasn't ready to have the conversation about her self-conscious worries about her being unable to perform for Adora the way she deserved. She flushed as she rationalized that must be part of the reason Adora didn't want her hands on her. Each irritation in her mind fired off, finding the path of least resistance to arm herself in the argument.

"Sorry, I forgot you're used to everyone doing whatever you want" she dug, hoping to hit enough nerves to make Adora storm out and leave her in the isolation she deserved. Adora knew all of her tactics, but it didn't make any of her insults sting any less. She straightened her legs back out onto the floor, facing away from her.

"What is going on with you?" she shot a look to Catra "Everything is okay, we're together just like we…I…" her words hesitated, unsure in the moment if that was something that Catra wanted. She shook off the feeling, leaning back to a resistant Catra. Hearing the sadness in her voice caused Catra's ears to lower. The wave of guilt for causing her hurt began to wash at her as it always had. Adora gathered her thoughts before trying one more time.

"If I hurt you or did something, just tell me. We can figure this out together."

Her anger fizzled, though the scraped as much as she could to keep the mask of it still partially on her face in a displeased sorrow. In a quick flash fire of her anger, the tired shame that accompanied her feeling of coming down. As much as she tried to push her away by showing all of her own faults time after time, Adora knew how to hold on. She wished she hadn't had the experience to know how to hold on. Always assuring that the pain of letting go would far outweigh anything they would endure together and that she would always be there for her.

She faltered, desperate to not ruin another moment by her own hand.

"No, please. I didn't mean it" Catra quickly reneged her words. She added a tally to the number of times she would ask this from her. The running count of how much Adora would accept this before she grew tired of her frantic apologies. "I swear, I do want you. Every piece of you..and I'm trying to do better…" her voice cracked softly. Adora watched, waiting to see what would follow.

"It's okay…"

"No it isn't!" she insisted "It isn't fair to you, that I do this to you all the fucking time! All I want is to be good enough for you!"

Her mismatched eyes had already filled with hot tears before she could finish her hurried sentence. Adora moved on to her knees, closing in and wrapping her arms around her like she was holding the broken pieces together. The bit of alcohol she had in her system hours earlier was long gone and now she had nothing to blame except herself. The muffled sounds of light sobbing worked their soft wretches from Adors's shoulder. She understood it was likely not the last time Catra would explode only to immediately regret it.

"You know that I love you. You're everything to me Catra," Adora assured, holding her hand on her head, keeping it in the stability of her embrace. "but you have to want to do better for yourself, not for me".

Catra's eyes peered open through tears that streamed down her face in drops. The self-help proclamation made sense but it was a mountain she couldn't climb. She didn't deserve forgiveness and everyone knew it. The only person who had thought otherwise was the one keeping her together right now and that shouldn't have been her duty.

She only nodded. Adora was much more clear with using her words and planning a course of action, something Catra wished she could replicate in herself. Personally knowing that she had all of the drive for her goals, but lacked in areas of discipline and control to make anything a reality for herself.

"I'm sorry for doing this to you" Catra said, feeling her own body relax into Adora's after her outburst. Adora didn't waiver, she continued to hold her even as she leaned back into the bed. Adora shook her head and kissed the top of it before resting her cheek on Catras shortcut hair, tickling her own skin. Her striped arms covering Adora's hold across her torso

"We're in this together, I promise"

Her eyes closed, the two holding onto each other long enough to create enough warmth and lull them into a tired haze before the sun set.

Chapter Six

Chapter Summary

> While learning more information about where the mission is taking them, more stressors are added to Catra's plate.

With luck, the two had fallen asleep early enough to be well rested for the wake up call they received before sun up. Catra finished packing her bag and headed down to the hanger bay where the ship was set to depart from at the lower grounds of the palace. Adora gave a small peck before heading to her own room to grab a small pack of belongings, telling Catra she would see her there. Just before she turned out the lights, she backed up and went for the top drawer to pack one more thing onto her bag.

Each time they loaded onto a new ship, it made her mind fall back to memories of the Horde’s internal storage zones, before she had been allowed to operate and lead heavier machinery. The phantom echoes of metal clanging and engines releasing pressure in small precise hisses made her senses feel more in tune, focused and ready to take on their directive. From the sleek lines of the floor, she could see in the main window the light shade of purple hair flipping switches and prepping the craft before it was time to take off. Two other grunts worked to carry on a bin of Entrapta’s additional tech that needed to be loaded, the newer boxes looking neatly stowed away while the largest bin held a tangle of wires that ballooned over and out of its edges.

Catra followed the men and freight up the ramp into the ship, picking up a stray motherboard to something that had fallen from the clump of electronics. When they turned right to store the load in a space out of the way, she took a left to head up to the bridge to see if she could make herself useful to Entrapta. Melog’s elated

bound past her made her scoff in amusement. The hurried feeling of excitement warmed the edges of her current nerves.

Her sharp eyebrows gave a rise as they studied the green chunk of computer in her hand. She tilted it to see small specks of golden and black colored circuits jutting from the top. The hollowness of a control room without its crew on display in front of Catra before she looked down to see the inventor now lowered herself under a control panel to tweak some wires that she likely didn't have the permission to do.

"Need this for anything?" Catra called out, holding the piece down towards her friend. At the sound, Entrapta pulled herself from her work. Small remains of sparks fell onto her well used welding mask before she leaned herself out from under the surface, looking up to see who had joined her. Red quizzical eyes went directly to the object Catra held out before moving to look at her. She lit up, grabbing it from her hold.

"That's perfect, I can reconfigure the circuits on this to make the finer tuned radar we need!" her nasally voice exclaimed. Though Catra rarely knew what she was going on about when she delved deep into her craft, she held a fraction of bitterness at her ease to be in good spirits for anything that aligned with her passion. Whether her research involved terrible outcomes or if she knew that nobody understood half of the topics she spoke of, she was carefree in freeing the string of neverending information to her friends in sheer happiness.

"There's others like it in that big box of shit they just carried on" Catra added, doubting that Entrapta had any remaining interest in anything she had to say now that she used smaller tools to pick at

the processing socket to facilitate a new connection. “What’s the radar for anyway?”.

She hadn't expected an answer but one large pigtail moved to the accord of its host, wrapping its flowing waves around a monitor on the dashboard. Her concealed voice spoke from under the frame.

“We didn’t want to go into this with only a loose idea of an area so we can have the ship narrow down the search” she elaborated, still fiddling with a small metal cylinder in her gloved fingers. Catra was glad that her friend seemed to lack the social awareness to question why she was coming when it hadn’t been a point of the meeting the day before. With Entrapta, she was very upfront with anything on her mind. Complex enough to be simple. The idea of using up valuable time on trying to find her way through a maze of structured cues that were typically lost in translation was something she couldn’t bother herself with.

“We already know the current signal is by a village though, right?” Catra asked, crossing her arms in front of the black and red of her outfit. She wanted to roll through the ideas of strategy for the number of ways this could play out. Having any number of civilians near them could be an advantage or a heavier disadvantage for them depending what strange readings the scans were picking up.

“Some place in the middle of nowhere,” Entrapta confirmed “Brimeda? A few hundred people living there was the last update we got.” her voice seemingly uninterested in discussing the geopolitics of the area they were headed. The facts produced only represent themselves as numbers, statistics to be accounted for in her planning.

Catra tried to remember her studies from the courses she was forced to sit through in her youth. Knowing the terrain and layout of areas was pertinent to being an exceptional soldier, something that didn't interest her at the time but when she would help Adora wade through the names of far off places and their capital cities that were hard to pronounce, many of the stronger cities remained in her mind, as did their places on a map.

A city- not even large enough to earn the label of a city- was not one that she could recall from the far off memories.

Through the front pane of thick glass that would soon separate them from the outer pressure of the atmosphere, she could see Adora and Bow approach as their heads looked towards each other to discuss plans. The base of Catra's stomach fluttered in the prolepsis of a new location. When they had originally settled the issue of Horde Prime and Adora had stabilized the Heart of Etheria, the frequent life of being on the move was fine. She had done it before with the Horde, she had done it with Prime, and she could certainly handle continuing the never ending loop of travel.

Once she was needed less and Glimmer had pressing issues in her home that she had to see to, they and the other princesses tried to return to a sense of normalcy in their respective kingdoms while maintaining the line of communication with each other to keep their homelands bonded and strong. Catra had landed herself in the temporary hold of Bright Moon's palace, taking advantage of the time to work on the facets of herself that she could. She never had time to herself where she wasn't scrambling,

chasing after something. She didn’t think it was something she could just unlearn within herself.

Through the assistance of her friends, she had. She learned the things she enjoyed to do with them and the importance of knowing how to be on her own in a safe place where she wouldn’t entirely shut down, trying to project the blame on anyone she could for the knots she felt inside. It was all steps in what felt like the right direction but still infuriated her when those steps turned into the receding way of life she used to live. As she left Entrapta to finish melting pieces together, the cold feeling of the ship’s hull graced her feet while she made her way to look for an open corridor and claim a bunk.

As she stepped through, she caught Bow and Adora coming into the room. Bow heading over to plug in the coordinates to the ships navigation system while Adora flashed Catra a quick grin and wave like her attendance had been a surprise. Keeping a stoic face, her ears could not mask in the same way. The black triangles gave a sheepish duck down as she gave an amiable smile over her shoulder before heading down the deep gray hall.

The broad doors that all stayed slide open, hidden in the recess of their walls showed each pristine bunk set in the rooms she passed. The third room already housing Melog, who moved in circles on the thinner material of the standard bed mat. While they pawed at the flimsy pillow, Catra tossed her bag onto the bunk overhead.

“Looks good to me” she said in agreement with their companion’s choice, letting her nails give a soothing scratch to Melog’s coat.

Though she set her mid-sized canvas bag on the top bunk, she had little intention of sleeping in that particular one if and when the time came. She would do as she did as a child and elect to pair up on the bottom bunk, this time with Melog instead of Adora who would likely take her own bunk room in the event that they had to work in shifts manning the ship. While she stood near Melog, she placed her hand around a beam running vertically up the furniture. She remembered before they had made things about their relationship clear for everyone and themselves that they played with the zealous feeling of sneaking into each other's rooms when they traveled through space. Careful glances in the darkness of the passageways while the colossal vessel pulled its way through the cosmos was her favorite game of cat and mouse. The shadowed feeling she would get as a child and teen when she joined Adora in her bed was amplified and over time she couldn't wait for the nights where the rest of the team had gone to bed before she would make her nightly route. Her sly morning exits were also less frequent when the two decided they didn't care if people knew. The only thing that mattered is that they didn't wake up without each other anymore.

The first night of having Entrapta work on the chip in her neck caused Catra to break down enough to beg Adora to stay was enough to make them tumble back to the old habits of their sleepovers. First it was at the suggestion of the inventress that someone should keep an eye on her overnight progress in case adjustments were needed. Adora had volunteered before that was even a request. Those nights were lined with the large margin of space, Adora standing, pacing, or kneeling at the foot of her bed as she would count the hours away while she monitored Catra's condition. The removal of the chip had been a difficult operation, the tech and her body only being paired for the short period of time still had numerous connections to the tissue and nerves in her body, joined in precarious places where a mistake with he disconnection could not happen without major damage to her vertebrate and their functions.

In the moments when Catra woke up, Adora worked to make her as comfortable as she could. Offering water, extra pillows, but the only thing Catra would accept willingly was her hand and the extended company that Adora promised she would give even while she slept. The waves of pain would tandem to shoot searing, invisible attacks through her body, Adora tried to refrain from calling for Entrapta and the other medical aids for painkillers while her former friend begged her not to leave. As time went on, her space at the side of Catra's bed made a good place for her to slump over from exhaustion after another overnight watch, which then evolved into her settling at the foot of her cot as Catra used to do in her own bed so the two could look at the boring magazines and make fun of them during their extended time together.

Somewhere in those nights, they would fall asleep with their hands wrapped around each other while Adora remained protective at her side. The last few nights of Catra's stay in the infirmary was spent with Adora falling asleep, now at her side with their hands weaved together as they slept soundly with their arms wrapped around the other's. It was in the top ranks for most pain she had been in, but if it meant seeing the slow movements of Adora's finally rested face up close for the first time in years, she would consider living through it again.

No portraitist could ever paint something that rivaled her heavenly allurement and seeing it with her own eyes.

Now back on active duty with Adora did spark that old feeling of adventure within her. As much as she wanted to hide her away from the rest of the world and save her for herself, it was a sight

to behold when she would change into the impressive First One's savior.

Ready to head back out, she caught one more glance at her pack on the top bunk and considered the option of taking a quick drink to calm her nerves.

She stood with her hand rested on the frame of the doorway, tapping her forefinger as she eyed where she knew the bottle stayed hidden. She pushed off, into the hall and allowed the mechanical door to slide shut behind her.

From the distance she was, she could hear Adora and Bow still going over important considerations as Entrapa wrapped up her work under the control panel. She walked out silently, her arms crossed as she took a seat at one of the formidable chairs in front of the navigation system.

"...they just gave word that the rest of the ship has been closed up and is ready to depart" Bow notified his team. It was like watching a different person when he was in an informative position like this. The compassion he had always worn was now concealed under his executive role when he was leading a mission. Adora nodded, giving a quick glance to Catra before taking the commander's seat behind her on the higher platform.

Once all of the carts were removed from the outside of the ship and the hatches were secure, Bow flipped two red switches and pushed the activator to bring the low roar of the vessel to life. The gentle hover was expertly guided out of the hanger before his broad wrist pushed the throttle forward to increase their speed to climb elevation quickly. Catra turned to keep her eye on the monitor, she had experience with systems before and with Entrapa keying in their destination it was easy to track an estimated arrival

time as she watched their radar move slightly closer in the passing hour.

When they had reached the appropriate cruising height, the four of them were experienced enough to know their jobs inside and out and could take small breaks while keeping an eye on their progress.

Catra still wondered why the vague description of a “signal” would be enough to not only spark a meeting with all of the leaders, but to send a team out to check. Something wasn’t adding up and she looked to Bow, believing the engineer knew more than he let on. Before she could voice her question, a minor change pinged on her screen. Near their destination, where there used to be one faint glow of green, there were now three. She leaned in slightly, being thorough to make sure it wasn’t a trick of the screen.

“Entrapa, you said you fine tuned this thing. Does that mean it would be more accurate?” she asked dubiously. She nodded her large head of hair, coming to view why she asked before having a look of worry on her face.

“Guys, there’s more than one signal being picked up now” she warned.

Bow frowned, approaching them to see what was happening. He pinched his thumb and forefinger over the map to zoom in. The scan showed a topographical map, easier to see elevation than actual borders of the landscape the flew over. He used the tips of his fingers to measure an area in the mountains to where the surrounding dots were. If he was checking the distance from Brimeda to each marker, they were outside of the city's perimeter

but not by the grand measurement they had estimated before. Catra watched the lock tighten on his composure.

“What are those?” she asked directly, looking to him and then Adora. Bow let out a discontent breath.

“They could be clones of Prime”.

Entrapta looked unbothered, Catra turned back over her shoulder to look at Adora who held her lips in a hard line as if his information was an insult to her.

“How long have we known about this?” Catra asked, now dropping her hand into her lap. She wanted her words to have some dig to them, though it was also her own fault she hadn't gone to a meeting in quite a while. Adora’s focus fizzled to meet her face.

“Not long, we knew the signal could have been a few different things” Adora insisted “but if there's more…”

“They’re multiplying” Entrapta concluded in awe, marveling at the concept. Bow's dark brown furrowed, looking like he wanted to say that wasn't a possibility but the honest truth of them not knowing held him back.

"What we can do is land in a clearing near Brimeda, then split. Two of us go to town to ask around and two check the surrounding area for signs of what we're dealing with" the full confidence in his plan laid out for the group to consider.

Catra couldn't bring herself to agree, only painted with a disapproving look. "If it *is* something along the lines of a clone resurgence, I don't think we should split up. The last thing we need is for half of us to get killed or chipped."

Without lifting her hand, she felt the phantom sensation on the back of her neck where the tech had dug into her, pulling the strings of her nerves like she was a puppet. As twisted as it was, being under the control of the chip was brutal but slightly cathartic. It didn't give her the feeling of completeness that the sinister man preached but it did make her feel wrapped in a sense of weightlessness, perhaps because her actions were her own. It was when Adora showed up that the pull was strong enough to realize she couldn't do it and sent her crashing back. Without the damage to the chip and seeing the familiar angles and softness of her face, Catra wondered if she would have been lost forever.

If it were even a possibility that the same thing could be done to Adora, Catra would fight until her death to prevent it.

Adora sent the scans back to Bright Moon to update Glimmer while Bow made changes to their plan of entry. Realizing she had a point, they discussed further and came to the decision that they would land and the four of them would check the town together, confirming that the inhabitants were all safe. The craft cut through the sky as their travel time ticked on. Looking down and beginning to see the massive canyons and sprawling dry

landscape of the mountain's massive faces showed them in pairing with the radar that they were close. There were no flat plains of field to land the ship, but Bow managed to find a plateau that seemed to meet their needs in terms of size and stability.

Once they had landed and the faint sounds of the landing gear locking to keep them in place sounded off, they all rose from their seats. They had made efficient travel, arriving just around noon. Arriving at midday would be helpful in assuring the town that they were there to help on behalf of the Rebellion’s post war clean up efforts. A ship towering over the town at sunrise or dusk could have been enough to panic some of the terrible things some of the occupied villages had gone through at the hands of the Horde.

While the others closed down their stations, Catra took her leave to visit her room one last time before they would soon depart to head for the more populated areas. Her mapping system was better left running to have real time updates to the objects they were tracking, even as it sat idle.

The idea of a resurgence of chipping and innocent civilians having their mind controlled against their will made her stomach churn. She had done a lot of wrong in her life and after living the invasive experience herself, she wouldn’t wish it on anyone. Her fur raised at the thought of manipulative hands dipping their unnaturally smooth claws into her most private memories and emotions just to tug at the strings as they wished.

She brushed her hands against the panel outside of her door, cuing the door to slide open. Her heart was beginning to race at the prospect of what they could be facing once they left the safe space of the ship. While she was confident and ready to get back

into the action, the hushed call from the bottle she had stashed inside of her bag assured her it would help tone down her nerves and keep her level enough for her friends to do the job they had been sent here for. She wrapped her fingers around the bottle after reaching around blindly in her bag, then unscrewing its cap and swallowing down a hurried mouthful.

Catra exhaled, recapping and feeling the radiation of the drink cover her in what felt like fake armor. Melog peered a squinted eye up at her, feeling the mix of emotions that were overtaken by her temporary fix.

Chapter Seven

Chapter Summary

> In the travels to Brimeda, Catra is already self aware that her presence may not be an entirely welcomed one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The red donned navigator took a relaxed walk down the ramp and off the ship to join the rest of her party. Bowling them inside, the expanse of walls of mountains more dramatic than the ones of Bright Moon holding them cradled within their confines. The colors were the more natural shades of greens and browns with the pounded surface of the main road laid etched within sight. Clearly near the ends of the brush that their ship had landed near, the area was close enough to see how to access the main paths of travel without being a nuisance and blocking the entire road with the behemoth of a craft.

Entrapta was already buying herself with samples of the soil near the landing area with small beeps and tapping coming from the tablet she controlled in her hand.

Noticing their last member stroll out, Bow addressed his friends, "Great, let's get to town and see if these people have noticed anything strange going on".

Catra was glad to have the extra time to wall and prepare herself before meeting another town's worth of people.

She used to love traveling the world. They were finally doing the things they would dream of as kids, but things aren't always so simple. Especially after a mass amount of blood was shed at her own hand, both directly and indirectly. For each town that would recognize her from the exaggerated description of the clawed she-devil who commanded the legions that destroyed the lives of communities and was hell bent on taking the world down with her, she attached herself to the hope that each village or full scale down they arrived at were so far out of the loop that maybe they hadn't heard the horror stories.

In the Horde, she had heard it all and decided that as far as words were concerned, nothing could hurt her.

Shadow Weaver had conditioned her for that. Even admitted herself that she said and did the things of the past to make Catra stronger.

Every taunt and snide comment on her mutant colored eyes or unkempt bushel of hair from other cadets, both senior and her peers, was a new chain she added to her armor.

They could say whatever the fuck they wanted but at the end of the day, she was finally their Captain. Then the second in command.

Now that she was just Catra, that broad block was torn away and each bladed word slashed at her harshly while she helped it rip

herself apart.

The first town was Salineas, Mermista's home. They gave extra aid and worked on a new Sea Gate restructuring, with Catra eager and nervous to lend a hand.

She was unsure if her name hadn't been mentioned to some of the councilors in Mermista’s cabinet, but around the second day was when Catra noticed the clear pattern of avoidance from any workers outside of the princesses or Bow. She had noticed what she thought were faces of disgust that spread among the people of the oceanic city whenever she spoke, but didn't want to bring it to anyone's attention, fearing it was all in her head.

That second day was when she had been trusted by Adora to be the lead onsite with the plans for the new gate. Just directing and keeping the materials straight until Bow could return in a few hours.

One of the larger construction workers had waited for a clear moment, before others had gone for a break before seizing Catra by her neck and slamming her against the concealed corner of a wall near the heaps of beams and mixed concrete material around them. The dust had only added to the pressure squeezing her throat smaller and smaller as she pried at the massive gloved hands with her claws.

Her frantic eyes flashing in anger as she kicked while her feet had been lifted too far for her to find purchase.

"*Not so fucking tough now, are ya Horde scum*?" the scar on his lower lip lunging upward in satisfaction.

She could feel frenzy turn into a slowed pulse throughout her head as it lost oxygen. The pressure behind her eyes mounted as her vision took a slight pitch of gray and her erratic movements calmed. With the energy quickly funneling out of her body, she gave one more attempt at a swing with her foot. Thankfully with her dexterous reach, she was able to swing just far enough to walk one foot to his torso and connect the bottom of her other heel to his face. The unclasped his monstrous hand from her neck as her lungs burned and eyes watered to pull greedily in, fighting saliva and coughing as she dropped, still hunched on the ground.

From the blur of her stressed eyes, she could see he was returning to strike again before the sounds of someone coming down the steps made him pause. He gave one glance to the crumpled mess before abandoning her to hold the attention of the newcomers. Catra fought the urge to lurch and empty the few contents of her stomach, still feeling the blood trying to return to its normal flow throughout her soon to be bruised neck.

"*Ah, the mighty Tech Master! Yes you just missed the crew but the progress we've made has been astounding with the guidance of your plans.*" his voice boistered throughout the dips and columns of the sizable balconies. Catra couldn't hear Bow's side of the conversation, it was held at a normal volume and she was still coming to her senses as she swayed from one side as she stepped one of her feet up to stand.

She doubted that Bow, or anyone had ever found out about the interaction he had just missed by seconds. By the time she found her footing and was capable of walking herself, her attacker had already led Bow off to discuss more structural integrity tests they could run on the new wall and gate.

She wished she would have said something instead of crying in her room on the ship that night and pulling nervously to add to the height of her collar for the next few weeks.

Bow had later asked where she had been, causing Catra to worry that he had brought it up to Adora and prompting the her to go off on him.

"I needed to take a damn break, okay?"

The next town had been in some region of the far off rainforests, she had felt guilty she couldn't even remember its name even after the terror she had spread there. She had gone with Glimmer and Adora to search and secure a specific piece of First One's tech. At the approach and descent of the ship, Catra could see a small trickle of people run towards them in excitement as they recognized the symbols on the sides of the ship. The unmistakable pride in Queen Glimmer and She-Ra's faces pulled a hint of jealousy up to her surfaces briefly before she pushed it back into its place. They landed, children swarmed the pair in adoration as the cheers called throughout the neverending forests around them.

Then Catra followed after them and one by one, the smiles on the young faces dropped as they whispered and began to back away and alert their friends before the gleeful scene was now a hushed stand off of a few hundred people.

Adora addressed the crowd, seeing the sink of Catra's ears. She looked like the same scared kid who got caught in Shadow Weaver's sanctum all those years ago. The crowd watched and listened to her, but gave unsure glances to Catra as if she were a beast that would lash out at any moment. Adora held Catra's hand, the latter feeling a mix of assurance and the air of putting on a show. It was a feeling that made her want to walk right back into the ship and leave. Adora promised that the world was changing for better and that they were there to help.

An ambitious and inspirational speech that pulled more cheers from the impressive group.

The entire week they were there, any time they had to interact with the town it made Catra turn into stone. Glimmer and Adora were met with warm welcomes and home cooked meals, wrapped in tidy cloths. Catra was not met with anything beyond a cold stare and being told she must leave.

She couldn't blame them.

Adora forgave her because of their past.

Glimmer forgave her because she had helped her escape Prime's ship.

She had done nothing but hurt these people and things like that sometimes could never be forgiven.

After enough experiences where Catra was emotionally beaten down or sometimes met with a real beating, she decided she would take a hiatus on Bright Moon. Thought at Glimmer's insistence, which led her to believe that she may have overheard some of the awful things being said about her.

Adora had only been privy to one incident. She had found a large purple blot of a bruise on her bicep, mostly hidden by fur where someone had thrown an "accidental" elbow into her while they traveled through town. She cradled the arm, brushing it with the tips of her fingers as she interrogated Catra at bed time.

"*Must have been from running into one of the crates in the bay*" she chuckled lightly.

She wondered if Adora found it easier to go on the excursions without her. The blonde powerhouse could do what she had to without worry and without her little fuck up of a girlfriend there to bring her down like old times.

Catra was determined to do what they had to on this mission as efficiently as possible. Even if efficient meant that she would be less prominent at the forefront with the team.

While the four of them tread from the dry grass near the ship to the opened flatness of the main road, it was as if Adora could read her mind already. She held up, letting Catra and Melog catch up to where she walked behind the other two.

"You alright?" she asked, giving her best effort trying to not make assumptions. Catra lifted her eyebrows, knowing that she already knew what her answer would be.

She wondered if the scent of liquor had faded from her breath.

"All good here" Catra assured, unable to mask the defeated tone in her voice that sounded something like sarcasm. Adora looked forward, as if the path they walked would reveal the perfect words to say.

"If something comes up and you don't feel comfortable, please tell me".

Catra threw a glance at her, almond eyes narrowing. "Why would I not feel comfortable?" she challenged, daring Adora to add more. The baby blue of her eyes just lingered before darting away again.

"I hope you *do* feel comfortable, I'm just saying I hope you would tell me" she clarified, not willing to waiver to Catra's bluff at a confrontation. The tell alone was enough to let Adora know that the uncaring attitude that her girlfriend tried to present was just an act.

Catra bit her figurative tongue, she wanted to throw sarcasm right into her face but she was just trying to help. She had grown so paranoid and defensive over the years to think that every

extension of help was some cleverly coated dig at what a failure she was. She would have loved to take another swig right now but would settle for a discreet breath, letting her formulate the words she was about to spew before she aired them.

Instead she just appeased her with a nod. The conversation between the two was low enough that Bow and Entrapa hadn't seemed like they had heard.

She wanted to fit into the puzzle that was Adora's life but it felt like she was just an awkwardly shaped piece that wasn't meant to have space in her heroic acts around Etheria. Maybe if she had done better to leave with her the first or second time Adora begged her to come with her, she would fit in more comfortably. The entire ordeal could have been spared and lives left intact.

She would never stop trying to shave off those gnarled pieces of her to give her the clean fit back into her life though.

The city before them had a different type of architecture than any place she had seen before. Similar to the wastes, the buildings looked coated in stucco and the dried browns of dirt proved strong enough to house multiple stories for each block of town they passed. The spread out simple homes changed in favor of high level shops with cloth awnings holding themselves over the street. Brimeda was tidy, people quietly walking along the streets that were lined by sharp inclines of mountains around the curves of the street.

The impressive scene around her made Catra forget about her small existence for a bit, feeling content in her own skin to just exist in the same world with features as astonishing as these. Spires of stoney layers posted around the edges of the sprawl.

For the first time she thought it may have been a bit quicker if Glimmer had come and could have abracadabra'd them to the town's center to get it over with. Sightseeing was nice but the pit in her stomach was about to swallow her whole. The people kept to their own sides if the street and the few children with their parents seemed well behaved and quiet for it being the middle of a beautiful day.

Whether it was out of politeness or just a cultural way of keeping their noses down, not many seemed to notice the group. Many cities and their populace were familiar with the shining knight She-Ra and knew who the Princesses were. Even without Queen Glimmer, it wasn't unexpected to be pointed out and have a swarm of gleeful citizens fly over like a flock of birds.

Only a few eyes seemed to double take their presence currently. For each look, Catra felt body tense more.

They reached the city center that held up a mid sized staircase up to what appeared to the capitol building. The natural juts of the stone pillars created swooping arches that were nowhere near symmetrical but still demanded authority. Guards lined the building in their pinned burnt orange colors and stern faces. Looking like the real life versions of small soldiers she had seen children play with, they kept a hardened grip on the lances at their sides. While their gaze remained fixed and unmoving, it was clear that they were very aware of the four new visitors.

The man standing directly in front of the door was dressed in similar apparel, with a few more pins and patches adorning the side of his jacket and a more defined fitting snug to the clean cut hair under it.

"State your business" his gruff tone commanded as they approached.

Adora took the reins. "The Rebellion is here in regards to concerns the King has with the end of the war".

Her answer was concise but left out enough details to not worry anyone who wasn't aware of the news of the now multiple possible chippings.

The hold of expression on what was exposed on his face left little to be read. Before he could validate their claims, a chipper older voice pulled the four sets of eyes from the block of the guard.

A smaller, portly man in a well tailored suit stepped up to the side of the watchman. "You must be She- Ra and the representative from Bright Moon. Welcome to Brimeda, we are so happy to have you!" He greeted fondly as he offered a large hand to shake. The gleaming eyes from behind his spectacles looked up from Adora, to Entrapta who offered a brief wave, then Bow, and finally pausing on Catra. His eyes weren't hostile but something about the shift in him made her match his frozen stare. At the sound of Adora's voice again, he snapped back to life.

"We came as soon as we could. Queen Glimmer sends her word that this issue will be looked into quickly and thoroughly" Adora assured. The confidence in her voice was enough to draw faith from anyone who hadn't had it previously. She looked and sounded like the most capable, sound person to have on your side in a time of need. The shorter man led them inside, past the security and through the detailed elongated doors with Catra being the last of the group to enter.

While he controlled the pace, he introduced himself as the lead of King's court while he led them through the main hall at the sounds of their echoing footsteps. Entrapa's pigtails swayed as her head panned from one wall to another in fascination. Her mouth moved silently as if she were muttering something about the dates about the architecture herself under her breath.

The light that beamed through made the hall look like it was an inviting glow on orange. The brown exposed beams on the ceilings far above them remained above them as the courtier led them down several halls.

Catra caught his eyes turning back to her several times when he hadn’t thought she was paying attention. He turned to the group in the middle of the next stretch of passages.

“I cannot express to you how grateful we are for all you have done and continue to do for us.” he began, clearing his throat “but before we meet with the King, I have to say I think that a smaller audience would be a wise idea.”

Adora made a face, looking back at her small group.

“Smaller audience? There’s only four of us. We’re all important to the function and success of this search.” It wasn’t the first time she had to try to keep her politeness when she wanted to hammer it into everyone’s mind that She- Ra was no more important than anyone else on her team. Nobody was to be left behind just to rise her up onto a pedestal. The man’s face fall, taking on a more stern look than the friendly one they had been met with. His shoulders dropped before taking the approach at his request again.

“Please understand that we have been fortunate enough to not have experienced as much direct terror from the war as our sister cities have. We pride ourselves on that and would like to keep it that way. Our people must remain safe,” he leaned slightly to gesture towards Catra “with one of your associates having been involved so heavily-”

“In the past” Adora interjected before Catra could open her mouth. The welcoming man they had met at the door was now a much more serious official, clearly not impressed with the presence she had before him. “She’s been with the Rebellion for some time now and has been vital to ending the war”.

“A war she helped start and escalate" he added, causing Catra’s face to turn sullen.

There wasn’t anything she could say to refute the things she had done. Even arguing against it seemed to confirm the hostilities people already viewed of her. Adora was visibly becoming more impatient with the man.

While Catra didn’t start the war, the other points he made were difficult to diffuse.

She *had* escalated. She *had* hurt people. She had nearly been successful in ending the world.

Adora fought against these counters, even after he informed her that the King of Brimeda had been very interested in the progression of the war and was aware of every city, every Horde defeat, and every move made by the opposing generals and commanders. Not only did he know who Horde Captain Catra was, he knew in great detail every military campaign she had been apart of. She didn’t say a word.

“If we can’t go in together, maybe it’s better we meet with your leader through holo-comms?” Adora suggested. “I’m not leaving anyone behind”.

He gave a light hearted smile, irked but impressed at the famous convictions he had heard that she held. “Had we known before who exactly was a part of the aid, we may have suggested other avenues.”

“Adora,” Catra intervened, causing everyone to look in her direction “it's fine.”

Her eyes lowered, looking firm at her partner. “Catra, no it’s not. If the King wants the Rebellion's assistance and wants to meet, he can meet with all of us or none of us.”

“We’re all on the same side, there is no threat from anyone in the Rebellion. That is what we’re here to protect everyone from.” Bow added, trying to diffuse the rising tension. Adora had already folded her arms, beginning her next arguments to try and make the man fall in line.

Again, Catra silenced them. There was no point to have this argument when their minds were already made up, it would just make them look disagreeable on her behalf. “I’ll just…check the maps on the ship. Make sure nothing new has pinged since our arrival while you guys are in there. Then you guys meet me back there?” her bare feet already stepping away. If she didn’t make the call, she knew it would only escalate into a shouting match and there was already enough to worry about.

The courier's round face looked pleased, a smug smile formed from getting his way. Adora’s irritability shifted to troubled as she watched Catra break from the group. “Catra…” she tested one more time. She could understand that the call was a gaguge and it prompted her to put on an upbeat face, semi-smile of indifference and even moved her tail intentionally to look as though this was what she had preferred the plan be anyway.

“Seriously, go. It’s fine, I’m good. Get the info and we’ll all check in later.” she assured, fighting back any breaks in her voice. If anything showed right now, she knew that Adora would call it off until they worked through the impasse. She couldn’t just deny help, and it couldn’t be at the fault of Catra again. She gave a small wave then looked to Bow and Entrapta. “Just keep me posted and I’ll…see you all when you’re out”.

Once she was a far enough distance away, the doors to the King’s Great Hall and the echoed knocking of doors closing was wrapped with the distant voices introducing the group before the closing of the door severed all sounds from within.

When the door shut, the weight came crashing down on her again. While she walked, her pace picked up to get her out of the capital and out of the town.

Of course these people didn’t forget. She wouldn’t forgive either and at the state she was in, there was no way she would allow herself to ask for leniency.

Walking back to the craft without the rest of her squad made her feel more self conscious than she had on the way in. Those who spotted them coming in and a lone magicat coming out probably knew exactly what the cause was and just how unwanted she was. She was aware of it herself even though she tried to bury it down within her.

She knew the appearance of her face was not a friendly one. Catra knew she looked just like the disgruntled, angry woman they all knew she was but she didn’t have the strength within her to pretend to be anything else. The more she walked, the more

she felt the pieces within her break. A carousel of feelings barraged her as she hurried out of the town, now moving down the path and almost to the tall, dry grasses and large rock formations around the ship. She didn't give a fuck anyway.

She didn't care if they knew her, hated her, or wanted her dead. They would have to get in line because those were things she knew and wished upon herself daily. She had been foolish to think that she could just move right into the group and they can all save the world together.

She prodded the key numbers in on the pad, unlocking and allowing the ramp to drop and let her in. Her strides hadn't even made it half way up the ramp before Melog greeted her. Their tail whipping and flaring as the uneased state that Catra was in spread. Instead of turning left to the controls she turned right towards her room. Towards her bottle she kept. Towards some form of relief of being in her own skin.

The door slid open with a hiss, her paired pet following close behind, trying to look at her face. Small mewls called to her, the abstract thoughts flowed to her mind as he peppered her with questions.

"*Hurt*?" Melog asked. She shook her head, digging both arms into her bag to grab her liquor. "*Mad*?" they tried again.

She shook her head, unsure of how to answer. She spun the lid off, inhaling the air around her before meeting the bottle to her lips. Taking a long, flowing swig she let it settle within her. "No, I

don’t know what I am. I- they just don’t trust me.” she looked down at the curious eyes. She took another sip, relieved that there was nothing reflective enough in the room to mirror the image of a monster back to her.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter was a little slow going but the next one is going to have more going on so thank you for your patience!

Catra is going to slam that bottle but Adora will come in later to check on her.

Thank you for reading :)

Chapter Eight

Chapter Summary

> A disparaged Catra finds solace in a midday drink before being checked in on by Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Over half of a bottle in, Catra was feeling much better as she swirled the liquor around the inside of its glass hold. The honey appearance chased itself in a syntrophic motion, absorbing all of her attention as she now lay down on the upper mattress in her room. The taste of her buzz was faintly drifting, the sharp wisp of the door sliding its metal open made her lazily drag her eyes over to see the reds and yellows of her girlfriend's stance at the opening.

Her feet swept over, Adora lowered her hand to pet Melog's dozing forehead that lay resting on the bottom bunk. Once she was level with the bed frame her eyes tugged from a quick study of Catra's state to seeing the bottle held loosely in her hand. The magicat gave a tight smile and stiff wave from her aloof position.

Adora rested her forearms on the mat Catra lay on, leaning into her. "Turning in for the night?" her golden head cocking slightly.

"Yup" Catra answered with a pop. If she was supposed to feel more sheepish about being caught drinking alone, it was lost on her. That evading feeling of happiness seemed to sit with her

comfortably now as she sat considerably under the influence. Adora bit at the inside of her cheek.

"Um, so they asked that we wait until tomorrow to start talking to the locals so they have a chance to acclimate to the presence of another ship landing".

"Another ship landing…" Catra copied her words back slowly. Adora's face tensed.

"Are you okay?" she asked, clearly not comfortable with how she was managing whatever issue she was trying to avoid. "Sorry about the King's people, they're just still really freaked out but it doesn't give them an excuse to treat you like that".

Her sun and moon eyes closed before rolling with the turn of her head to open in Adora's direction. "I am doing great" she assured in a sarcastic slur "I would do the same thing if it were me. Don't want the Horde blazing the place up again, right?" she tipped the bottle to her chest at the mention of her past affiliation.

Adora could see the zig zag of where her mood was heading, working to get ahead of it like she used to with Shadow Weaver when they were younger.

"They'll see tomorrow, you're doing the right thing" her soft voice assured as she reached for the Catra's hand. Holding the bottle in

her right and resting her hand inside of Adora's, she felt rattled but complacent thanks to her drink.

"You know what's *great* Adora? Even if the whole She-Ra thing wasn't a factor, these people would have still loved you the moment you switched over." she nodded, then glancing over to see the look of confusion on Adora's face.

"What do you-?"

"Think about it. You leave the Horde before all that mess. You don't lead the whole push. Your face isn't the one they have nightmares about or have burned into their minds. They would still welcome you as you are even if you just defected." she added, clearing her throat and taking another sip while Adora let her words digest.

"Catra, we can't change what happened. You're here now though."

"That's the thing, I'm *sort of* here. But nobody wants that" her hands flipping like she was giving a talking down to a stranger.

"I want that" Adora's hand held tighter, her blue eyes flipped to the bottle and back. "Put that away too, that isn't helping".

Catra moved before Adora even had time to reach for the bottle, still quick enough in speed to beat her but less gracious in her movements and causing the alcohol to splash around in the bottle and spray loose drops from its opening.

"I know you always say that Adora but that's who you are. You're always saving people and now here you are, *saving* Catra" her voice dipping at the mention of her own name like an insult. She laughed at herself. "You ever wonder if Catra is a lost cause at this point?". Her playful self-deprecating jabs tilted in emotion now, feeling the same lingering weight pull her down again. Now out in the open were words that swirled with her on a constant rotation but never thought she would voice aloud.

"Stop" Adora demanded, letting her stronger tone pull Catra from her pity party. Her mouth pulled down further into a frown, now feeling worse about herself for making Adora cater to her rambling again. She looked at the wall, eyes unable to keep focus on one spot but doing anything she could to not look at her girlfriend.

"I'm sorry." she said after a long pause "I just…I try. And I keep trying and it's like its never enough" her voice fully opposed to the joking insults she was pulling on herself moments ago. She cleared her throat, "I'm trying not to ruin us like I ruin everything else".

From her position at the side of the bunk, Adora stretched up onto her toes and moved her hand to Catra's to pull her half sat up form into her for an embrace. Only one of her arms could reach but the hold was strong enough that Catra let her and rested her forehead on her shoulder. Adora rested back flat on her feet,

returning her hold to Catra's hand and bringing her chin to the bed, letting her lips rest near their intertwined fingers.

"Nothing is ruined Catra. But you can't keep doing this to yourself" she begged, fighting back tears as her voice tried to seize in her throat.

Perhaps it was the fault of her drinking, but while she was prepared for another breakdown, it felt like the final dam that held the release back was devoid of anything to give. Only the feeling of further berating herself remained in her mind but it was something she wouldn't put Adora through. Whenever she voiced her feelings like this she felt terrible for making The Chosen One feel like she wasn't doing enough. She knew that Adora would light herself on fire to keep everyone else warm. It's why it was so much easier to just not mention when she started having those feelings again.

Before she could murmur her usual *"I know"*, Adora was already wondering out loud if she had been gone too much and that eventually things would slow down but she could make more time for them to be together so she didn't feel so lonely.

"Look, I'm sorry I brought it up. I didn't mean- I didn't want to start this" her velvety voice walking itself back to try and take some of the brunt off of Adora. She could feel the coldness wash over her again as she tried to build her wall back up to keep her girlfriend safe from her avalanche of issues. Already regretting their conversation that was in full force forward, the next question felt like her body slamming into a solid wall.

“Do you drink a lot when I’m not here?” her face was direct and serious as she asked.

Catra couldn’t force a sound to come out as she shook her head in disbelief like it was fired from out of nowhere.

“No, today was just a rough one”.

Adora studied her face, the dots on her cheek up to her dipped eyebrows that defied her by matching her look back.

“Tell me the truth”.

Catra hesitated, lying to Adora was the last thing she wanted to do when all she had given her was full support. “A couple times a month maybe” she admitted quietly, her ears lowering slightly. Adora didn’t seem impressed but looked as though she accepted the answer. Had she been braver she could have been more forthcoming. The tip of her head enhanced the tired dark circles under her eyes.

Today was rough. Last week was rough. The night she came home from Glimmer’s game night was rough. Last month was okay, but sometimes at night when she fought for rest it felt like reason enough to grab a drink. It was like the days between grew shorter. It had gone from socially grabbing something small, to mixing something to numb a panic attack, to having one whenever she wanted to escape any feeling.

It could have been denial, but Catra hadn't realized until now when she had to face it head on that the amount of times she had tried to take the edge off with a glass or bottle had somehow tumbled out of control without her even noticing it. Dinner together wasn't the first time she had drank herself nearly to a stupor, it was just one of the first times Adora had been home to witness it.

"I can stay here tonight" her eyes giving full compassion as she waited for Catra to respond. She shook her head, now noticing the sickening melt of guilt within her.

"I'm fine, really" Catra paired with a forced smile that could win her awards in acting.

"Catra…"

The short haired woman passed the bottle down to Adora, a gesture of defeat. "No, its okay. I know you have data to send back and I don't want everyone to think you're in here consoling me about King Dipshit or something".

Then tension broke when Adora let a giggle escape, making Catra feel like the guilt was being forgiven for each second the smile remained on her lips.

“You’re such a dork” she whispered, holding the bottle secure in her hand and a genuine look of care warming through her shining eyes. “I love you, I’ll come back later to check on you. Try not to throw up all over.”

"Love you too" she returned, blinking softly and letting their hands slide away from one another when Adora left the bedside with the close to finished bottle.

Adora leaving the room felt like the air had gone with her. Talking to her usually made Catra feel better but tonight made her feel more like the burden she believed she was.

The buzzed elation was now deflated and left her feeling empty again. Her mouth turned to a harsh frown, pressing her lips firmly together like that would have any chance at stopping her own mind.

"Should have kept that last bit…" she thought, mentally kicking herself.

With the depressant working with her already disparaged mind, all of the anxieties that creeped at the edges were ready to take center stage. She was already uncertain that she was deserving of being forgiven in the first place, but instead of keeping that at the forefront of her mind, her surreptitious drive to get out of her own mind for even a short period.

The first time she drank in excess, she would be left feeling like she was flying, confidence pouring from her and feeling like that was who she was meant to be before life beat her down. That feeling was the one she chased from then on, in competition with how being with Adora made her feel. With her, she felt wanted but it easily extinguished when she wasn't around her. Drinks were much easier to keep around for long periods of time and they were never too busy to give her the sense of ease and fun freely.

She slid her body off the side of the bed and lowered herself down to the floor. Her legging covered limbs caught herself as she shuffled off balance. She had grown more tolerant the more she drank but wasn't immune to the effects of standing up quickly after a hearty amount drank in such a short time span. Her relaxed body tried to straighten, holding the metal pole that supported the top bunk for support as her face looked to the door.

Feeling like it was a full on mission, she let out a laugh that made Melog look at her in surprise before she cleared her throat and forced her steps forward. Seeing most of her friends drunk before, she knew that she wasn't usually a happy or sad type when she started drinking. Thankfully, she wasn't one looking to pick a fight either. It was like she just became a person without worries or past baggage and as long as she kept that feeling, then everything would be fine.

Without stumbling she focused to control her movements to seem more natural when she left for the hallway. Her plan was to use the restroom, clean herself up a little bit, then grab a bite before retreating back to her room. Knowing that Adora would be occupied for the next hour and Entrapta was probably prepping

for tomorrow, Catra knew it would be easy work to get back to her room without having to interact with anyone.

The restroom was close to her room, a clear shot. After relieving herself and having a session of prolonged staring at her reflection in the mirror, she washed up and mulled over that she hoped there were toaster pastries in the kitchenette. Swooping out of the bathroom and turning she let out a hard breath when she ran straight into the steadily walking Bow. The two collided their shoulders when he was unable to move from her sudden appearance.

“Oh man, I’m sorry Catra” he apologized while putting his hands up in a gesture that looked as if he would catch her body that moved faster than her feet could match.

Her wide eyes gave off a look of startlement before resetting. She was unsure if she had let out a yelp when they hit. “My bad, I wasn’t paying attention” she shook her head, ready to keep moving on.

From her darting eyes and slowed speech, he could tell instantly that she wasn’t sober. He looked at her like he was looking at some great misfortune unfold in front of him. “Just a heads up that tomorrow for the search, I told Adora you and I could take the perimeter outside of town”.

Catra wasn’t in the mood to listen or plan anything. The only priority in her mind being to grab food then get back to turn herself into a semi-decent person in Adora's eyes.

“Yeah, okay. Sounds good” abruptly attempting to blow him off. Among other things, Catra knew Bow was a commendable friend. He wasn't going to let her go that easily. His features pulled into something mixed of care and wish to take action.

"Are you…alright?" His tentative voice tested Catra's muddied waters. Not wanting to oversell and out her condition, she shut her eyes and nodded with a tight lined almost smile.

"Never better."

He pulled a hand to scratch awkwardly at the back of his neck, considering what he should do to keep things civil. "I was about to grab a drink…if you want one?". He chose his words carefully but not so selective to evade a word that made her eyes spring open in surprise that he might have some spirits of his own stowed away on board.

Noticing the look on her face, the tech master edited himself, "A nice cup of tea before bed just helps me unwind". The two had already begun matching steps before he made the clarification and she had already wordlessly agreed to walk with him.

'*For fucksake Bow, you had me there'* she chuckled to herself while letting a stifled laugh slip. She was too giddy to care about her original plan being immediately thwarted and did her best to walk in a straight line.

"Tea tastes like shit" she objected, every filter she had at this point was either gone or wavering greatly.

"Maybe a nice glass of water then…" he mumbled under his breath. His always bare midriff showing through his clothing as he stepped in front of her into the kitchen. The lights above them automatically flashed on when their motion was sensed and Catra half slid and half collapsed herself at one of the taller seats at the island counter. Bow took the responsibility of grabbing her a glass while he retrieved his own mug and the dispenser began brewing. He flipped a cupboard door open with one hand to set his box of tea down from the semi-matted chrome cabinets, then checked the silverware drawer for his steeper.

Before he could fill and place the drink in front of her, she had already slunk herself back to her feet and began rummaging through the taller cabinet she knew to be storing loose snacks. The plastic crinkled under the uncoordinated attacks from her fingers as she grabbed a small packet of crackers she pulled from a clear bin. Her mouth crunched on while Bow prepped his tea. She kept one leg planted firmly on the ground and the other bent to keep her chair swaying while she ate.

Quick snack out here, little drink of water then she'd dash. The lack of crumbs in bed would be bonus points.

Typically reveling in long silences and awkward pauses, she was feeling a little more chatty since she had something on her stomach now.

"Did Sparkles get you into tea drinking?" she asked while shifting a mouthful of chewed cracker. Bow glanced over his shoulder, the sound of a spoon tapping against porcelain preluding him.

"My dads were pretty big on it growing up. Glimmer just turned me onto different varieties" once his kettle was set to boil, he filled her clear glass with a hiss from the sink. He set it in front of her, now seemingly having the permission to look at her directly without her critique.

"She seems like the type. I dunno. She's alright though" Catra chewed through her compliment. Bow chuckled, shaking his head. He knew he didn't want to enable her.

He smirked before scooping tea from its container. "I think she's pretty alright too".

Catra looked at her picked over bag of snacks. Her all or nothing attitude pulled her to blurt "When did you know?".

"About me and Glimmer?"

"Yeah…well whe- how did you know you were *enough* for her?" she looked up at him from her seat. He leaned back against the counter behind him.

"I still wonder if I am sometimes to be honest" he confessed "she's a Queen, renowned sorceress, and esteemed veteran from the Rebellion and Princess Alliance. I used to feel like I didn't measure up because I'm just some guy".

If Catra was more focused, she would have found it hard to believe this was the guy she had plans to kidnap and torture after the Princess Prom.

"Do you still, ya know…think that?" she sniffed, reaching for her clear glass.

Bow shrugged. "Hard not to sometimes. But we all have our worth and we don't have to prove it one hundred percent of the time to know it's real".

Taking a drink tasted beyond bland in comparison to what she had been tasting for the duration of the evening. "But when they give one hundred and sixty percent all the time…I don't- I-".

She interrupted her own words, opting to cut herself off until she found what it was she wanted to say. The twisting expression on her face rose in frustration and she stood up, leaving the half sipped glass on the counter. Bow scrambled to think of something to say.

"Catra, hey wait…".

"If you tell me some version of 'I'm sorry', I'm gonna lose it" she threatened, teetering her head loosely back at him. Her hand snaked to the wrapper, giving him just enough time to plead whatever case it was he was trying to pitch.

Bow hesitated before pushing through. "We're all really glad you joined the Rebellion. If you don't believe it when Adora says it, you should reconsider that she wouldn't just say it for nothing".

Catra stood, looking down to the floor and scuffing it gently with her foot. Tossing the trash into the bin, it made her stomach flip to hear the words she easily managed to push away, coming from anyone besides Adora.

"I'll uh…see you in the morning" she murmured quietly before departing for her room.

She thanked the gods she had left the room before Entrapa came in, lately it felt like she was making rounds to talk to all of them when she would prefer to keep her business under tight lock and key. Spilling her heart to Adora was enough and in the morning she would add her stupid self-conscious babbling to her list of things to be ashamed of about herself. At least a smile or thank you would have been a gesture to show her appreciation. But she wasn't operating in the head space she usually lived in.

The water and food felt like it had just brought new vitality to her drunkenness, though it was more realistically brought on by the

alcohol having enough time to reach the desired receptors in her body from the time she had laid down. Her tipsy conscious yearn to start calling down the tight corridors for Adora. She had enough control to scold herself for that poor idea.

'*Pull it together, dummy…*' she ordered herself.

Her brief trip down the hall felt like an all day event. As soon as her door opened, licks of blue flame like energy from Melog greeted her as they nuzzled into the curves of her leg.

"I'm stealing your spot" her words mushed together. There was no way she was going to climb that fucking bunk when a perfectly good and prewarmed one was here and waiting. She tossed herself into the cove of the lower mattress, quickly followed by Melog who snuggled and seemed to be matching her same lax mood.

The room already began to feel like how sitting on a spinning out skiff would, glee in her stomach and unfightable grin on her face. She wished the feeling would stay with her all the time. People were just able to feel this good naturally, and that thought was inconceivable to her.

She let the lids of her eyes close, the light of the room still off but would be to time out on its own if neither moved. The warmth of Melog and a soft purr she wasn't sure was from herself or from them began to work its lulling magic against the part of her that worked to stay up and wait for her gorgeous girlfriend to come back.

'*Just a few minutes, sleep off a bit then good as new*' she thought to herself, nodding along to her own thoughts against her pillow.

She was uncertain how long her "few minutes" actually was. What she did know was that when she woke up, she was no longer flat on the bed curled with Melog. Her legs were sloped over Adora's hand while the other held her back with her arms supporting her slumped back. Adora had already made it to the hall and almost back to her own room before Catra had pulled herself from her liquor enhanced sleep.

'*What are you doing*?' was the sentence she tried to convey but her mouth only formed the tired and weak words of "doing?". Adora looked down at her girlfriend stirring in her arms.

"I came in to check on you. There's no way the three of us are going to fit on that tiny cot." she whispered, sounding amused. Catra shook her head in protest when they entered Adora's room. Melog flowed in right behind Adora's calf to the combined mattresses on the floor. Pulling the strength to control her eyes from closing again, she saw that Adora had pulled both mattresses down on the floor to make one large bed on the floor. "Plus if you get sick, no one has to play gymnast at night and try to jump from the top".

"...play gymnast with you…" Catra slurred breathily, pulling herself into the nest of a bed when Adora sat her down. A small metal bin and bottle of water sat near the bed, clearly all pre-planned by the blonde.

"Shut up and go to bed" Adora giggled, pulling her long sleeve shirt over her head to stand in her sports bra before working to undo her pants. Catra tried to lean herself up with the prop of her elbows but couldn't quite control her head or how much she wanted to pass back out.

With her eyes shut, she continued on. "I love you, I really *love you*, Adora". Once the rest of her day clothes were off, she lowered herself to the floor and climb to her side of the bed. Catra wasn't sure if she had ever seen something as sexy as Adora crawling toward her, especially on a bed and in a state of undress.

"I know. I love you too" she said. Her muscles moved to settle herself under the blankets next to Catra. Melog pawed up Adora's side of the bed to pat a spot down. While her girlfriend was distracted with petting them, Catra inched her body closer. Adora saw the obvious movements and held a hand up gently. "While I love you, you should rest".

'*Are you mad at me*?' Catra wanted to ask, but couldn't. Again unable to articulate.

Catra whined, hiding her brown hair against Adora's chest and under her chin while the two were cradled by the sheets and blankets. "You look so *good*, though" she drew her words out and pressed her nose into Adora's neck to tickle and try to get a rise out of her. The pour of giggles started before the powered down She-Ra smacked at the blankets that concealed Catra's body.

"Knock it off before I kick you out" she teased, then noticed Catra was still fully clothed. "You're going to sleep with all that on?".

"Make up your mind, Priss-ess" Catra's words fumbled.

"We're not doing anything tonight while you're like this. We just had this conversation" she reminded, already pulling Catra's arms from the tunnels of the jacket sleeves.

"Ugh" Catra grumbled, letting her arms flop as she decided to turn herself in dead weight. Adora exhaled out of her nose at the immaturity. She threw the blanket off and helped her out of her leggings that were tattered in well-placed tears.

With the constraints of her clothes gone, lavashing in her buzz felt even more enjoyable. Still she pursed her mouth and pulled the scratchy blankets tighter around her. She could feel Adora's weight against her back and the familiar mass of her arm over her own. Adora's hand rose and tipped the lower part of Catra's chin towards her, prompting her to open her eyes.

Having Adora control where she looked made her pause her breathing when she looked over her shoulder to see the comfort of all the features she viewed as the most gorgeous thing in the world. "Believe me, I *want* to".

"So do it." Catra whispered, closing her eyes and leaning back into her while Adora held tighter.

Her heart thudded hard at the possibility that Adora's chivalrous restraint could fail at any moment. Her lips gently kissed Catra's cheek, the smell of Catra's indulgence reminding her why she felt it right to say no tonight.

The shorter haired woman was tired and knew it was a losing battle to fight. She took Adora's hand in her own, holding her own over it like she could shield them from the world.

Nights like this made everything worth it.

Chapter End Notes

We (Catra) have yet to hit rock bottom.

I'm also on the search for She-Ra merch if anyone has any recommendations, I would appreciate it!

Thanks for reading! :)

Chapter Nine

Chapter Summary

Before the group heads out to search for the anomolies, Catra has the best cure for a hangover shes ever had.

Chapter Notes

○●smut alert●○

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Waking up in the confines of the ship was much less luxurious than what waking up in the pastel walls of Bright Moon's Palace was. Especially when you were hung over.

The room sat dark, Adora waking before Catra yet again. Her long hair covering the pillow behind her with Catra's body now facing her own as she cuddled within her hold. When they were kids, it was similar to how they would fall asleep. Waking up then was much less relaxing because the risk of being caught, ripped out of bed, and hurt by Shadow Weaver. She left the lights off, letting the blue glow from Melog give a small glow. It was enough to see the fine details of Catra's relaxed face but not enough to combat all of the shadows in the room.

One of Catra's hands stayed hidden under her pillow, tucked snugly under her own head as the other rested in front of her like it had collapsed in the drowsy search for Adora. The lack of smell in the room made her relieved that Catra hadn't utilized the bucket she left out during the night. The water bottle sat empty, tipped over and without its cap on the floor of Catra's side.

Adora wished she had the power to let Catra see herself from this angle. Not necessarily the one that apparently needed a strong drink last night but to see the peaceful woman, breathing slowly in and out with the rise and fall of the flames blue light. If those piercing eyes opened now, Adora knew she wouldn't be able to pull herself away until she was made to.

She marveled at how they had gotten to where they were. The rocky past of a harshly continued childhood, finding safety only in each other then having it torn away. Adora knew she had been starved to reinstate their relationship but throughout most of the war, she had misread her own aches as a friendship that had been torn away from her. By the time she and Catra had reconnected and it was time to take the failsafe, it was a sudden hit to her core to realize she hadn't just craved her friendship.

If that was all Catra wanted, she would have accepted it. The want to be something more would have probably corroded away.

The first time she saw the past holo-visions of Catra, she knew it was beyond the more than simple friendship they had. Having all the stages of who her friend was and had been flash before her ripped memories from her that she didn't even notice she had been scrambling to hold on to.

Back then, the hole in her heart had been freshly punctured from Catra turning her back on her again was the deepest pit of loss she had felt.

The gravitational pull made everything become clear in her own mind that after everything, it wasn't just retaining their bond that she wanted.

Seeing that softness in Catra, entirely present and standing in front of her paired with the touch that made her feel like she was okay to fall apart in her hands. When it all disappeared, Adora was left coerced once again into being alone, back in the mental place of wanting things she couldn't allow herself to have.

She refused to let herself fall back into the place that made her waste so much time before. The years of them at odds were ones she could never get back. Adora scolded herself for not figuring things out sooner and being able to have more time together. She knew there was nothing she could have done that she didn’t already try to coax her friend with her.

She didn’t want the things that were forced on them as kids but that didn’t mean she was breaking the oaths she made to Catra. Now that they were together again, she just regretted all those years of wasted time. If Catra would have joined so willingly, it wouldn’t have been the same stubborn, fiery Catra she had fallen for.

Laying in a flattened, barely passable bed mat on the floor of a space vessel while dealing with the world’s ever constant issues was something she was oddly grateful to have now. Healing the world and the love of her life in her arms was something that was never entertained as a possibility in the Fright Zone.

If she didn’t already have her arms cradled around Catra’s sleeping body, she would have wondered where exactly it was that she was under the pile of bed dressings she had bundled over and around herself to keep warm.

The muffled sounds of breathing and a low purring noise fought its way out of the stack of blankets, a small dark cavern revealing the small hint of her cheek as she slept facing away.

Adora knew it was early and that it would be time to get up and ruin the moment. Right now it was just the two of them, nobody to impress or pull either of them down. She pulled Catra into her, the large form of comforter moving with her.

After both Glimmer and Catra were saved from the clutches of Horde Prime’s ship, Adora had finally felt like she had been broken one too many times past being repaired. Catra saved her best friend and gave the only apology she had ever heard her utter, only to turn around and scream in her face for coming back for her. It was clear that Catra harbored that deep resentment and outright hatred for her and there was nothing she could do to fix it.

Then in the whispered nights of her room, she had promised Adora she would do better.

It was all she ever wanted.

Adora had heard other couples gush about their partners before. Seahawk adored Mermista, treating her like a queen at all times even in the face of her indifference. Glimmer would sometimes sigh dreamily and say that Bow brings out the best in her. Spineralla and Netossa had such a history that they knew everything there was to know about each other.

She didn't want to compare. It was childish to think that everybody's love story could be a fairytale.

Sometimes in her longer weeks away, she wondered if Catra missed her.

She thought about how she brought out some of the good in Catra. In between teasing and previously slamming each other in the heat of a fight.

One thing she did know was that they technically were on par with Spin and Tossa. She and Catra had been together even longer…not in the same way but enough to know each other deeper than anyone else. Yet, in that longevity there were things that she wished she didn't see or have to do.

None of those things mattered. She would willingly work through anything as long as it was with Catra. Having the perfect relationship, with no arguing, or no mess wouldn't have been perfect if it was with anyone except her. In some terrible way, having her there to resolve their past only made her feel more relaxed. There were some nights that Adora questioned her own

mind, thinking surely Shadow Weaver and the Horde weren’t that bad.

It was usually random when either she or Catra would bring up some dark memory and laugh it off like the abuse was an inside joke or rite of passage from their childhood. They had grown enough to understand that not only were these things real, but that having the reactions they did, didn’t mean anything was wrong with them.

Adora knew how hard it was for Catra to be forward with what she was feeling but she knew that she was trying.

And Catra knew when Adora needed to put herself first and not try to please everyone.

Through the scope of her up bringing and Shadow Weaver's words that shaped her, Adora thought that Catra's bullhead insistence to take breaks or sneak off for time for herself was just her best friend trying to push her into becoming a slacker. Adora would never use the words out loud, but hearing the insults from their caregiver was enough to imprint them in her own mind.

The minute that Shadow Weaver could see Adora's uneasy body language, she would lay into her. Her words sounded more like she was venting to her as a trusted confidant rather than the child she actually was. Hand in hand with complimenting Adora's hardworking nature, she would demean Catra's laziness and inability to take any form of responsibility.

It was terrible to say that it made her feel good. Adora always loved to be doing the right thing. If she did the right thing, nobody could be disappointed in her and her smile could stay on her face as she achieved more and more from her drive.

It took far too long to understand Catra wasn't trying to slow her down. She didn't want to distract Adora. She just wanted her to not pretend she was a robot and overwork herself at the insistence of all their superiors.

The first time Catra convinced her to sneak onto a skiff was a few days after Adora had pulled a near triple watch shift. She stood tall during her post but once she was finally off duty, she fell asleep at a table in the mess hall only to have Catra snap at the other cadets as she tucked herself under Adora's limp arm to shake her somewhat awake and help walk her to her bunk.

Adora slept the entire next day, waking up with a small rations bar and water bottle at the side of her bed. She would insist to Catra that it was no big deal, which seemed to irritate her more.

Days later, when it was time to choose the new schedules for shift and she knew Adora would take another long block, Catra slyly acquired keys for a little joyride and caused Adora to miss priority shift choices.

She could still remember how fast her heart beat and how her stomach flipped at each hovered bump of the skiff. The grin and

cheers from Catra made her feel miles away from the reality of their lives in the Fright Zone and made her feel more alive than any promotion ever had. Adora had almost been distracted by the flow of Catra's thick hair and how she moved it out of her face to the point of having to jerk the vehicle back onto the clear path, narrowly avoiding a rotten stump.

When the outing was over, they were able to sneak back in. Adora was finally pulled back into the Horde mentality and was bothered to only get the short shifts but didn't notice how Catra smirked in satisfaction when she checked the board.

Later, someone would report some missing fuel and additional mileage that was unaccounted for on the skiff. The Captain at the time had a strong feeling it was Catra and brought the matter to Shadow Weaver's attention.

After being called down, pressed, and getting set with extra cleaning duties, Catra still never admitted to doing anything out of line. She maintained the story that she had just been using the restroom. They had been so busy trying to crack her that nobody noticed the accoladed soldier's absence and no one expected Adora to be involved.

It wasn't everyday, but everytime she let Catra convince her into little adventures like that it seemed to be easier to just go along with her. She knew that her best friend was very convincing when she wanted to be and she wasn't ready to admit how ready she was to jump with her when she gave the word.

Adora used her own face as she stretched over and into the opening in search of Catra. She nuzzled her nose in until she felt the warmth and kissed her on the cheek like she was a precious buried treasure under all of her covers. Her sleep must have been light enough to let her wake as she started to stir before the slits of her eyes pulled open and her cat eyes slid to zero in on Adora's face. Catra leaned into her, resting her forehead against the underside of her girlfriend's jaw.

"Morning" her sleep laced voice mumbled. Her eyes undoubtedly had shut again, Adora could tell that she would fall back to sleep if she let her.

"You didn't get sick," Adora mused. She could feel Catra shift under her arm, curling a bit tighter in her bedding.

She cleared her throat, "I'm a professional".

"Professional brat maybe" Adora mumbled, her smile curving upwards as she pressed her mouth into Catra's cheek again. The pair didn't move from their melded position for a bit until Catra sniffled. Adora couldn't imagine how she always managed to get cold on these ships.

"We gotta go don't we?" her voice sounded disappointed.

"Yeah," Adora pulled back, giving the other enough room to turn to face her while pulling free from the blankets cocoon. "Entrapta and I are going to take the city center while you and Bow-".

"I know," Catra stopped her. "I ran into him for a minute last night."

Adora waited, trying to read the look of hesitation on her face. She wondered if she made the right call or would just pull Catra off course enough from her attempt to have a day.

"I just need someone with me who knows the signals well enough to help decipher exactly what's going on."

Catra didn't respond, only picking at the fringe on the blanket with the tips of her nails. Adora knew the words that were more than likely the ones she wanted to say. She was aware of the worries that plagued Catra while she tried to find her place, both in the reconstruction and in the world. Adora struggled to try to blindly meet Catra’s needs.

“Shouldn’t be too long, we already have the perimeter of where we need to search from the scans and then just asking around town is pretty low profile. If you want we can all probably group back up in town…” Adora prattled, trying to stack her words until she felt like she had made the situation any better.

“I didn’t say anything,” Catra reminded, waving her palm upward. “We’ll make quick work of finding what's going on, meet back with you guys, and call it a day.”

Hearing the acceptance so easily earned from someone she had caught in a clear state of distress last night made Adora pull back. She wondered if she was just trying to coddle too hard.

Sne could feel Catra begin to sit up. In compliance, she pulled her legs out from the blankets to try to follow Catra’s sudden confidence in how easy the day would go. Poorly trying to disguise her apprehensiveness, she moved to roll out of bed before Catra. She felt a hand on top of her own, looking at Catra who was clearly more awake.

“Do we have any time for anything *else*?” her sharp eyes adding to the suggestive tone of her voice. Adora’s face burned, feeling embarrassed for thinking of getting out of bed first. She tilted her head from side to side playfully like she had to consider the offer before leaning back over the bed to where her back once faced. Catra’s touch moved down her arm as she leaned, eager to let their mouths meet.

Adora’s body remained mostly unclothed, still in the gray of her under clothing. She drug one knee on the low profile of the bed to bring herself closer to her prize and frame the sides of Catra as she pulled her in. The comforting touch of her hands made her wish they had been in the right state to do this the night before.

Feeling Catra's lips move against hers, Adora gladly reciprocated. Her body now returned to its rightful place against Catra in the bed with hands searching each other in a building heat, she could feel Catra's mouth part more, her tongue lightly moving against Adora's lips to ask for permission.

Hungry and driven to receive more of her, Adora opened, bringing her hand up to run through the tufts of Catra's hair.

The moans and light sounds of sucking reverberated in the room, sounding off of the metal walls as the two lost themselves in becoming more frantic to seize their moment.

Catra hadn't missed the tempting outline of Adora's boyshorts, keeping the taught curves of her firm ass just concealed enough to make her angry she couldn't see beneath them yet. Her hand wandered the outer side of Adora's thighs, fully prepared to tear the shorts to shreds if they gave too much resistance.

Feeling sharpened claws being to scratch at the fabric, Adora broke the kiss and tipped to all fours, trying to intimidate Catra while raising an eyebrow.

"Someone's excited, huh?" she asked, ponytail waving behind her, just calling Catra to grab a fistful to shut her up.

Before Adora could finish her predictable motions, Catra kept her eye contact, swiping the hand Adora was using to keep herself

stable from under her. Once her balance was off, Catra twisted quickly enough to flip Adora down onto her back and kept her hands restrained.

The bold look on Adora's face was gone. Catra pulled her arms up over her head, holding her in place as she stayed propped on top of her in a straddle position of power. The thin fabric of Adora's bra wasn't enough to prevent her hardened nipples from peering through, screaming to Catra that she was just as ready as she was.

Adora's already revealing bottoms slid up further, out of sight but not forgotten by the woman seated atop of her. She brought her lips back down to Adora's, now more messy while her hands tangled in what was left pinned up in the nest of blonde hair. Catra's teeth worked to nip at Adora's bottom lip, pulling more illicit sounds from her.

Catra could feel the involuntary movement of Adora spreading her legs from underneath her. She found pleasure in keeping her waiting and wanted to tease her further.

Still stuck in her clothes from the previous night, Adora didn’t have the same easy access to let her eyes prowl over Catra’s body. It didn’t dissuade her from working at each layer, keeping as much of her hands and mouth on her as she could manage while Catra moved on top of her. She pauses to lean back, taking in the threatening sight of her slinking form above her with desire in her eyes.

From the rise and fall of anticipation within her, it was as if a magic of its own held her in its grasp.

"Get the rest of this off…" Adora nearly begged, pulling at the skin tight clothing that clung to Catra.

Catra moved back to her mouth before taking an achingly slow halt to move to her ear. "Why would I do *that*?" she purred. Feeling the sharpness of teeth now ticking down her neck, Adora fought to hold in a yelp of surprise. A jolt traveled down to her feet, making her feel like she was ice on track to melt.

Her hands traveled down to her waistband, territory she wasn't allowed to cross the night before. Catra wondered if she could stretch out her misery by asking if she was permitted to touch today. She was past the point of that and just wanted to see the look of Adora reduced to a mess and begging for more.

With her back to the mattress, she didn't bother to hide her arousal. Pulling gingerly at the back of Catra to bring her back down to her and rounding her hands on her ass that she willingly leaned forward to offer more of a handful.

There was the unspoken time crunch that they couldn't help but be aware of.

It wasn't fair.

Catra was ready to take her time in whatever way she wanted.

They were finally together, both of sound mind, and Adora wasn't turning her down.

She thought Adora would play a more passive role but when she grew more impatient with Catra by the minute, her hands rubbing Catra's thighs, chest, and back while Catra had graced Adora's chest with the presence of her mouth down the v of her collarbone. Through the modest cut of the sports bra, Catra reached under the band to palm at her breast. In a surge of excitement, Adora tried to roll, an unsuccessful attempt to get herself on top of Catra. A commanding slam of her thigh kept Adora right where she wanted.

With Adora's already hardened nipples in her grasp, Catra used each hand to squeeze them in her fingers. A low groan came from her partner as she rolled them with alternating pressure before pushing the clothing up and placing her mouth over the pink nub.

A pitched moan sprang from Adora before Catra put her hand over her mouth. Their faces were close enough that all that was needed was the threatening look from Catra that if Adora was too loud, she would stop everything. Holding still, she waited until Adora whispered her pleads for her to continue before obliging.

All of the blankets that once had their places on the bed were now cast off of each side. Adora removed her displaced bra, throwing

it off of the bed. Catra moved backwards, straightening her legs behind her and following with her body to crawl herself back and lower down the length of Adora's exposed body. She trailed her nails softly down Adora's abdomen, pulling them up just before the band of her boy shorts before kissing the area and letting her hands slowly pull the shorts down.

Her eyes were unwavering as she looked up at Adora, daring her to take a breath. Catra's lips pursed and blew cooling air onto Adora's exposed skin and hair, sending shivers throughout her.

Catra revels in finally getting what she wanted. Watching Adora's complexion settle before heightening as she traced her inner labia softly with her finger, adding teasing laps with her tongue to really let Adora understand what she had given into. The scent of her excitement was as intoxicating as the bottle she had finished off the night before- a clear reward for her alone.

The desperate want in Catra's expression turned to one of carnal desire. She wanted to revel in every minute of watching Adora squirm with pleasure but couldn't ignore her instinct to want to show her who was in the position of power.

Her vexatious grin grew as she used her two fingers to rub firmly against Adora's increasing sensitive clit, then slid them quickly inside of her. Her dark eyebrows pulled together as she cried out and her chest rose before Catra ran her hand up Adora's neck to feel like she had her contained.

"Oh- fuck, Catra don't s-s-" Adora tried to stammer out breathlessly. Adora's usually maintained hair was already in shambles from sleep. With her head rubbing and pushing itself further into the soft surface, blonde hairs sprung around her face in a messy frame that made Catra work harder. Anytime she could feel Adora become too excited, she intentionally slowed her motions.

Once she could feel Adora's heart attempt to slow its beat, she brought herself back to Adora's mouth. Her lips sunk against hers to take ownership while she kept her hand in soothing motions, covered in Adora's wetness.

"More?" Catra tested with a tilt of her head. Adora nodded desperately, praying for the opportunity to come. Catra added another finger- carefully keeping all nails retracted. Adora's hips rocked against her hand. Her girlfriend was so beautiful, it shocked and excited her to be the one to see her like this.

Maintaining her own composure while Adora's sighs turned shaky in the wane of Catra's light grunts as her arm moved back and forth. She wanted to return her mouth back to its rightful place to savor Adora's sweetness but could feel the light pulsing tell of her getting close.

"You're doing *such* a good job taking all of me" Catra cooed, running her hand down the side of her light completed breast before pushing back up to grab the plush flesh with her hand. Adora whimpered, now holding onto Catra with greater strength.

The sweat was felt on the cloth around them, wiped from their bodies at the slightest bit of movement. Catra moved herself to Adora's side, keeping her movements steady the way her lover liked it. She brought her lips to nipple, sucking hard.

"Ca-" muffled sounds tried to sound out of Adora's before her own hand blocked it to sensor herself. "I-I-".

"You can do it…" Catra encouraged, kissing her chest. "...for *me*".

Around her fingers she could feel the walls tighten while Adora cried out. Catra pretended not to notice as her body went noticeably less rigid, feeling like she was now fading into bliss. Her freckled cheeks moved as her lips gave more attention to the warrior's body before allowing her fingers to slip from her.

Once her mind would allow her to form a coherent thought, she tipped Catra's chin up to look at her. A smug Catra crawled up to meet Adora's face for another peck before settling into each other again.

"See what you're missing out on?".

Adora snickered in a single breath. "That was…" her face seemed to look into the middle space in search of the word to describe what had just happened. Catra knew she was pretty good at distracting Adora when she wanted to.

"Take your time".

Adora shot a look at her, then brought her mouth to Catra's neck. "Now it's your turn".

She eagerly accepted, then thought of what the actual reason they were on the ship. After letting Adora indulge herself, Catra put her hands onto her torso to slow her.

"How soon until someone comes to wake you up?" she asked softly, wishing they didn't have to stop.

Adora's glass eyes flickered from relaxed to the determined steel Catra was more accustomed to seeing lately.

"You're no fun".

"You didn't think that a minute ago".

Adora pulled her arms around her again, resenting everything that was forcing them from their safe place and into a world where they were forced back into their respective roles.

Even as they got dressed- the smell of sex still hanging in the air around them, Catra could still feel the lingering gaze of Adora's eyes on her. Anyone else and she would have felt threatened enough to snap at them and demand what their deal was.

When Adora stared at her, she could feel her heart become permeated with admiration. She didn't know what to do with it but had grown to no longer order her to knock it off, she would pretend not to notice. It allowed the butterflies to flare up inside of her without having to acknowledge it too much.

Adora decided to leave the mats as they were, then she, Catra, and Melog made their way to the bridge to meet with the other two.

Before they had fully approached, Entrapta was bringing a glowing screened tablet right to Adora's face to fill her in. More dots had sprouted overnight.

Catra listened in, receiving the new Intel with a stern expression. Adora nodded along, asking what the council's recommendations were and if the King had been alerted of the change.

Her eyes wandered to Bow. He was standing over the pressure control panel, loading a variety of arrows into his golden quiver with another open backpack he was in the process of stocking full.

"What do you think we're in for?" Catra asked, seating herself near him and leaning her elbow on the small offering of countertop under a group of dials.

"Something…not good."

Catra gave a last look to the other pair. She could see Adora's body language tense as she pulled herself closer. Arms folded, feet planted as she continued to speak to Entrapta.

She leaned back, then placed her hands behind her head "I'm ready when you are".

Bow nodded.

As they rounded the others to exit, Catra traced her nail on the red shoulders of Adora's jacket. Adora pulled her attention from the inventor to see Catra give a playful wave of her sharp fingers wiggling.

"Be careful guys" her voice sounding more like a plea than a warning.

Chapter End Notes

I had more I wanted to happen here but if I didn't break it up, this chapter would have been like 10k words.

Chapter Ten

Chapter Summary

Bow and Catra check the forests of Brimeda for trouble and find it.

Chapter Notes

Warning for violence in this chapter.

Bow and Catra set off with their direction being let by the trackpad in the tech master's hands. Catra volunteered to carry his pack on her back so he could focus on the change of the screen and direct them in the best way to approach.

The wide trail the had traveled before was one that they took again- in the opposite direction towards more uninhabited parts of the forest.

Catra had balked a bit at being given the 'easier' end of the job but understood why it had to be done. With the quickly growing number of dots in the area, it didn't seem like either scouting mission would be entirely without trouble. The deep thicket began to swallow them, sounds of rustling leaves in the far off timbers around them. Each sound made Catra's ear pull in it's direction, seeing if it was a follower of Prime.

She kept pace behind Bow, being his eyes when his were on the screen as they grew closer and the path became less easy to travel without weaving their bodies through weeds and reaching branches. The floor of the forest made it easy for her to see the

dry surroundings around them, no signs of footprints or other disturbances that had made their way before them.

After altering their course several times in the hour but maintaining his confidence in route, Bow finally spoke.

"Keep alert, we're close" he warned. Catra nodded.

The closeness of the tree's gave them enough handles to grab to keep steady now that there was no definite path to be followed. From over his shoulder Catra could see the greens and whites of the screen display the two dots to be within a very close range.

Bow's brown eyes veered from the tablet, focusing on getting himself over a large root system that lay exposed above the ground. Ahead of them looked like a break in the dense foliage, a small stream of water weaving around the bases of taller trees while the two broke from the tangles of the brush surrounding them. They could see the water on the map, connecting to a larger pond further east.

Then, Catra saw them. She wordlessly placed a hand on Bow's shoulder, bending at the knees to prepare for a crouch. His gaze followed where she was looking, a small embankment on the riverside where two figures stood.

They were far enough where they could hear sporadic mumbling uttered but nothing more. The taller of the two had what used to

be a pristine uniform of Prime's clones. The clean white and perfect tailoring, now looking tattered and dirty from an extended time in the wilderness. Catra frowned, the other person seemed to be just that- a person.

A few feet away from the clone was a woman in civilian clothing, not looking as if they had been exposed to the elements as long as her counterpart. Smaller in stature, she stood oddly as she milled back and forth and rocked herself with her hands to her side.

"Should we…?" Catra whispered, preparing herself for the next step. Bow watched them for a another second.

"...What are they doing?" his rhetorical question began to make his own mind start an attempt to rapid fire possible answers.

"No idea but if they're standing, they could still be a danger. I don't think we should wait for an order. It needs to be dealt with now."

Even at the insistence of her words, they continued to watch from a distance as the two moved. At first many of the steps were nothing out of the ordinary, only seeming out of place due to their haggard appearance. Suddenly, the taller one stopped all movement, making Catra think they had been detected before the defective looking clone began to convulse- its spine and joints contorted in uncomfortable angles. The other didn't react, instead looking at the stream. Bow's eyes were fixed, studying what was happening in an effort to formulate a plan.

A disgusted look twisted Catra's mouth. She could feel her head shake involuntarily.

"Something is wrong with them…" Bow whispered. The possibilities were already rolling through: defective chip, disrepair, or maybe too long of a period without being updated by their creator.

"It doesn't explain her" she said gravely. Wayward clones were something they thought they had taken care of at the beginning of the restoration period. Few wandered from the location point of where their leader was unless they were in the midst of carrying out a programmed order before being cut from their hub.

They had never seen another person be turned without having Horde Prime directly involved in a series of surgical and painful installations, Catra knowing this the best.

Sometimes it still felt like it was sewn into her, a part of her. It made her want to tear at the back of her own neck most nights. The pull of the memories made her want to act more quickly to snuff the issue out. That woman was once just a civilian going about her own life before this happened. While Catra wasn't as noble to want to cleanse the world for the pure sake of good, she didn't want anyone to feel the horrors she had.

Her eyes watched the gray clone, mud splattered and now leaning at an off-kilter angle as green liquid oozed from a gash from his

ribs. The mass traveled down, spilling into the ends of the bank and stream before the bright green deluded in the running water. Her eyes narrowed, noting the lack of a mechanic on the back of the woman's neck where a chip should have been if she was connected to the hive mind of Prime.

It didn’t make sense.

Wanting to stomp the paid out but having enough empathy to see that it wasn’t this woman's fault for whatever had happened to make her this way. She didn’t move in motion with the other, she seemed to be…stuck. Wandering like she was lost, the woman kept her face turned to the water, now reaching her arms out to hover her hands across it as she stood. Her hands swayed as if she had a piano in front of her that no one else could see except her, with her palms remaining turned down.

“We need to see what’s going on with that water.” Bow noted, motioning with two fingers at the span of the river as it moved on. “I don’t want to jump into an attack before the others know what’s going on. If we can just incapacitate them, I think there’s good odds that we can help her”.

Still frowning, Catra nodded. “The don’t look like they’re moving from this spot any time soon. How do we get close enough to that part of the water” she bobbed her head towards where the clone had and continued to bleed out onto his surroundings.

Bow looked up and down the stretch of the forest, checking for better cover or a way to lure the pair away. Still not entirely

satisfied with the plan, Catra followed direction. In her glance across the water, far through the cuts of the branches and leaves, she thought she saw what looked like a small smoke plume.

She gave a small surreptitious noise to catch Bow's attention before pointing it out further down the same direction of where the water was headed down hill. Whatever the smoke was from was set in the opposite direction of town. The gray cloud looked steady enough from what they could see that it appeared to be from a set structure or even a home.

"Pretty close. We should warn whoever that is then see if we can get a decent read on the water from downstream" Catra said, already beginning to move. Bow quietly stood with her, looking at the now uncomfortably still pair who had frozen like statues in their places in the forest. Bow and Catra gave a wide berth as they headed towards the smoke, looking back every once in a while at the woman.

Until they couldn't make them out through the tree line anymore, Catra finally stopped trying to see her out of the corners of her eye. She moved quickly, now leading Bow as they moved through the woods. Still holding the tracker in his hand, they were less concerned with running into the danger since they had already located what it was they were looking for. Bow fell behind in her step as he worked to send an alert to Entrapta and the ship to log what they had seen so far and safely mark it.

Her sharp eyes never failed her, they moved in on a small wooden cabin that sat several miles into the wilderness from where they had been. The stone chimney was the source of the smoke as it

stood proudly at the edge of the forest and before the glassy lake. In other circumstances it probably would have been a dream home if it didn't have sinister mind controlled clones and infected nearby. The dirt of the forest floor was gentle under her feet as she walked up the slightly worn trail to the home.

A hip high stone wall attempted to line the weathered path, portions of it already falling from time and gravity. She turned, nearing the door before catching herself. When she remembered who she was and that Bow was still several steps behind her, the drive to help quickly fizzled and made her stop at the edge of the wall to wait for him.

He should be the one to knock. People were fearful or angry when she was the one at their door.

Looking up from the data pad, Bow was swift to understand what happened without saying a word. He put the tech away before jogging up to meet her side by side to approach.

As they got to the old door, he reached a wide hand up to rap firmly with his knuckle.

The area was so still and tranquil with only the sounds of wildlife and the burning from the chimney giving hint that the place was anything more than abandoned. With no answer from the owner, Bow knocked again.

Catra looked around the small property. She could imagine herself and Adora in a place like this if there were different lives to be lived. A large woodpile sat off to the side of the home while off several yards there was a fire pit and sporadic leafy plants that looked like they needed tending. In the idyllic picture, a putrid smell harshly cut through.

The pungent scent of rot wafted in with the slight change of breeze, easily picked up by her heightened senses. Bow knocked one more time before Catra asked him.

"Do you smell that?".

He inhaled once before shaking and trying to perceive what it was she was picking up on. Following the direction where it grew stronger, it led her around the right side of the home.

"Catra, wait!" Bow feigned a whisper in a weak attempt to stop her trespassing.

She couldn't just ignore the smell of death while they tried to calmly warn someone about possible dangers.

Luckily, not that she would view it as luck, they didn't have to walk far before finding the source. A fair distance from the house and down near the water, the smell grew nearly unbearable. They didn't need to go closer to see the waterlogged corpse of another clone laying on the side of the beach. Gentle waves from the lake

lapped up at its still body, looking like it had bloated significantly and had begun to house algae and other small organisms that feast on its remains. It was unbelievable that it was this close to the house.

Bow's mouth hung agape, the sight and smell causing his stomach to churn and Catra to pull her fist up to her nose to try and block the smell. This would have been the third mark on their map.

" *Don't* move!" a man's voice ordered from behind them. Catra and Bow's eyes looked to each other before turning their heads to look behind. Bow put his hands up to show good faith while Catra was slow to do the same.

An middle aged looking man held a blaster as he looked down the slope at them with anger in his wrinkled frown. Seriousness was clear in expression as he glared at the two, Catra kept her hands slightly up while seeing the ax hanging from his belt loop.

"Sir, we are with the Rebellion-"

"I don't give a damn who you're with or where you're from. Get away from my home." his gruff voice demanded while he waved the gun at them, motioning them to leave before he had to use the weapon.

"Did you know about the clones?" Catra questioned quickly, motioning to the sickening display on the sand bed. Something

about his eyes and how his breathing changed when he looked at her made her feel more unease.

A booming shot was fired off into the tree beside her, making her jump as it tore off layers and shards of bark. "It's none of your concern, I got it taken care of".

Bow looked worried, his brows dipping before he motioned to the tracker in the bag on his side.

"We don't mean any disrespect, please. We were sent to help Brimeda and we aren't your enemy. There are two nearby-".

"Two?" the man lowered his gun, letting Catra breathe finally. "Was one a woman?".

"Yes, we just want to keep everyone safe," Bow assured, lowering his hands. She was unsure if it was the angle or just from them being lower but the man appeared to have an enormous height advantage on the two. A messy beard lined his jaw and stray hairs traveled down his neck, with his work clothes starting where the facial hair ended. He had the appearance of a working man who was in no mood to play games.

He looked down, debating his options before holstering the weapon. He still looked incredibly defensive. “Little late for all that isn’t it?” he asked sarcastically. Bow ignored it, just happy to not have the threat of a firearm on them anymore.

Catra wanted to fire off more questions to the guy but after having him shoot, her words failed to voice themselves. Bow was better at the diplomatic aspects anyway.

"We're here now because of some weird readings we've been getting. It looks like you're pretty familiar with them, we're working to take care of it…" his explanation was rushed but concise to keep the man on their side. He waved them up to follow, refusing to turn his back as they neared him.

"'Few weeks now I've been seeing 'em" he mused without a trace of fear in his voice, "didn't start with me though. I don't head into town often but when I did there were these rumors about things in the forest. Kid's stories, y'know." he spoke to Bow before looking to Catra and back. The three of them moved away from the body closer to his home. The former Horde Captain's stomach still held a firm knot inside, possibly from the remaining decay she knew lay at the bottom of the dune.

Bow continued to question the man as Catra kept her guard up, trying to convince herself to stop being too paranoid. If she was going to be in the field, she had to be focused. The adrenaline from being shot at still had her heart racing, unable to slow and take her out of survival mode. She knew staying silent the whole time would only make others more comfortable but thankfully Bow was taking the reins until she could collect herself. He questioned when the first time he saw one was, if he had been in contact, and why he had one down at the foot of his property.

“That one wasn’t me, it washed up on the shore a week or so ago and I didn’t wanna touch it.” he claimed. They stood back in front of his home, hoping to gather what they needed before meeting back up with the other team that had worked the city. He cleared his throat before opening his door. “I’m headed in for a drink, come and grab one.”

Catra looked at Bow. Sometimes people did offer more hospitality once they were more comfortable with their reasons for being there. While her insides were shouting at her to ignore the man entirely, the strange urge to prove that she could be personable like the others was enough to make her unwilfully agree. Bow smiled at her comradery, agreeing to come in for a quick moment for some water. It made him proud of Catra to put herself out there at the expense of her own discomfort but be rewarded with how well received her presence was. Catra breathed to calm herself before following him in with Bow behind her.

The cabin was a small, one room home. There was a large bed in the corner with various fur trappings lining the walls, a kitchen hearth on the other side of the room that fed a fire where the smoke they had spotted was growing from, and in the middle there was a table. The whole set up was very rustic but seemed to suit the man perfectly. Dried flowered lined above the window and door frames as they entered.

Bow and Catra remained seated as the man moved to the kitchen portion of his house. The counter already had a tin pitcher filled with water ready while he grabbed three carved wooden cups down. Among all the hand made furniture and finely made items, it was easy to see he was a man used to working with his hands.

The man filled one cup before handing it to a thankful Bow then starting on Catra's. Bow quickly sipped before placing it on the table before him.

"Do you mind if I take a few quick samples of the water? We want to figure out why this is happening and how to stop it as soon as possible." Bow asked.

The man nodded, allowing him permission to do whatever was needed to get them on their way. He gave a quick glance to his partner, nodding to convey he would be back shortly.

Catra begged with her eyes for him not to leave, but he was already out the door.

When it was just her and this man whose name they still did not know, she worked hard to keep her emotions inside. She could be confident, thank him for the drink, and Bow would be right back before they would be on their way.

He set her drink down on the table next to Bow's. She scooped it up to have something in her hands so she didn't feel so exposed.

"Thanks" she said before taking a sip. He nodded, giving her hope that maybe he wasn't much for idle conversation either.

“You can take a seat.” he said, now turning away from her to reach into his cabinet lined with bottles. She didn’t feel like sitting, but did it anyway. “Been a rough one today, I’m feeling something stronger than water is in order” Catra was unsure if he was speaking to her or himself. She watched him pull a stout bottle from the middle of the cupboard, pulling the cork and pouring the golden liquid into his own wooden cup. He raised the bottle over his shoulder for her to see as an offering. She shook her head, feeling more jittery.

“I’m good, thanks.” she declined, keeping her face straight. He brought the bottle and his drink to the table but didn’t sit.

“Come on, you’re gonna tell me after seeing all that out there, a little drink is what's gonna bother ya?” he took the cup from in front of her and poured the remaining bit of water into Bow’s drink then filled hers a fourth of the way with rum.

She watched the distilled drink pour into the complementing brown of her own cup. If it were any other day she would have probably welcomed a quick shot or two. He slid it over. She wondered if that was what she was missing. She had just gone through seeing a disgusting display and being fired at, a quick drink before Bow came back could calm her enough to be pleasant with a stranger and help her act like a person.

Her black nails rounded the cup, then she picked up and drank. He nodded. “See, I knew it.” he commented. “Been rough out here for a while now”.

“Yeah, you have a nice place though.” the rum was strong, not as smooth as the drinks that she could find in the city but significantly more potent. “Did you build this place?”.

He nodded, drinking from his own receptacle. “All myself, yep. Floors were me, walls, everything”. Catra took a second and final drink before her’s was empty. “...except the flowers, those are my wife’s...”.

Catra nodded, seeing his eyes look to hers in a way that looked almost glazed over. She wondered if she shouldn’t have asked, maybe it was a sore subject.

“It looks good.” she said simply, trying to be careful.

“That’s what I told her,” he chuckled “before the war, she always wanted to go off and travel and shit. Then when everything hit, we stayed home and she would try to beauty up this place the best she could…”.

All she could do was listen to the man go on. Maybe this was finally it and she was connecting with the people of Etheria in a way she had dreamed she could.

He finished off the rest of his rum, setting it down as he seemed to think as he stood. The silence made everything feel frozen, she wondered if she was expected to say something or if it was rude if she didn’t. Something felt wrong.

"...where is your wife?" she asked quietly, her eyes looking up at him. He shifted his jaw, looking out the window.

"Out with that fucking thing you brought here." he spat. Catra's stopped. All of her breathing, her heart, everything felt like it crashed into the depths of a cave and splintered herself apart. He looked at her now, his unreadable face now devoid of the fake smiles and offering it had before.

"I didn't bring them here-"

"You don't think I would remember the day the Horde came? The day you invaded our home?" he ripped a wooden chair away from the table, sending it flying and crashing apart across the bed. Catra sat in her chair, arms pulled in.

"The Horde is gone." she managed, having practiced the phrase several times when she was by herself.

He clomped heavily around her chair, closing in on her. "And here you are. *Captain*."

She felt the weight of his hand on the back of her chair, closing her eyes as he leaned in. Fear overtook her, but she knew if she could act fast enough, she could get out of there without having to land any scratches on him.

“I’ve been with the Rebellion. Trying to fix what I’ve done” she countered, her voice beginning to shake.

He laughed, letting the air loudly out from his lungs like he had heard the funniest joke in the world. “Just wanted to get those first thousand kills in before switching sides, eh?”. He didn’t seem drunk, but he had seemed to have been in a deteriorating mental state for a while. Wishing for the day he could do something. Now here she was, the scapegoat for all of the wrongs in his life served to him to deal with as he pleased.

“I’m sorry, for your wife. If I could take it back I-”.

“Don’t you fucking *listen*?!” he shouted, ripping her from her chair by her short hair. “She isn’t dead, she’s still out there with that… that…thing!”.

Catra’s hands tore at his, digging into his flesh before he grabbed her upper arms. His giant fingers wrapped around them and squeezed before he picked her up and slammed her back onto the table. Cups spilled on her and the floor while the bottle shattered, making the wooden surface beneath them reek of alcohol and bare the threat of glass. Now terrified, Catra began to fight, kicking up at him to get him off of her as he hovered above the table.

“*Bow*!” she cried as loud as her lungs would let her. He twisted her body as much as she could to wring free, only managing one

limb before he would clamp back on to her. The table had only the middle support their movement was too much for, when it tipped. It sent Catra to the floor into the mess of glass and rum but not with enough time to scramble away before he latched on to her again, straddling over her to stop her movements.

"This ain't his fault. You took my entire life from me." he panted, then threw a hard punch down into the side of her face. "Now I'm gonna do the same".

The hit was enough to send her reeling, pain pulsing through her when he landed another and blood dripped before splashing from her nose. She tried to move, each hit making her slower and more dizzy. Her eyes hurt, her cheeks, everything was a target. The thick glass beneath her cut through her clothes and skin as the liquid seeped through with it. She had hoped she would lose consciousness to end the pain of being struck over and over, but each one landed just as harshly as the first.

A mess of matted hair covered in blood and her battered face held dear to the visage of Adora. For all the suffering she endured on the outside, in her mind she pictured herself safe at home basking in the sun with Adora.

The shining dream began to gray, the sounds of his fist crashing into her over and over sounded like it was oceans away as she began to fade. The last sound she heard before everything went dark was yelling and then the weight of the man on top of her was gone.

Chapter Eleven

Chapter Summary

Catra deals with the aftermath of an attack.

The soft groans of muted sounds came first. They sounded like she was coming up from being submerged, but without the feeling of being drenched. Feeling her eyes roll around behind her lids was already a strain that she wished she didn't instinctually move to do.

Then the throbbing pain.

From her face, down her arms, and through her entire body the more clear the sounds around her became, the more the muscles in her body shouted at her in rebellion that they wanted to be put under again to escape the ache. She tried to control the weight of her head but failed as it toppled back and forth and the voices now sounded near enough to be in front of her. Her eyes tried to flicker open tiredly, swollen and heavy. The hands connected to the voices tried to steady her loosely controlled neck, accidentally brushing the sides of where she felt most vulnerable. The second the contact was made, skin to her own neck, she began to thrash her body away violently. Ignoring the pain as she ripped herself from the touch, trying to escape a hand she couldn't see in fear that it was a memory of Prime trying to dominate her mind and body again.

In the frenzy, the rest of the sounds were drowned out as she fought to flee from what she realized was a cot of some sort. Even with the new information of her surroundings, she couldn't bring herself to calm and wretched herself further back, now feeling

small plastic tubes hooked throughout her arm. She started to claw them out of her just based on feeling with her hands and tugging them out in a display of distress.

"Catra, stop! Stop! You're here now, I've got you." she heard Adora plead. Her throat hurt both on the inside and outside from the beating and from her stressed breathing when she had thought she was in another fight for her life. Barely able to open her eyes enough to see Adora through the small window of a half slit, she was able to confirm that she wasn't in the cabin anymore, or even in the forest outside of Brimeda.

Adora sat half on the foot of her bed and half over her with her hands on Catra to get her to stop unhooking herself from her IV fluids and machines that were tracking her vitals. Now Catra was able to make out the sounds of medical devices in the background beeping as fast as her heart was before slowing with each breath she took.

With Adora's hands held over her forearms, Catra crumbled. Her body melted forward into Adora who held her close. Her arms weren't the tight hug that she craved because Adora worried that all it would give was more pain to her already damaged body.

Leaning her back carefully into her medical cot, Adora fought to keep her face strong.

Catra was beyond recognizable, her face flared in different colors and stitches to piece her back together from her encounter. Her

lip had been split and every movement of her face looked like pain.

All Adora could do was fix her IV and move her hand down to hold Catra's.

Her first attempt to speak was met with a dry false start, forcing Catra to clear her throat before asking again. "How did you find me?".

Her memory was decent, she didn't think she had lost any recollection of what she and Bow had been doing, but couldn't remember if being dragged was a dream of the void or something that had been real. It felt almost silly to ask.

Adora answered, "You and Bow were getting some samples after you found some clones and - he said this guy…". Her voice rasped against the silence, filtering itself back into nothingness.

She struggled to find the words to use. She struggled because she was a good person who couldn't imagine how real people could do something like that to another living being. She wasn't like Catra or the man who attacked her.

Catra just nodded weakly. Dried blood clung to her scalp, pulling at the roots to add more nuisance to her condition. She wasn't about to make Adora have to repeat any of the gory details back

to her. It was overload to know that Adora was seeing her in such a fucked up state, but making her retell a story that she wasn't there to prevent would tear at her deeply.

Because Adora is a good person. She thinks everything is on her.

The choppy, sliding movements of her thumb running over the clean skin of Adora's hand reminded her more of what a blemish she was in comparison to her lover's existence.

"Bow incapacitated him, then sent out an alert to us. I came- I got there as soon as I could" her voice trembled. She sounded like a kid trying to assure their parents that they had tried their best. It was never a question in Catra's mind.

In the moment, it felt like she was trapped in that cabin for nearly thirty minutes. Stranded at the merciless hands of someone who only wanted to act out cruel revenge on her once he had the opportunity. She knew time had probably moved much faster than that in real life. Bow was not so careless to leave her alone with someone for that long, even if he mistakenly viewed it as her final achievement of acceptance. The feeling inside of her heart falling was one she tried not to take personally. He wouldn't have left her if he had known - something that her mind knew but the rest of her had to wrestle to accept.

Through the drawn shades, it was impossible to see what time it was or if it was even the same day. She tried to adjust the angle she was sitting at, sending a hiss through her teeth as her bruised

flesh shoulder and ribs protested at her movements. Each wrong move felt like a smaller version of another hit.

Adora’s movements stammered, eyes searching how she could help her when she couldn’t touch without hurting her more. She pressed a button on the side of the machine before looking to the doorway.

“We’ll get you something for the pain.” she nodded while Catra’s face tried to relax and close her eyes again.

Catra wanted to care about the mission. She wished that she was self–sacrificing enough to insist on knowing the next part of the plan.

It wasn’t about being careless or selfish.

She just felt nothing.

She felt like she was nothing.

The purple and black blotches of bruising under the light fuzz of her face decorated up her jaw and right eye in savage markings. The rising and fading of discomfort was tormenting but it was the only thing reminding her she was still here and not something that the world had finally rid itself of.

It was obvious that Adora didn't want to leave her side. She wished that he had done less of a number on her face so she could stare directly into her eyes without her looking back with that pitiful gaze. She wanted to scream and asked if she could finally see it now.

Adora would always be blind to the terrible things Catra held in her core. Now that that ugliness was worn across her face, she hated that Adora still clung to her faith that she was a victim.

Down to her center she could understand what she was now. She was worthless. There was nothing that could be done to rid her or anyone around her of the damage that she was just natural at inflicting.

She couldn't do the things that the others could. It had been too much and she had crossed too many lines for redemption to ever be a realistic possibility.

The entire idea of joining them on their venture to Brimeda was just the final crash and burn in every delusion that she had of being something more. She couldn't say it to Adora now so she sat in silence. The small motion of elevation made her stomach flutter before her automatic tensing washed her in another pang of ache.

"Are we in the air?" Catra managed to ask, her lips not cooperating to form her words with the clarity she wanted. The

sound of her own semi-muffled vocals revolted her.

"We're going home".

Adding more to her list of wrongdoing, a glimpse of purple hair entered the room with a small tray of new supplies to tend to Catra's wounds. Entrapta mumbled something to Adora, hanging a new bag of liquid in place of her old one before she began instructing her on the best method for changing out the already saturated bandages around the edges of Catra's head.

She remained as still as a mannequin - without wincing or pulling away as they cleaned her up for what must have been a second or third time. She knew that before she had lost consciousness, there had been much more blood than what she could make out without seeing her own reflection. She-Ra must have used her healing at some point when they got her aboard the ship, which made her wonder how badly the damage had been. Her body still hurried to form the remaining scabs to begin the healing process on itself.

Her bones ached and the new medication began to kick in after Entrapta administered it. A wave of relief soothed all of the pained pressure on her person, making her sink into the bed again. She was in between if she was tired or just wanted to close her eyes and pretend to rest so Adora would feel better about having to walk out of the room if the need arose.

Small parts of their doorway conversation flowed into her but were dismissed. She had no fight in her to try and overhear

anything.

Catra just sat in her emptiness with her eyes closed, hoping to drift away.

At some point in between her soft sniffles and struggled movements to seek some comfort, she did fall back asleep. There were no dreams or refreshing feeling from the memory foam hold of a medically assisted rest.

Every time she returned to the world, she felt less and less like a real person. The void feeling in her echoed inside and a bland expression lay hidden under her damaged outside. They brought her food and offered drinks, which she would receive without a word but left them untouched.

She wanted the window open to see where they were, but it didn’t matter. Whether they were near Bright Moon, the Crimson Wastes, or anywhere else on Etheria she knew nothing would offer the relief of a welcomed embrace.

Catra receded further. Hours where she was awake could hae been mistaken for her being sedated with her eyes open. She didn’t speak and hardly reacted to any of her teammates who made their rounds to check on her.

Entrapta came in once on her own and attempted to ask her how she was feeling. With no response given, she tapped something

down on the data pad before seeming to understand and push no further. She promptly left the room after.

Adora came in again, bringing another water that she wouldn't drink and smaller portions of sliced bread to coax her into eating with something a little more basic than her previous offerings. She listened to her words but it was like smoke blowing around her, with nothing clinging or actually sinking into her.

"Glimmer wanted to check in on you, but I told her you're resting and maybe once we get back…".

She looked like she was stuck in a trance, remaining still while she was being talked at. Once her attempts failed, Adora looked downtrodden but gave a sad, understanding leave.

"I can leave you alone if you want. I'll be back before we land." she promised.

Time went by in a way that was undecipherable. In her mind it felt like eternity while everything happening around her on the ship was moving at a breakneck pace. She wasn't sure how long after Adora left that Melog came jaunting in before catching a glimpse of her and rushing up carefully onto the bed with her. He sniffed, nudged, and took in the condition she was in. Several steps behind Melog, Bow trailed in.

The firm press of his snout against her hand prodded her to move. She did nothing. Her eyes didn't look to meet Bow's but she did look at the floor around him in a catatonic manner.

She wasn't trying to make him feel worse, but she could tell that just seeing her was difficult for him. He crossed his arms, steeling himself at the wall near the door before moving a step closer to her bedside.

His hand moved up to cover his mouth, caging his words before he even had a chance to say them.

His voice was already emotional. "Catra…I didn't know that he would- I'm so sorry." Hearing him carry all the weight of the guilt should have felt like a pile being stacked on her but Catra felt nothing in her stone cold bones. She only listened to him.

"We turned him over to the King's Guard, but I'm going to make sure action is taken against what he did." Bow offered details that she didn't care to know. "I shouldn't have left you in there alone…".

She knew what he wanted to hear. Fully aware that it was her turn to downplay it, assure him it wasn't his fault and that she knew he had seen the optimism on her face at her flourishing on her own and being the new consoling touch that she never had the chance to be for anyone before.

She looked away from him.

“I get it if you’re mad at me, I just wanted you to know how sorry I am.” the end of his sentence cracked slightly. He had such a compassionate heart.

The feline stretched across the foot of her bed lowered their head onto the blanket that concealed her legs underneath. He longed for a reaction from her. The previously dancing flames around their neck died down into a small light.

She wanted to drop her exact thoughts bluntly onto him.

"I wish you would have let him."

Her sentence remained locked inside, rotting away somewhere near her heart. The thought of causing harm to her own body was not a new thought. It pawed at her more than she wished it would and in her moments alone the thought of falling from severe heights or sinking to the bottom of the ocean seemed effortless - like it could be the next natural step for her.

Bow nodded at the dry silence.

"I'll let you get back to resting." his fluctuating emotions fought to raise a crack in his voice. Catra stayed still, not bothering to watch him leave.

"You shouldn't have stopped him."

Sinking back into the pain felt like gravity was pulling her into the grave but she didn't fear it. Her frail frame inside the medical gown remained seated upright in a sharp ninety degree position. The only thing that could indicate that she wasn't planning to run was when the thin openings of her eyes closed entirely. It looked as though she was in a meditative state.

Eventually the time came where she had to use the bathroom.

A small private bathroom was offered with its door open in the corner of the room. Getting off of the bed and shuffling the short distance with her wheeled pole of wires and equipment with her wasn't too bad. Her stomach and back ached as she began to step, making her pause and change her movements to continue her route more comfortably.

Once she completed the painful walk, she brushed her hand against the wall to activate the bright light of the restroom. Her instinct to squint at the blinding rays made her face radiate and ache sharply. When her eyes did what they could to open, she caught her reflection above the small circular sink.

It felt like the wind was knocked out of her again. The feeling of her throat tightening was a terrible pairing with the evidence of what had been the result from the last time she had an ache in that part of her body. She looked like she had been through hell,

it would have been impossible to try and play it off even if she had actually wanted to try that angle.

Before she had a chance to close the door or tear herself away from her horrid reflection, Adora had returned.

"We're getting close," Adora said in a low voice, looking at the empty bed in a slight panic before peering around to see Catra in the private bathroom in front of the mirror.

Catra didn't look at her. Adora felt her shoulders pull slightly downward, unable to imagine what was going through her best friend's mind as she stared at what was done to her.

"...and then?" the crackled feel of her dry throat croaked out. If it weren't for the equipment keeping her hydrated, she would have lacked the drive to sustain herself.

An uncomfortable husk formed itself in the air around them. Adora's mouth opened once before closing and rehashing her words. Catra could only look at the feet of the hero's reflection in the mirror. She folded her arms against herself in the doorway. Even in clear discomfort, Adora knew how to keep an air of confidence.

"We get you taken care of." she said simply. The response was not enough for Catra and both of them knew that wasn't what she was asking in the first place. The quiet standoff was enough to

make Adora continue. “We have all the information we need right now and can make adjustments to the plan after we meet with everyone and fill them in.”

Catra dropped her head in a miniscule single nod. She was in limbo. Waiting to be shouted at, while fearing it at the same time. She knew that Adora would never lay into her about being attacked - unless she was being reckless which was known to happen. She waited for Shadow Weaver or anyone who would come along and berate her into confirmation in her deep seeded belief that this whole thing was entirely her fault.

Someone should be tearing her apart for how foolish she was to think she would be anything more than what she was.

“What information do you have?” she asked, no longer including herself in the team.

Adora didn’t catch the omission. “We know that something is spreading from the clones biologically. Maybe contaminating the air or water.” Adora theorized “It has the capability to sort of… infect others.” she sounded uncertain even after seeing the sights first hand.

“Why hasn’t it done this anywhere else?” Catra frowned. The crease between her brows deepened enough to agitate her facial muscles.

"Could have been a higher concentration of bodies left in a single area. They're not- um, not chipped or anything."

A cold chill sprung from her cheeks then around and down her neck. The metal prongs of her own device dug into the back of her neck was one she didn't like to think about for too long. It was a positive though, at least they weren't being mind controlled.

All Catra could picture was the eerie glow of the fluorescent green pool Horde Prime had submerged Hordak in before trying to rip every shred of himself from him through a reconditioning wipe. The pull down for her now felt the same, Catra was soon to be stripped of her own rights to attend meetings and assist in missions but it would be framed in a way to prevent harm from befalling her. Her friends and teammates would do it and say it was because they cared about her.

Is this what Hordak felt like when he stepped into that plasma?

Knowing that the moment they landed, it would be back to being on some form of house arrest made her begin to feel jumpy. Adora would insist that she take her time and rest back in the safety of the castle. She would probably do her best to hang around more for a few weeks until she would have her own duties to attend to, then it would be just like before. Catra would be a bird in a cage, locked away and perpetually waiting.

Don't do this.

It seemed to occur to Adora that Catra was in the restroom and probably for good reason. “Do you need help?” she asked, already crooking her arms to help move her to wherever it was she wanted to go.

“No.” Catra said curtly. “I got it.”

Adora knew better than to push. The creases at the edges of her eyes tightened slightly, looking like she would tear up if she didn’t step out. Catra didn’t want to snap at her, but by this point Adora knew who she was. She was a bad person and didn’t deserve help or kindness. It felt better to turn it away on her own decision than to have someone give that affection and they take it away.

“I’ll see you in a bit…love you.” Adora held her hand onto the frame of the doorway, slowly letting her fingers release as she pulled herself away and gave her goodbye.

She used the restroom, then moved herself raggedly back to her bed until the smooth feeling of descent cued her in that they had finally arrived and were landing. In both the bathroom and the open counters of the medical wing, she scanned and noticed a lack of any instruments being left out.

Once they had extended the landing gear and a few moments had passed, Entrapta had come in but found an already standing Catra searching for her clothes in the cupboards lining the side of her room.

“Oh. Transport to the medical suite in the Bright Moon castle doesn’t require you to stand.” she informed, as if she entirely believed the information would be helpful.

“I can walk.” she insisted. *He didn’t focus on my legs…*

Entrapta let a groan sound off in her throat. “Adora and Glimmer insisted that we follow protocol until we get you fully evaluated.”

“Just get these fucking things off and out of me!” Catra screeched. After her outburst her eyes looked wild. Entrapta shrunk, gripping onto her data pad with fear in her eyes.

“O-okay.” she agreed. Catra continued to huff, hot tears threatening to spill over and only making her feel the familiar rage that she had done so much to push away. Once the last needle was pulled from her skin, she roughly brushed past the scientist and left the room.

She had no intention of going to the medical suite, or royal physician, or wherever else they had already predetermined was best for her. Her torn and battered face was going to be hidden away in her room for as long as she could physically manage. Not out of embarrassment for her appearance, but for the shame of what it represented and all the wrong she had done.

Still adorn in the ridiculous looking hospital gown, Catra moved as quickly as she could down the hall to where her room was. Melog followed as if they were her shadow, gentling chirruping to try and pull her attention from her fierce stalk towards where she knew her bag was. While the far off voices of the others down the hall echoed, she moved purposefully to enter her room and get dressed before trying to vacate the ship before Adora tried to carry her.

In her room she tore a long sleeve shirt and full length leggings from her bag, she would put anything on as long as it made her feel more contained. Her skin buzzed and head hurt from a pulsing migraine as she wiped a little too aggressively at the water droplets streaming down her face. Once her clothes were changed, it would be a short path to sneak past everyone and back up to where she knew she could hole up without being bothered.

Except that it wasn't being bothered. It was just them showing that they were concerned for her. She had wished for something to that tune her whole life and here she was shoving it away just like she did with everything good in her life. If there was an opportunity to squander a talent, relationship, or anything remotely positive, she would do it.

She scratched at the draw strings on the back of her gown, scraping her skin in the process while working in too much frustration. Once she had scrambled out of the outfit, she left it discarded on the floor. The moment the new clothes were on, she was already pulling her bag on to her back and peered down the hall with Melog in tow.

Looking left and then right, the coast was clear. The sound of Bow reading off a checklist on shut downs for the vessel made her more at ease with moving when she knew they would be too busy to catch her. She hadn't heard Entrapta's voice in the low muffle but it was only a matter of time before she joined and told Adora about her refusal.

Silently, she moved down the stretch of the corridor. Catra knew she was in no condition to dash or move with as much agility as she would typically have. Veering right to where the exit ramp was, she let out a breath.

It was still shut. They hadn't open the hatch yet and the moment she hit the switch, they would know it was her.

It didn't matter.

Without a second to think, she pressed the release and let the loud metal disengage to lower the ramp. Over the clanging and groaning of the mechanisms, she heard their conversations stop abruptly but couldn't make out anything else. Disinterested in waiting for the entire platform to lower to the proper degree, Catra crouched down and moved out once there was enough room to do that. She repositioned her bag, slinging it back on after it had slid from her shoulder.

The landing pad was well organized with other spaces nearby for ships that she walked briskly too, taking a pause only to ease the pain in her ribs when the movement was too much.

When she had passed one, then two ships and walked around their sides she knew she had enough cover to make a clean getaway.

Until Melog's head whipped around.

"Catra!"

Can't ever leave well enough alone.

"Stop!"

Her legs kept moving until she was to the cement stairwell and grabbing the handrail. She couldn't see Adora yet, but knew she was nearing from the proximity of her voice.

Once they were in the hold of the stairwell, she looked at Melog with pleading eyes. They looked back with cerulean eyes shining. Instantly understanding and with a shimmer around them, cast them to both be imperceptible. Each step she took was now with a different goal - silence, not speed.

Adora’s voice called out over and over, sounding more desperate.

“Catra!” she cried again, her voice now creating guilt born goosebumps on Catra’s arms. “Please, I just need to know that you’re okay...” she called out before facing into the tower that held the stairs.

Melog and Catra were already several levels down, both moving fluidly enough to keep from making any noise.

“I- I’m sorry, I should have been there. I should have been with you-” she floundered in her words.

Catra stopped mid-step, holding onto the rail and looking upwards while Melog paused to do the same. She grimaced at Adora’s words, knowing that she should keep moving.

“We have to have a doctor check you out. We only had limited supplies with us and I have to know that you’re not hurt.” she sounded like a lost duckling crying out in hopes that its mother would hear.

Adora moved her head around in a scan of the area, biting at the inner parts of her lip as she breathed in and out of her nose in anxiousness.

“Yes Adora, yes I’m hurt” she replied in a normal speaking voice. While Adora couldn’t make out the words, she whipped back and peered over her own platform railings to look for Catra.

“Catra, wait! I’ll come down there, just hang on-”

“Stop Adora, you just- you never know when to stop!” the invisibility washed off the two of them, still with Adora being too far away to see her. “Yeah I’m hurt. I’ll go to the doctor but you know what? They can’t fix everything.”

Adora moved in a rushed pace down the stairs, glancing over to check how close she was. Catra hadn’t gotten nearly the head start she thought she did. Adora’s face lightened when she finally set her eyes on Catra and she closed in on her flight.

“I know that, I’m not expecting them to. We just have to make sure you’re fine is all.”

“I’m *not*!” Catra ran her hands from her temples before throwing them out. “I try to be, but I’m not. Not when you leave, not when I try to be good like you, I’m not fine!”

Adora was finally within a few paces of Catra but kept her distance after the outburst.

“I’ll be here with you this time.” she said, a promise lingering on her lips. Catra could see the look of hesitation on Adora’s face. She was walking up to a grenade with the pin pulled.

Catra laughed, waving a hand. “*This* time. But Adora, what about next time, and the next time. Then all the other times after that?” she rambled. “I can’t keep making you tear yourself down to meet me where I’m at.”

A look of confusion spread across Adora’s face. She was trying to figure out what kind of battle she was fighting but it was a new argument she didn’t have experience with.

“Nothing you do tears me down - or anyone else. You said you wanted to do better and you *have* been. That's all I want to do is be there for you in this.” she calmly retorted. Catra didn’t want to egg her on into a blow to blow fight of insults. She only wanted Adora to open her eyes and see the huge blind spot she had when it came to her.

A pause held steady between them.

Catra looked down before steadying herself. “You are there for me. You always have been.” she admitted softly, creating a small smile on Adora’s face. Her two toned eyes looked up sadly to meet hers. “That’s why I can’t let you do this to yourself over me.”

“What are you talking about?”

“I can’t *be* better, okay?” her voice began to raise and break. Melog refused to sit and remained ready at her side. “I’m never going to be. When I said- when I thought that, it was just me lying to you and to myself, alright? I can’t do it.” tears were falling, shimmering streaks left her eyes to drop to the concrete.

“Don’t say that” Adora’s voice was quiet.

“I can’t be the thing that brings you down like I do to everything else. When you go-” she choked up before pushing through “When you go back in that castle, I want you to leave me alone.”

“You don’t mean it…”

“I’ve never meant anything more in my life.” she assured, slicing at her with her words. “I’ll get checked by whatever people you want me to, then I’ll figure out the next part.”

Adora’s head snapped back up. “Next part? Catra, we can get through this. Like we always have…”

Catra squeezed her eyes shut and shook her head. “It’s not fair to you, I don’t want you caring for the world and then having to work double to take care of my bullshit on top of it. I won’t be part of the reason why you work yourself to death.”

Adora stopped again. Racking her brain for anything to pull that might change Catra's mind. "You're the only thing that makes it worth it" the strings on her heart pulled. It felt like someone had pierced it with a hook and was twisting it out of her chest. Tears welled in Adora's eyes as she fought the notion of where the conversation was heading.

"I'm never going to fit into this picture you have" Catra motioned around them as if to gesture at Bright Moon. "I thought if I tried hard enough I could but it doesn't work like that."

The expression on Adora's face was one of loss and grief, she looked like a piece of herself was being broken off.

"I need you Catra" she begged, pain reverberating in her tone.

Catra nodded, fighting the urge to let a sob overtake her. "You're my best friend Adora. It's why I can't do this to you anymore." she breathed again "I just need space."

Adora's eyes were already pink, marked with the downturn of her eyebrows when she looked at Catra who was incapable of meeting her gaze.

"Okay."

Catra continued on while Adora stayed frozen in time. Her muscles didn't seem to know how to move anymore and a hole had been carved out where her heart had been. She had sworn to herself that she had seen Catra walk away from her too many times before and that after she had run off after hearing Shadow Weaver's words, that it would be the last time she let her go.

Going back on her word now, she couldn't bring herself to watch her go again. She couldn't understand how she was able to do this to her again but tried to put on the bravest face she could and be the support she needed.

If Catra needed time, Adora would patiently try to outwait the clock.

Chapter Twelve

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first few days were precarious, like stepping around delicate eggshells and trying her best to carry on as if nothing had changed. Catra remained in the hold of her room most hours of the day but didn't close the curtains and hide away in bed all hours like a small part of her wanted to. Her wounds began to heal, pulling the gashes back together and changing the colors of her battered body from strange shades of black, to purple, then morphing to a slight yellow tone.

Adora didn't visit.

If she did, she didn't knock or show her face.

For as easy as it all felt, Catra almost felt pride from the heaping emptiness in her chest. She didn't go running back and she didn't cry her eyes out like she was lost without her. It felt like a twisted form of success.

She went to her medical appointments her second day back and was formally diagnosed and scans to further check how everything was doing internally.

Some light fractures, little bit of evidence from hemorrhaging, and lots of ecchymosis that was clearly visible to anyone who saw her. She sat there in mostly silence, answering the questions of the medical professionals in short, polite replies.

Catra was surprised that Adora didn’t show up at these appointments. She didn’t want her there but she had to have been aware of them because she had been the person who had set them up.

The physician's advice was to rest, make sure she continues to eat and drink, and take medicine as needed for any pain. In the gray-white of their spotless office, they looked at her with sorrow when they thought she wouldn’t notice.

“Here are some resources for you to reach out to if you feel the need.” the female doctor’s voice was soothing as she set two pamphlets on the counter beside them. One had a picture of a woman looking out a window and was undoubtedly about mental health or information about how to spot depression.

“Thanks.” Catra said. It was all she could muster before checking out, obtaining her medications and starting back towards the safety of her room.

All things considered, she felt oddly proud of herself. The brunette didn’t feel much of anything anymore but that was something she was relieved of. The scarring anger within her that was always clawing to get out to unleash upon friends, enemies, or simple

acquaintances was notably absent and she felt…nothing. As if she was a light husk in a host's body.

In the face of others, she appeared more agreeable. Her constant drive to confront or challenge was entirely wiped from her in the rare moments where she did speak to anyone. While she agreed with the nurses that she would do her best to take care of herself, she knew that old habits were the most difficult to break. She decided now was not the time.

She nearly promised herself that she would try to make it down for dinner, at least after everyone else had cleared out and she could grab a small plate in solitude. After she couldn't convince her body to move when the time came, eventually a portion of the meal was brought up to her. Catra thanked the staff member and would take a couple bites before abandoning the meal on her night stand.

In her mind, she was still doing the right thing.

When the contusions on her muscles began to feel a little overwhelming, she would use her medicine just as the doctor had recommended.

Except for the warning that it should be taken without alcohol.

She convinced herself that it was still within the parameters of following the instructions because she hadn't drank that much in

the hours before she had taken it. The lightness of her detachment, the floating that the medicine made her skin feel, and the considerable amount of drinks she had continued to sneak during the day made her feel good - like she was basking in the waves of a beach as she bobbed in and out of the plans her mind was trying to make.

She had *almost* followed the rules by resting - which she did. She had also used the moments of clarity before her medicine kicked in to begin packing up her room.

Catra wasn't clueless, she would only pack small sections each day. If she had done everything in one go, word would have gotten to Glimmer or Adora that she was planning to leave and that was something she didn't want to risk. There wasn't enough to pack to make it notable when she got to the end anyway.

By the third day, Glimmer had knocked on her door to check in. Catra was surprised she had held out that long.

In the mid-morning hours, Catra opened the door. Glimmer looked surprised that her friend had been awake, much less dressed and looking nearly back to normal.

"Hey Catra," she quickly glanced up and down her body in the doorway, "I was just checking in on you to see how everything is."

Catra stood for a moment, silently staring at her to work out what it was exactly that she wanted to know. Her injuries, her mental state, or Adora? What did Glimmer already know about?

As much as she hated how easy it was to open up to Glimmer, she didn't this morning.

“Had my first check up a few days ago. The damage wasn’t as bad as it looked so they just gave me some meds and told me to take it easy.”

Which I’m trying to do right now.

Glimmer nodded, smiling but not seeming satisfied with the answer. Her color swirled eyes looked beyond Catra and towards the room as if she wished to be invited in. That was something Catra wasn’t willing to do.

“That’s good news! Right, absolutely no pressure. We just miss seeing you around and wanted to double check if you needed anything." The chipper musical tone of her voice felt forced. Catra wondered how much she was trying to pull from her approach. If she could put on an act, then so could Catra.

She mustered the smallest piece of herself to feign a half-smile. “All good here.” she breathed, panning the small space of the open door with her arm and letting it tap back against her side to display her interpretation of a relaxed person.

Glimmer held herself up but the near imperceptible dull in the sparkle of her eyes was enough to show that the apparent good spirits was something she had not expected. The queen looked disappointed that her friend didn't seem in worse condition emotionally than what she had imagined in her mind.

The gold and blue of Catra's eyes looked at Glimmer from her shoulders down to her feet, waiting for her to try and slip more confessions of more detrimental feelings. She was almost sorry to disappoint.

She knew Glimmer was very loyal to Adora and would always do what she could in her favor. Catra admired that quality in her.

"Maybe if you're feeling up to it later this week, we can all get brunch. It's been a while since I've had a gap in meetings long enough to actually enjoy my meals when the sun is up." The slight dishonesty was easy to pluck out. All of her words were genuine but her reasons for suggesting them were undoubtedly driven by her want to help her friend's work out whatever it was she had heard that they were going through.

Catra shook her head in disagreement but her words tumbled out against her own wants. "Yeah, we'll see." she agreed flippantly. She couldn't slam the door in Glimmer's face literally or figuratively.

The Queen of Brightmoon still had a flat look of displeasure adorning her face. It was somber, like she was silently hoping that

through sheer force of will that the floodgates would open and Catra would let herself be vulnerable with her.

Catra blinked several times to banish any tears that had tried to group in the corners of her eyes.

"Catra, you know it's okay if things are hard right now. You can talk to me whenever or if you ever feel like it." Glimmer's softness was welcomed but the thought of Bow confiding all of his worries in her and that being her motivator for being at her door in the first place made her step away from the precipice of pouring her feelings out to her friend. Her heart shaped face and the way she could tune herself into the emotions of others was a dangerous combination for someone who just wanted to hide away in the depths of their own mind.

In the end, Catra knew she was only here at the request of Adora and Bow - even if they hadn't directly asked her to do it. She was caring enough to take it upon herself.

Feeling a little more untethered, Catra couldn't stop her eyes from looking to the floor and molding themselves there, looking like she had disengaged from the conversation. "I just need a bit longer…" Catra explained quietly.

Glimmer nodded, slightly in glee that Catra had even given her that. "Of course," she turned from the door and just before Catra closed it, Glimmer left her with one last statement: "we all care about you and are rooting for you."

She abruptly paused, leaving the door ajar before gently closing it with an eased click. The drive of her plan was cleared like the board of a classroom. Trying to make sense of anything anyone did anymore felt like playing advanced chess and she was a novice just trying to survive.

...Rooting for you…

How could she root for someone who had just broken her best friend's heart?

The same person her fiancé guilted into taking on all the blame of a mission gone terribly off the rails?

Glimmer knew who she was when she was Horde Captain. She had openly hated her and it made sense. Their small level of connection outside the holding cell of Prime's ship was just a weak moment in her resolve. Catra had been thankful for that gap in her armor because her words had moved her to do something to make her life meaningful in some small way again.

Catra could only stand in the silence of her still room. She moved her mind from obsessing over the words of the Queen to thinking about nothing. She stood long enough that her knees began to complain at the feeling of being locked for so long, finally urging her to move or take a seat.

She began to pack again. In under an hour she had everything of hers stowed into two separate canvas bags. If she didn't leave tonight, she wasn't sure if she ever would. Glimmer would converse with Adora who would certainly come to check on her in the next day or two, and Catra still wasn't ready to face her.

The only option for her was to be the coward she knew she was and run.

She would willingly free herself from Adora. She- Ra could soar to new heights in her campaigns to help the world and she wouldn't have the constant rot of Catra's stained image to hold her back. She wouldn't worry about having to take breaks to come home after months of being off continent or off the planet - Catra would set her free.

She just couldn't look her in the eyes to say all of that to her again.

Catra loved her so much it ached the muscles around her heart. For the longest time she didn't even know it was love that she was feeling, she had grown to think she wasn't capable of giving or receiving love because she was just a barbaric animal.

In a way, those points were correct. While she knew that she could love and she had people who said that they loved her, she wasn't able to maintain it. The intricate work to keep herself and someone she cared so deeply about content was an overload of weight that she had never heard anyone describe love like. It

wasn’t fair to Adora and Catra knew that she deserved to have everything.

Her long fingers rubbed down the edges of her hairline by her temple, a habit she still held onto from brushing her bushel of hair out of her face when it was long. The room was entirely vacated and looked as if it had been an empty guest bedroom for a long time with no signs of life other than herself and Melog.

She carefully closed the french doors of the balcony before untying the wispy curtains and letting their sheer fabric fall in front to mask the doors.

Catra stood like a phantom, ready to dissipate away from the place she had been haunting for too long. It could be so easy to just walk down the ornate halls and knock on Adora’s door to tell her what she was feeling and let her convince her to stay, with the coax of her strong grasp and heavy heart trying to hold her into place like an anchor.

It wasn’t going to happen this time. She wouldn’t go crawling to beg the woman who had already given her so much to beg her to give more by temporary helping her fix herself. It was time to go, even if she wasn’t sure where her significantly unbound mind would drag her off to. She gave a short click to Melog to lead them along and out of the room, noiselessly closing the door behind her.

A small paper lay on the bed, with only two words scrawled onto them:

I’m sorry.

Chapter End Notes

I'll continue the story on when I have a bigger portion of it started and it will pick up where this one left off. I'll either add on to this one or post it as a separate story. Little bit of a hiatus for now because of life. Thank you all for the kudos and subscriptions :)

End Notes

I've been wanting to get back into writing for a bit now. The dynamic between Catra and Adora is really interesting so this is me experimenting with that through story.

Hope you enjoy ;)
I'll do my best to update regularly.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!